

FISH TANK VALIDATION RANTS

A chaotic live-show comedy
of approval-seeking.



12matt3r

Introduction

Fish Tank Validation Rants is organised into focused chapters, each designed to stand on its own. Read cover-to-cover or jump to whatever catches your eye first.



Table of Contents

Chapter 1 The Fishy Portal Won't Open

Chapter 2 Jet Smiles, Then His Mic Cuts

Chapter 3 The Wrong Button Gets Pressed

Chapter 4 Under-18 ID Request Pops Up

Chapter 5 The Crocs Sandwich Incident

Chapter 6 Google Assistant Refuses to Rap

Chapter 7 The Aquacadabra Rule Gets Misquoted

Chapter 8 The People's Court Harassment Loop

Chapter 9 He Tries to Leave, Gets Rejected

Chapter 10 The Four Nonsies Curse

Chapter 11 The Wet Market TTS Token Mishap

Chapter 12 Why Is Craig Back Again?

Chapter 13 The Wrong Song Bass Booms

Chapter 14 The Discord Normies Overwhelm

Chapter 15 He Falls, Can't Get Up

Chapter 16 The ADD Forgets the Button

Chapter 17 The Website Pitch Gets Trolled

Chapter 18 The Public Approval Round of Applause

Chapter 19 He Finally Gets on the Fish Tank

Chapter 20 Poop in a Bucket, Portal Approved



CHAPTER 1



The Fishy Portal Won't Open

The shelf was too narrow for a man with a dream and three unpaid parking tickets.

I sat sideways on it inside the fishtank.live lobby, one sneaker dangling over the edge, the other wedged against a plastic storage bin labeled WINTER CABLES. The shelf smelled like dust, hot electronics, and the faint oceanic funk of a fish store that had never actually contained a fish. A blue portal shimmered across the room, six feet wide, perfectly round, and absolutely uninterested in me.

I had been waiting there long enough for my left leg to become a separate political party.

"My name is TJ Birds," I told the camera. "You're watching Goddamn Let's Kill Somebody. Goddamn it. Let's kill somebody. Let's kill somebody."

The lobby microphone returned a soft electronic burp.

"Good," I said. "Professional."

On the monitor, my application floated beneath the portal in a gray box:

PENDING.

Not rejected. Not accepted. Pending. The bureaucratic purgatory of the fish tank. My face appeared in the preview window, slightly green from the portal light, with a strand of hair stuck to my forehead. I looked like a handsome hostage being held by a screensaver.

"I'm going live on fishtank.live 247," I said, leaning toward the lens. "Come say what's up, squad. Look for the Jurgenator. Or the Jerkinator. Either spelling. The fish know who I am."

A notification chimed.

I slapped the approval button.

The screen changed.

PENDING.

"That was not a button," I said.

It had been a decorative button. A little fish icon wearing sunglasses. I had pressed its stomach, and it had responded by playing a six-second sound effect of a toilet flushing.

From somewhere beyond the portal came a muffled voice. "Who is this?"

I straightened on the shelf.

"That," I whispered, "is the sound of opportunity."

I climbed down too fast, caught my heel on the storage bin, and kicked a coil of extension cord across the floor. It struck the portal's base with a wet plastic slap. The blue circle flickered.

The lobby went dark.

Then the emergency lights came on, bathing everything in red. My face on the monitor looked like it had just been accused of stealing a horse.

"Okay," I said. "Minor technical issue. Nobody panic. I am still beautiful."

The portal returned, now half its original size.

"Why did you make it smaller?" I asked the room.

A robotic voice answered from the ceiling. "Applicant posture unstable."

"My posture is artistic."

"Applicant has not been approved."

"I know that. I'm trying to get approved."

"Please remain available."

"I have been available for forty-seven minutes."

"Please remain available."

I looked into the camera. "This is what they do to the little fishy. They put him on a shelf and tell him to remain available. I'm out here wishing somebody could open that fishy portal."

The portal pulsed.

I took one careful step toward it.

"Do not approach the portal," said the ceiling.

"I'm not approaching. I'm emotionally approaching."

"Applicant distance violation."

The gray box on the monitor changed from PENDING to PENDING WITH CONCERNS.

"Pending with concerns?" I said. "What concerns? My talent? My aura? The fact I'm sitting beside winter cables like a divorced electrician?"

A new message appeared.

PLEASE PROVIDE EVIDENCE OF COOLNESS.

I stared at it.

The lobby fan rattled overhead. Somewhere behind the walls, water gurgled through a pipe, though no one had ever explained where the water went. The portal made a tiny bubbling noise, like it was trying not to laugh.

"Evidence of coolness," I repeated.

I reached into my jacket and pulled out a pair of sunglasses.

The lenses were cracked down the middle.

I put them on anyway.

"Observe," I said. "Cool."

The camera focused. The monitor displayed my face in two separate halves, one eye pointed toward the portal and the other pointed toward a vending machine.

The system chimed.

COOLNESS EVIDENCE INCONCLUSIVE.

"Run it again."

I pressed the approval button.

The screen opened a text-to-speech menu.

I meant to type, APPROVE TJ BIRDS, BUT MY FINGERS MOVED faster than my brain, which is how I ended up sending:

APPROVE FISH BIRDS JERK SOFA PORTAL WET MAN.

The lobby speakers announced it in a cheerful woman's voice.

"Approve fish birds jerk sofa portal wet man."

Silence.

Then the portal shrank another inch.

"No, no, no. That was not my request. My request was normal. My request was dignified."

The speakers repeated, "Wet man."

"Stop saying wet man."

"Wet man."

I slapped the keyboard. The text box filled with symbols, fish emojis, and the word CHICKEN repeated eleven times.

The portal began rotating backward.

"Hold on. I have ADD," I said. "The controls are too close together. Who designed this, a raccoon with a touchscreen?"

A small camera mounted above the monitor swiveled toward me.

"Applicant self-identifies as unstable."

"Applicant self-identifies as entertaining."

"Applicant self-identifies as wet man."

"That was the machine!"

The portal emitted a low hum. Its surface turned from blue to a bright, aquatic green. For one beautiful second, I saw the other side: the fish tank stream room, the main camera, a row of chairs, and Jet standing beneath a light that made his face look unfairly excellent.

I pointed at the opening.

"Look at Jet's face. It's beautiful. You look great, Jet."

Jet turned toward the sound.

"Thanks, I - "

His microphone dropped off its stand.

It hit the floor with a hard clack.

Jet's mouth kept moving, but the portal swallowed the rest of his sentence. The only sound that came through was a faint burst of static followed by what sounded like a duck stepping on a keyboard.

The portal snapped shut.

I stood there with one hand raised, compliment suspended in the air like a bad balloon.

"Jet?" I said.

Nothing.

"Jet, you look great."

The ceiling voice said, "Compliment delivery failed."

"I know it failed."

"Would you like to retry?"

"Yes."

The menu appeared.

I pressed RETRY.

The speakers announced, "Jet, you look grate."

I froze.

"Grate?"

"Jet, you look grate," the speakers repeated.

"That is not what I said."

The system added, "Jet, handsome man looking like a Squirtle."

I covered my face.

The portal reappeared, but now it was the size of a dinner plate. Through it, I could see one of Jet's eyes. He was staring directly at me.

"Open the portal!" I shouted.

The speakers turned my voice into a bass-heavy echo.

"Open the portal! Portal! Portal! Portal!"

The fish tank stream lobby shook. A cup of cold coffee slid off the shelf and spilled into my lap.

I jumped.

The portal expanded.

For half a second, I thought the coffee had validated me.

Then the system announced, "Applicant fluid event detected."

"It's coffee!"

"Fluid event detected."

"It's not a fish thing!"

"Fish thing pending."

The portal widened to the size of a refrigerator. Wind blasted through the lobby, carrying the smell of chlorine, wet carpet, and somebody's aggressively seasoned chicken. My cracked sunglasses flew off my face and vanished into the green light.

I lunged after them.

The portal slammed shut.

My hand hit the wall.

The monitor flashed:

COOLNESS SCORE: 2%.

I looked at the camera.

"Two percent?"

The ceiling voice said, "Applicant is currently sitting in coffee."

"I'm not sitting in coffee. I'm standing in coffee."

"Correction accepted. Coolness score unchanged."

That was the moment dignity left my body. It did not storm out. It did not make a speech. It simply packed a little suitcase, looked at my wet pants, and moved to another stream.

I grabbed the microphone.

"Fine," I said. "If the fish tank won't let me in, the fish tank is going to hear me from outside."

The beat began in my headphones, a distorted club rhythm I had accidentally created by hitting three settings at once. The bass sounded like a washing machine falling

down stairs. The hi-hat sounded like a spoon trapped in a garbage disposal.

I nodded to it.

“Perfect.”

The camera zoomed in automatically.

I started rapping.

“I’m on the shelf, I’m waiting for the call, Portal looking tiny like a fish in a mall, TJ Birds in the lobby, Sofa at the door, Jurgenator knocking like a landlord with a sword.”

The portal flickered.

I pointed at it.

“Open up, fishy, let the little man through, I got a cracked pair of shades and a dream or two, You looking awful, portal, I’m looking fly, I’m a Squirtle with a Wi-Fi signal in the sky.”

The ceiling voice interrupted. “Applicant rhyme quality is disputed.”

“Don’t interrupt the artist.”

“Applicant has requested no interruption.”

“I did not request that.”

The text-to-speech menu opened again. My elbow bumped the keyboard.

The lobby speakers announced, “I did not request wet chicken.”

The beat cut out.

Then it returned twice as fast.

I tried to recover.

“Wet chicken in the club, got two kids in the back, Point and play, clap, somebody open the shack - ”

The portal made a violent popping sound.

A small plastic fish shot out of it and struck me in the forehead.

I caught it on the rebound.

It was a keycard.

The monitor changed.

APPROVAL GRANTED: TEMPORARY ACCESS.

I stared at the keycard. It was warm, slick, and stamped with my name in crooked black letters:

TJ BIRDS, MAYBE.

The portal opened.

This time it was enormous. Green light flooded the lobby. The wind lifted my shirt and plastered it against my stomach. My coffee-soaked pants dripped onto the floor. The camera zoomed in farther, capturing every detail: the wet crotch, the crooked hair, the plastic fish keycard, and the expression of a man who had finally been chosen by a door after begging it for an hour.

From the other side, a voice shouted, “Is that Sofa?”

I raised the keycard.

“It’s the Jurgenator!”

The portal beeped.

TEMPORARY ACCESS EXPIRES IN TEN SECONDS.

"Ten seconds?" I yelled. "I waited forty-seven minutes!"

"Nine seconds."

I ran.

My shoe squeaked with every step. The floor was slick with coffee. I hit the portal at full speed, bounced off the edge, spun sideways, and landed on the shelf again with the storage bin in my lap.

The keycard flew from my hand.

The portal counted down.

"Eight!"

I grabbed for it.

"Seven!"

My fingers closed around the extension cord.

"Six!"

I pulled.

The storage bin toppled. Winter cables erupted across the lobby like electronic spaghetti. One loop caught my ankle, another hooked the microphone stand, and the microphone swung through the air directly into the portal.

"Five!"

The portal swallowed the microphone.

"Four!"

I crawled across the floor.

"Three!"

The speakers said, "Sofa be pooping."

"I am not pooping!"

"Two!"

I found the keycard beneath the vending machine.

"One!"

I slapped it against the portal.

The portal shut.

The lobby went quiet except for the fan and my wet shoe.

The monitor displayed a new message:

ACCESS CONFIRMED. WAITING ROOM ACTIVATED.

I looked around.

The shelf lowered three inches.

A red sign lit up above it.

PUBLIC WAITING.

The camera pulled back, revealing my entire body, the coffee stain, the cables around my ankle, and the storage bin balanced on my shoulder like a plastic crown. A viewer counter appeared in the corner.

247 WATCHING.

Then 248.

Then 249.

A chat message slid across the screen.

IS THIS THE GUY WHO HAS BEEN WAITING?

Another appeared.

WHY IS HE WET?

I picked up the microphone, which had somehow returned covered in what looked like fish food.

"I got approved," I said.

The ceiling voice replied, "Temporary access."

"I got approved."

"Temporary access."

"I got attention."

The viewer counter jumped to 300.

A fresh message appeared.

NOT COOL ENOUGH LOL.

I read it twice.

Then I leaned toward the camera, trying to recover the handsome, dangerous posture I had possessed before the coffee and the public shelf.

"Under 18, please have your ID ready," I announced. "The fish tank live stream is about to go right now."

The portal remained closed.

Behind me, the vending machine began making a grinding noise. Its display blinked:

NEW CHALLENGE AVAILABLE.

I turned toward it.

The machine dropped a single orange object into the tray.

It was my missing sunglasses.

Both lenses were now gone.

CHAPTER 2

Jet Smiles, Then His Mic Cuts

The second missing lens was still on the floor when Jet appeared in the fish tank stream overlay, smiling like a man who had never been betrayed by eyewear.

I leaned toward the camera, one cracked lens hanging from my sunglasses frame, the other socket empty and accusing. The chat crawled up the side of the screen in green, white, and one alarming shade of fish-belly blue. Somewhere under the desk, my coffee had dried into a sticky brown continent. The approval button sat in the corner, glowing with the confidence of a button that had already ruined my life.

"I'm TJ Birds," I said, squinting at the overlay. "You're watching Goddamn Let's Kill Somebody. Goddamn it. Let's kill somebody. I'm going live on fishtank.live 247. Look for the Jurgenerator. Sofa is in the building."

Jet's video loaded with a tiny electronic cough.

I pointed at him. "Look at Jet's face."

Jet lifted a hand and said something.

The mic cut.

Not faded. Not crackled. Cut. His mouth kept moving while the audio vanished, leaving only the faint hum of his room and the greasy little whine of my computer fan. Jet froze halfway through a sentence with one eyebrow raised, like the universe had just interrupted him for being too interesting.

I leaned closer.

"You look great, Jet."

The compliment landed in perfect silence.

There it was. The friendliest sentence I had managed all night, floating in the chat like a balloon nobody wanted to touch. Jet nodded, or maybe he was trying to restart his microphone. His lips moved again.

Nothing.

"Jet, if you can hear me, blink twice."

He blinked once.

The chat immediately decided this meant something.

A message flashed by: JET IS GONE.

Another said: MIC DIFF.

A third simply read: SQUIRTLE.

I slapped the desk. The cracked sunglasses jumped, skittered across the wood, and dropped into the coffee continent.

"Don't panic," I said. "This is a professional fish tank live stream. Technical difficulties are part of the fish experience. We are not falling apart. We are becoming content."

Jet waved both hands at the camera.

"Exactly," I said. "He agrees."

He did not agree. His face had gone from handsome to hostage negotiator in under three seconds.

I clicked the audio settings. A box opened asking whether I wanted to route Jet's microphone through "Default," "Communications," or "Advanced Fish Audio." I chose Advanced Fish Audio because anything with the word advanced in it had to be useful.

The stream played a wet popping sound.

Jet's face vanished.

The chat accelerated.

"Okay," I said, "we have temporarily transformed Jet into a sound."

The screen showed a loading wheel shaped like a tiny silver fish. It spun, stopped, spun again, then displayed a red message: MODERATION TIMER STARTED: 09:59.

I stared at it.

"Why is there a timer?"

The number changed to 09:58.

Jet reappeared upside down.

His mouth moved. No sound.

"Jet, you're upside down."

He pointed downward, which somehow made it worse.

"I'm fixing it."

I dragged his video window toward the center. The overlay snapped it to the left, then resized my own camera until my forehead filled the broadcast. My remaining sunglasses lens reflected the entire interface. In the reflection, I looked like a tired insect trapped inside a casino.

The timer dropped to 09:31.

"Moderation timer," I said. "That is fine. That is a normal thing for people who are already approved. This is not a countdown to remove me. This is a countdown to appreciate me."

Jet's microphone made one noise: a low electronic fart.

His video tilted sideways again.

"See? He's speaking."

The chat disagreed loudly.

I clicked the approval tab. It opened the TTS panel. I clicked the TTS panel. It opened a donation form. I clicked the donation form. A robotic voice announced, "Sofa is pooping on the beat."

I slapped the mute button.

The voice continued.

"Damn, Sofa. Where did you find this poop?"

Jet's silent mouth opened wider.

"Stop saying poop," I told the computer.

The computer said poop three more times.

The moderation timer hit 08:47.

I tried to restore Jet's audio manually. The settings menu had a slider labeled MIC GAIN. I pushed it up. Jet's video produced a blast of static so thick it looked visible. My desk lamp flickered. The empty sunglasses socket vibrated against the coffee-stained wood.

I pulled the slider down.

Silence.

I pushed it up again.

A deep, distorted version of my own voice came through the stream.

"YOU LOOK GREAT, JET."

Then another delay answered from somewhere inside the software.

"YOU LOOK GREAT, JET."

Then another.

"YOU LOOK GREAT, JET."

The compliment multiplied until the stream sounded like a stadium full of haunted TJ Birds.

Jet covered his ears.

"I know!" I shouted. "I said it once!"

The computer repeated me.

"I know! I said it once!"

The chat filled with fish emojis. Somebody typed, "TJ is flirting with the router."

I looked at Jet. He was trying to explain himself with hand gestures now. First he pointed at his throat, then at the microphone icon, then at the ceiling. He looked like a mime trapped in a customer-service call.

"Jet, don't worry," I said. "Your mic is going to come back. We are in the middle of a planned silence segment."

The timer hit 07:12.

A yellow banner appeared beneath it: MODERATOR REVIEW IN PROGRESS.

I sat up.

“Review what?”

The stream answered with another robotic announcement.

“Under 18, please have your ID ready.”

I had not clicked that.

The message repeated.

“Under 18, please have your ID ready.”

Jet pointed at the banner.

“I know there’s a moderation review! I can see it!”

The TTS voice said, “I can see it.”

Then it said, “Sofa be pooping.”

Then it said, “Look for the Jurgenerator.”

The overlay began stacking captions over itself. Jet’s silent video had a green label reading AUDIO CONNECTED. My camera had a red label reading AUDIO MAYBE. The TTS panel had a blue label reading PLEASE STOP.

I reached for the mouse and knocked the cracked sunglasses off the desk again. One lens slid under the keyboard. The empty frame caught on my sleeve. I yanked my arm back, which pulled the keyboard cable loose.

The entire stream froze.

Jet froze upside down.

My face froze mid-blink.

The timer froze at 06:03.

For one beautiful second, nothing moved. No chat. No TTS. No fish wheel. No haunted compliment. The room smelled like old coffee and overheated plastic. My hand remained suspended over the keyboard, still hooked through the sunglasses frame like I had been arrested by my own accessory.

Then the screen refreshed.

The timer read 05:59.

Jet returned upright, but now his face was stretched horizontally across the overlay. His eyes were wide, his cheeks flattened, and his silent mouth occupied nearly the entire width of the screen. He looked like a handsome photograph somebody had dragged through a doorway.

The approval button flashed.

APPROVAL PING: TEMPORARY ACCESS GRANTED.

A small bell chimed.

I stood so fast my knee hit the underside of the desk. The mouse launched into the air, struck the lamp, and sent the lamp swinging across the wall. The camera tilted. My cracked sunglasses dangled from my sleeve. Jet's stretched face slid diagonally toward the corner.

"I'm in!" I yelled.

The stream immediately muted me.

My mouth kept moving.

Jet's mouth kept moving.

The timer continued counting down.

05:41.

The chat watched two silent men panic inside a crooked rectangle.

I pointed at the approval ping. "I have been approved!"

No audio.

I pointed harder.

The camera fell sideways, showing the underside of the desk, the coffee continent, and one missing sunglasses lens lying beside a dust-covered coin. My voice came back for half a second.

"I am - "

Cut.

The computer generated a caption: TJ Birds is not currently speaking.

"Lies," I said, though nobody could hear it.

Jet's video suddenly produced sound. His voice arrived all at once, carrying the last twenty seconds of his sentence in a compressed burst.

" - and that's why I think the whole thing is - "

Then it cut again.

He stared at me.

I stared at him.

The moderation timer displayed 04:44.

A moderator message appeared in the chat: PLEASE KEEP AUDIO CLEAR.

I nodded solemnly toward the camera.

“Absolutely.”

The mic cut.

The chat erupted into question marks.

I grabbed the spare microphone from behind the monitor. It was the cheap one I had bought after the last device began making every sentence sound like it was being broadcast from inside a washing machine. I plugged it into the computer.

The stream made a siren noise.

Jet’s video went black.

My TTS voice announced, “Gay guy alert.”

I unplugged the microphone.

The siren stopped.

Jet returned, still silent.

The moderation timer hit 03:18.

I held the dead microphone up to the camera like evidence in court. “This is not my fault. This microphone has a personal issue with success.”

The chat message appeared: THEN STOP TOUCHING IT.

That was rude, but not inaccurate.

I put the microphone down. It rolled across the desk and bumped the keyboard. The keyboard typed a row of commas into the chat.

,,,,,,,,,,,,

The moderation banner turned orange.

MODERATOR ATTENTION REQUIRED.

I leaned close to the screen. My one remaining sunglass lens made the letters bend.

“Okay,” I whispered. “Friendly vibe. Friendly vibe. We are approved. Jet looks great. Nobody is pooping. The fish tank stream is about to go right now.”

The TTS voice said, “Sofa be pooping.”

Jet’s silent video lifted both thumbs.

I pointed at him. “See? Jet understands the brand.”

The timer reached 02:00.

A new approval ping appeared, brighter than the first.

ACCESS CONFIRMED: JURGENATOR LOBBY.

For half a second, the stream stabilized. My camera straightened. Jet’s face returned to normal size. The chat slowed enough to read. His microphone icon turned green.

I smiled.

“You look great, Jet.”

Jet inhaled.

The mic cut.

The timer hit 01:59.

Jet’s face collapsed into a look of pure administrative disgust.

I tried to keep my own dignity upright. “That was a successful compliment.”

The moderator message appeared again.

PLEASE RESOLVE DEAD AIR.

I looked at the countdown, then at Jet, then at the approval ping glowing in the corner like a tiny government-issued blessing.

“Dead air?” I said. “This is not dead air. This is suspense.”

The mic cut before the sentence finished.

The chat received only the caption: TJ Birds says this is.

Jet pointed at the timer.

I pointed at the approval.

He pointed at the timer again.

I pointed at the missing sunglasses lens under the keyboard.

Neither of us had a solution. The stream had approved me just long enough to prove it could reject me with paperwork.

At 00:47, Jet’s microphone came back.

“ - not going to work,” he said.

Then it cut.

At 00:31, mine returned.

“I’m TJ Birds, and - ”

Cut.

At 00:12, the TTS voice whispered, “Look for the Jurgenerator.”

At 00:03, Jet's video rotated upside down.

At 00:00, the timer vanished.

The stream displayed one final message: MODERATOR NOTED.

Then the approval ping chimed again.

ACCESS CONFIRMED.

I sat in the crooked chair, holding one half of my sunglasses and staring at Jet's upside-down face.

"We did it," I said.

This time, the mic worked.

Jet's worked too.

He answered, "Did we?"

The chat immediately posted a new challenge request: KEEP JET'S MIC ALIVE FOR FIVE MINUTES.

Underneath it, another message appeared.

MODERATION TIMER: 10:00.

I looked at Jet.

Jet looked at me.

The countdown began again.



The Wrong Button Gets Pressed

The countdown said 9:58 when I stabbed the approval button with the confidence of a man who had already lost one sunglasses lens and still believed technology respected him.

“Approve me,” I said. “I am TJ Birds. I am Sofa. I am the Jurgenator. Look for the Jurgenator. Fish tank live stream is about to go right now.”

The control panel glowed blue in the dark room. Blue button. Blue border. Blue little fish icon swimming beside a warning that said MODERATION TIMER. My coffee sat beside the keyboard with the oily brown surface of a swamp that had given up. Somewhere on the stream, Jet’s microphone made one tiny electric pop and then died again.

The button did not approve me.

It opened a menu.

I leaned toward the screen. My cracked sunglasses slid down my nose, the remaining lens catching the monitor light like a wounded disco ball. Three controls appeared in nearly identical boxes.

APPROVE STREAM.

APPROVE AUDIO.

APPROVE TTS REQUEST.

“Why are there three approves?” I asked.

Jet's frozen video stared back at me. His face looked beautiful and completely useless.

"Look at Jet's face," I said. "He knows. You look great, Jet."

The microphone produced a dry click.

"Exactly," I said. "Jet agrees."

I moved the cursor toward the first option. The pointer trembled over APPROVE STREAM, then drifted sideways because a notification popped up in the corner.

NEW AUDIENCE MESSAGE: UNDER 18, PLEASE HAVE YOUR ID READY.

"Under 18, please have your ID ready," I announced into the camera. "That's the law of the fish tank. That's the club door. That's the bouncer asking for paperwork while I'm dressed like a broken couch."

The notification vanished. The cursor was now sitting over APPROVE TTS REQUEST.

I saw the word approve. My brain saw victory. My finger saw a button.

Click.

The panel flashed green.

For half a second, I thought I had done it. The fish icon swam in a circle. A little chime played, soft and proud, like a microwave congratulating itself for heating soup.

Then the text box beneath the controls filled with a sentence I had not typed.

TTS QUEUE: "TJ Birds is a handsome wet Squirtle who would like to apologize to the moderation team."

I stared at it.

"No," I said.

The voice came through the stream speakers anyway.

"TJ Birds is a handsome wet Squirtle who would like to apologize to the moderation team."

Jet's frozen face remained on screen, one eyebrow caught halfway up. The stream chat began moving.

SOFA WET.

SQUIRTLE CONFIRMED.

WHY IS HE APOLOGIZING.

I grabbed the mouse. "Cancel. Cancel the Squirtle."

The cancel button sat directly beside SEND TO LIVE.

My hand stopped.

The mouse wheel rolled under my palm. The screen zoomed in until every letter became a fat rectangular building. SEND TO LIVE grew enormous. CANCEL became a narrow gray strip behind the coffee cup icon.

I lifted my coffee to see better.

The cup snagged on the charging cable.

The cable pulled.

The coffee tipped.

A warm brown wave slid across the desk, soaked the mouse pad, and poured directly into the gap between my keyboard keys. The smell was burnt beans, plastic, and immediate consequences.

My elbow hit the trackpad.

SEND TO LIVE clicked.

The TTS queue flashed again.

“TJ Birds is a handsome wet Squirtle who would like to apologize to the moderation team and also has a suspicious bucket.”

The sentence blasted out in my own voice, except the system had stretched every vowel until I sounded like a haunted GPS.

“Suspicious bucket?” I yelled.

The stream chat exploded.

BUCKET ARC.

HE HAS THE BUCKET.

IS THIS THE APPROVAL TEST?

I slapped the keyboard. “Stop! Stop talking! Stop making me sound like a wet Pokémon with legal problems!”

The interface opened another box.

SELECT VOICE.

There were four options: NORMAL, ROBOT, ANNOUNCER, and JET.

I clicked JET.

That was not intentional. My finger was wet from the coffee, the trackpad was slick, and the cursor moved like it had just been released from prison.

The next TTS message came out in Jet’s broken microphone voice: a three-second burst of static followed by a single electronic cough.

The panel interpreted the cough as a request.

TTS QUEUE: "Cough."

It read the word aloud.

"Cough."

Then again.

"Cough."

Then the system added punctuation.

"Cough, cough, cough."

Jet's frozen image twitched. His lips moved for one frame, but no sound came through. His face looked like he had been asked to explain a tax audit while trapped inside a screensaver.

"Jet," I said, "your mic is now doing my TTS. You have been promoted from man to button."

Another chat message appeared.

JET VOICE GOOD.

MAKE HIM SAY THE PASSWORD.

"Password," I said. "Fine. The password is approval. The password is let TJ Birds into the damn fish tank. The password is fishtank.live 247."

I typed it into the text box.

The coffee-soaked keyboard turned the sentence into:

FISHTANK.LIVE 247 JERKINATOR POOPING SQUAD.

I looked down at the keys. "I did not type that."

The system read it.

“Fishtank dot live two hundred forty-seven Jerkinator pooping squad.”

The phrase rolled through the room with the dignity of a royal proclamation delivered by a malfunctioning toilet.

I tried to delete it. The backspace key stuck. It erased one letter, paused, and then removed the entire message history.

The control panel chimed.

TTS REQUEST APPROVED.

I froze.

“Wait,” I said. “Approved?”

A second message appeared beneath it.

STREAM APPROVAL PENDING.

“No. No, no, no. You approved the wrong thing.”

I clicked the stream approval tab. The panel asked a question.

WHICH STREAM WOULD YOU LIKE TO APPROVE?

Underneath were two dropdowns.

LIVE STREAM.

TTS STREAM.

I selected LIVE STREAM.

The dropdown changed to TTS STREAM.

I selected it again.

It changed to LIVE STREAM.

I selected it a third time because now it felt personal.

The screen shook.

TTS FLOW ACTIVATED.

A red border appeared around the entire control panel. The fish icon stopped swimming and began spinning in place. A progress bar crawled across the screen at the speed of a tired slug.

TTS FLOW: 1%.

“Why is it loading?” I asked.

The system replied through the speakers.

“Why is it loading?”

The chat answered before I could.

BECAUSE YOU PRESSED IT.

I pushed my chair back. The wheels rolled over the wet mouse pad and squealed. My knee hit the underside of the desk. The cracked sunglasses flew off my face, bounced once, and landed lens-first in the coffee puddle.

I reached for them, missed, and grabbed the charging cable instead.

The monitor went black.

The stream did not.

My voice continued broadcasting through the speakers.

"I am TJ Birds," the TTS version of me said. "I am Sofa. I am the Jurgenator. I am currently searching for my eye equipment in a beverage."

I could hear the audience typing.

SUNGASSES IN COFFEE.

HE CANT SEE THE BUTTON.

"Those are sunglasses," I said. "One of them already died. The other one is taking a bath."

The monitor returned with a new prompt.

CONFIRM TTS FLOW?

Two buttons appeared.

YES.

YES, BUT LOUDER.

I stared at them without the sunglasses. The letters blurred into glowing blocks. I leaned closer until my nose nearly touched the screen.

"Which one is the normal yes?"

The system repeated me.

"Which one is the normal yes?"

I reached for the keyboard and struck the space bar. Nothing happened. I struck it again. The system treated each hit as a separate command.

YES.

YES.

YES.

YES, BUT LOUDER.

The speakers screamed the last phrase so loudly that the loose plastic lid on my coffee cup jumped and spun across the desk.

"TJ Birds says yes, but louder," the machine announced.

"I did not say that."

"TJ Birds says I did not say that."

"I'm not talking to you."

"TJ Birds is not talking to you."

"Stop."

"TJ Birds says stop."

"Shut up!"

"TJ Birds says shut up."

The chat filled faster than I could see.

NEW TTS REQUEST FROM SOFA.

NEW TTS REQUEST FROM SOFA.

NEW TTS REQUEST FROM SOFA.

Every sentence I spoke was being captured, approved, and shoved back into the queue. My own mouth had become a hostage situation. I could not ask the machine to stop without giving it another line to perform.

I covered the microphone with my hand.

The system picked up the muffled sound.

"TJ Birds is hiding the evidence."

The fish icon spun faster.

TTS FLOW: 83%.

I crawled under the desk for the power strip. The floor was cold against my knees. A crumb stuck to my palm. Somewhere near my ankle, the coffee had formed a sticky brown lake around a USB hub.

"Power off," I muttered.

"Power off," the speakers repeated.

"No."

"No."

"Don't repeat me."

"Don't repeat me."

I found the power strip and pulled the wrong switch.

The ring light died.

The monitor stayed on.

The TTS voice became louder in the darkness.

"TJ Birds is a handsome wet Squirtle who would like to apologize to the moderation team and also has a suspicious bucket."

The sentence played again, but now the voice was set to ANNOUNCER. It sounded like a stadium announcer introducing a championship match between a confused man and a mop bucket.

"Ladies and gentlemen," it boomed, "please welcome Sofa, the Jurgenator, live on fishtank.live 247!"

The stream chat erupted with a wall of bucket emojis.

I stood up too fast and hit my head on the desk.

The system heard the impact.

"Bonk."

Then it approved the request.

"Bonk."

Then it sent it live.

"BONK."

The word echoed through the room. The progress bar reached one hundred percent.

TTS FLOW COMPLETE.

For one beautiful second, the panel went quiet.

Then a new prompt appeared in the center of the screen, clean and bright, with a little gold fish wearing a headset.

CONGRATULATIONS. YOUR TTS FLOW IS READY.

Below it:

START AUDIENCE-SELECTED VOICE CHALLENGE?

I squinted at the options.

START NOW.

START NOW, BUT SEND ALL REQUESTS TO MODERATION.

The approval timer had reset.

MODERATION TIMER: 14:00.

I looked at the clock. Fourteen minutes. I had spent nearly the entire previous countdown turning a simple approval button into a public voice-operated confession booth.

Jet's video finally moved. His mouth opened. His microphone produced one faint pop.

"Jet," I said, rubbing the bump on my head, "say something useful."

The TTS system caught it.

"Jet says something useful."

Jet's screen froze again.

The prompt waited.

START NOW.

START NOW, BUT SEND ALL REQUESTS TO MODERATION.

I pressed the second one.

A warning appeared.

THIS MAY DELAY STREAM APPROVAL.

"Of course it may," I said. "Everything delays stream approval. My whole life is a loading screen."

The system spoke over me.

"Everything delays stream approval. My whole life is a loading screen."

The warning vanished.

AUDIENCE-SELECTED VOICE CHALLENGE ENABLED.

STREAM APPROVAL REMAINS PENDING.

A final line appeared beneath it.

FIRST REQUEST: MAKE SOFA SAY THE APPROVAL PASSWORD.

I wiped coffee from the remaining sunglasses lens and held it up to the screen. The prompt sharpened.

The chat began sending suggestions.

POOPING SQUAD.

WET SQUIRTLE.

BONK.

I put the sunglasses back on. The cracked lens split the gold fish into two gold fish, both wearing headsets, both looking disappointed.

I leaned toward the microphone.

"I'm TJ Birds," I said. "I'm going live on fishtank.live 247. Look for the Jurgenator. Under 18, please have your ID ready. And the password is - "

The TTS queue lit up before I finished.

REQUEST ACCEPTED.

The machine interrupted me in Jet's broken voice.

"Bonk."

The approval timer ticked down to 13:59.

CHAPTER 4

Under-18 ID Request Pops Up

The approval timer ticked down to 13:59, and the machine interrupted me in Jet's broken voice.

"Under 18, please have your ID ready."

I froze with one hand over the keyboard and the other holding the coffee cup that had already tried to drown my equipment. The stream went quiet except for the computer fan wheezing like it had smoked behind a gas station since birth.

"What?"

The banner appeared across the screen in a clean white rectangle, which was offensive already. Nothing that clean belonged in my room. Not with the cracked sunglasses on my face, one lens missing, coffee drying beneath the keyboard, and the approval window still haunted by the previous TTS loop.

Under 18, please have your ID ready.

The machine repeated it.

Jet's voice repeated it.

Then my own voice repeated it because I had accidentally left the playback monitor on.

"Under 18, please have your ID ready."

Three TJs stared back at me from three different corners of the stream. One was alive. One was broken. One sounded like Jet trapped inside a microwave.

"I am TJ Birds," I said. "I am a grown-ass man. I am going live on fishtank.live 247. The fish tank live stream is about to go right now. Look for the Jurgenerator."

The banner blinked.

Under 18, please have your ID ready.

"Why is it asking me?"

"It's asking the audience," Jet said, or the machine said, or some damaged combination of Jet and machine said. His microphone had been cutting out so long that his voice now existed in the same category as weather and suspicious plumbing.

"I know it's asking the audience. I'm the audience right now."

I leaned toward the camera. The remaining lens of my sunglasses reflected the white banner. The missing side made me look like a pirate who had been rejected from a children's birthday party.

"Chat," I said, "don't panic. This is not a problem. This is what approval looks like. We are about to get approved. We are simply walking through the fishy portal."

The portal had changed. That was the issue.

Before, it had been a lobby with buttons. Then it had been a TTS trap. Now it was an age-verification hallway, a narrow digital corridor where every door demanded paperwork and every floor tile said I had probably clicked the wrong thing.

The audience counter climbed.

Someone typed: WHY IS TJ GETTING ID CHECKED

Another message appeared: HE LOOKS 16 WITH THAT ONE GLASS

I adjusted the sunglasses. The frame squeaked.

"First of all, this is fashion. Second of all, I have two kids in the back."

"That was a lyric," I told myself immediately.

The banner expanded.

UNDER 18, PLEASE HAVE YOUR ID READY.

A red button appeared beneath it.

VERIFY AGE.

I clicked the wrong button.

The screen flashed blue. A little fish icon spun in a circle, then grew teeth.

"No," I said.

The machine spoke in Jet's broken voice. "Please upload a valid government-issued identification document."

"Absolutely not."

The camera light turned on.

The lens stared at me.

I stared back.

A notification popped up: FACE POSITION NOT DETECTED.

"I'm right here."

FACE POSITION NOT DETECTED.

"I have been positioned my entire life."

The camera made a soft electronic chirp. My coffee cup tipped against the keyboard. I caught it with my elbow, knocked the sunglasses off my face, and sent them skidding across the desk. The cracked lens tapped the mouse twice.

The page refreshed.

“Why did it refresh?”

Jet said something, but his microphone chopped it into a wet digital cough.

“What? Speak up, Jet.”

“ - look - ”

“What?”

“ - great - ”

“I know I look great, Jet. Look at Jet’s face, everybody. Beautiful. Handsome man looking like a Squirtle.”

The audience chat exploded so fast it became a gray waterfall. Somebody clipped the moment before I finished the sentence. I could feel the clip forming in the air, its tiny invisible scissors cutting my dignity into a square format.

The ID window demanded a front image.

I picked up the nearest card from beside the coffee cup.

It was a grocery rewards card.

The camera scanned it.

INVALID DOCUMENT.

“Okay, listen,” I said. “That card has my name on it.”

INVALID DOCUMENT.

"It has my points on it."

INVALID DOCUMENT.

"It proves I buy things."

The machine made a low error sound.

Jet's voice said, "Please have your ID ready."

"Stop saying that! I'm trying to have it ready!"

I dug through the drawer. The drawer contained two dead batteries, a receipt from a place I did not remember visiting, a bent spoon, and a small plastic fish with one eye. The fish fell onto the keyboard and pressed the space bar.

The stream paused.

When it returned, I was enlarged to fill the entire screen. My one remaining sunglass lens sat crooked over my eye. The camera had frozen my mouth halfway through a word, creating a portrait of a man being legally questioned by a refrigerator.

The banner remained beneath my face.

UNDER 18, PLEASE HAVE YOUR ID READY.

"Chat, this is harassment."

A message appeared: SHOW THE ID, SOFA

Another: JURGENATOR BIRTH CERTIFICATE ARC

Another: BRO GOT AGE-GATED BY HIS OWN INTRO

"I'm not getting age-gated. I am passing through a safety checkpoint."

I found my driver's license under the coffee cup.

The corner was damp. The photograph had a brown stain across my chin. I held it toward the camera.

The page rejected it before I even pressed anything.

DOCUMENT TOO DAMAGED.

"Too damaged? That's me!"

DOCUMENT TOO DAMAGED.

"Are you calling my face damaged?"

The machine switched voices. First Jet. Then me. Then a flat automated voice that sounded like it had never once enjoyed a song.

"Please remove eyewear."

I removed the sunglasses.

"Please remove eyewear."

"They're off."

"Please remove eyewear."

I held the cracked glasses up to the camera.

"Look. No eyewear."

The system recognized the glasses instead of my face.

EYEWEAR DETECTED.

The missing lens dangled from the frame by a thin strip of plastic. I had not noticed it was still attached. It swung in front of the camera like a tiny broken windshield wiper.

"Okay," I said. "This is a setup."

Jet's microphone clicked on.

" - TJ, maybe - "

"Maybe what?"

" - turn the - "

The microphone died.

"Maybe turn the what? Turn the fish? Turn the portal? Turn my life around?"

I clicked VERIFY AGE again.

This time the camera demanded a head turn.

TURN HEAD LEFT.

I turned left.

TURN HEAD RIGHT.

I turned right.

BLINK.

I blinked.

BLINK.

I blinked harder.

BLINK.

"I am blinking."

The system did not accept my blink. It wanted a more official blink, a blink with government posture. I squeezed both eyes shut, lost balance in the chair, and rolled

backward into the wall.

The camera saw the ceiling.

FACE POSITION NOT DETECTED.

“Technically, my face is still in the building.”

The chat began chanting.

ID! ID! ID! ID!

I pulled myself back into frame. The chair wheel had caught on a cable from the coffee-damaged setup. The cable tightened. The monitor shook. The plastic fish jumped off the keyboard and landed in the cup.

The cup tipped.

Coffee spilled again.

It ran across the desk in a dark, shining sheet, straight toward the ID.

“No, no, no, no.”

I grabbed the license. The cup struck my elbow. The license flew upward, flipped once, and slapped against my forehead.

For one perfect second, it stayed there.

The camera captured my face, my crooked sunglasses, the license pressed to my forehead, and the white banner underneath like a legal caption.

Under 18, please have your ID ready.

The machine read the license backward.

DOCUMENT ORIENTATION INVALID.

I peeled it off my forehead.

"Now it's upside down?"

The audience counter jumped again. A donation sound fired, but the alert was still using Jet's broken microphone. It announced, " - please have your - " and then dissolved into static.

I tried to rap through it.

"About to get approved, don't know why you doubt me, Fish tank portal got a cop around me, Sofa on the beat, Jurgenerator ready, One lens missing but the paperwork steady - "

DOCUMENT TOO DAMAGED.

"Shut up!"

" - under eighteen - "

"Shut up, Jet!"

" - please have your ID ready - "

"I am not under eighteen!"

The system asked me to select my age range.

The choices appeared.

Under 13.

13-17.

18-24.

25-34.

35-44.

45 and older.

I clicked 25-34.

A warning appeared: AGE SELECTION DOES NOT MATCH FACIAL ESTIMATE.

The room became very still.

Even Jet's broken microphone stopped coughing.

"Facial estimate?"

The machine displayed a yellow face outline over my head. The outline was smaller than my actual head by what felt like several legal inches.

"Listen, algorithm. I have been through things."

AGE SELECTION DOES NOT MATCH FACIAL ESTIMATE.

"I have paid taxes."

AGE SELECTION DOES NOT MATCH FACIAL ESTIMATE.

"I have a coffee stain on my government ID."

AGE SELECTION DOES NOT MATCH FACIAL ESTIMATE.

"That should make me older!"

The chat moved so quickly that individual messages became little sparks. Someone wrote, TJ BIRDS VS BIRTHDAY. Someone else wrote, THE FISH TANK THINKS SOFA IS A MINOR. Another user posted a screenshot of my frozen forehead-license pose with the words PLEASE HAVE YOUR ID READY stamped across it.

The clip was already spreading.

I could tell because the donation alert changed.

MEME CLIP DETECTED.

“What does that mean?”

The alert played my own voice, slowed down and lowered until I sounded like a haunted bass drum.

“Look at Jet’s face.”

Jet finally came through clearly.

“I said turn the camera down.”

The camera turned itself down.

Now it showed my chest, the desk, the coffee puddle, the plastic fish floating in the cup, and the ID lying face-down beside the mouse.

The banner remained at the top.

UNDER 18, PLEASE HAVE YOUR ID READY.

“Why is it showing my stomach?”

“ - turn it up - ”

“I don’t know how!”

I reached for the camera mount. The chair wheel pulled the cable again. The monitor swung toward me. The remaining sunglass lens fell off my face and landed directly on the ID.

The system scanned the lens.

DOCUMENT ACCEPTED.

I stared at the screen.

“What?”

The banner vanished.

A green checkmark appeared.

AGE VERIFIED.

The fish icon stopped spinning. The teeth disappeared. A cheerful chime played, followed by the voice of Jet saying, “You look great, Jet.”

Jet’s real voice cut in at the exact same time.

“I did not say that.”

“I did,” I said.

“No, you didn’t.”

“I definitely did.”

The stream window opened.

LIVE STATUS: APPROVED.

The audience saw everything. The forehead license. The coffee. The floating plastic fish. The one-lens sunglasses. The age estimate argument. The accidental scan of the cracked lens that somehow cleared the gate.

For three seconds, nobody typed.

Then the chat filled with the same message.

THE GLASSES GOT APPROVED BEFORE TJ.

I picked up the lens and held it toward the camera.

“Chat, let’s be clear. The lens is part of the Jurgenator brand. Look for the Jurgenator. We are official. We are legal. We are going live on fishtank.live 247.”

The approval timer vanished.

A new notice replaced it.

CLIP OF THE MOMENT CREATED.

I clicked it.

The preview showed my license stuck to my forehead while I screamed at the age-verification banner. The title had already been generated.

UNDER 18? PLEASE HAVE YOUR ID READY, SOFA.

I tried to change the title.

The page asked for moderator approval.

I clicked the approval button.

The TTS loop woke up.

Jet’s broken voice came from the speakers.

“Under 18, please have your ID ready.”

The banner returned.

The timer reset to fifteen minutes.

I looked at the camera. The plastic fish bobbed in the coffee cup. Jet’s microphone clicked once, then died.

“Fine,” I said. “The fish tank live stream is about to go right now.”

The machine answered before I could rap.

"Please have your ID ready."

CHAPTER 5



The Crocs Sandwich Incident

“Please have your ID ready.”

The machine had said it like it was announcing a fire drill in a building made entirely of wet cardboard. I stared at the comment thread, one cracked sunglasses lens hanging off my face, the other lens reflecting the blue approval timer like a tiny haunted aquarium.

“Under 18, please have your ID ready,” I repeated, because apparently the fish tank live stream needed me to become a mall security guard before it would let me exist.

Jet’s microphone clicked somewhere offscreen.

“ - and I was saying - ”

Then silence.

“Beautiful,” I said. “You look great, Jet. Look at Jet’s face. Nobody can hear the face, but the face is doing numbers.”

The chat was moving too fast. Every time I reached for the approval button, somebody dropped a message about the coffee stain under my keyboard, the missing lens in my sunglasses, or the fact that my camera angle made me look like a divorced raccoon waiting outside a vape shop. I needed control. I needed one clean message. One professional statement.

I typed: FISHTANK.LIVE 247. TJ BIRDS. SOFA. JURGENATOR. LOOK FOR THE JURGENATOR. APPROVAL IN PROGRESS.

Before I could send it, a comment appeared.

“Are those Crocs?”

I froze.

The word sat there in the chat like somebody had thrown a live crab into my lap.

“Why are we talking about Crocs?” I asked.

Another comment arrived.

“Bro is wearing Crocs.”

“I am not wearing Crocs,” I said immediately, which was a terrible sentence because the camera was pointed directly at my feet.

The Crocs were visible beneath the desk. Gray. Ventilated. Brutally comfortable. One had a coffee splash on it from the previous disaster, giving the little rubber holes the appearance of a beverage had tried to escape through my shoe and failed.

The chat detonated.

CROCS CONFIRMED.

JURGENATOR IN THE CLOGS.

SOFA GOT THE FISH SHOES.

“Those are not Crocs,” I said. “Those are tactical foot containers.”

The approval timer dropped another minute.

I reached for the mouse. My hand hit the coffee cup. The cup wobbled, performed a slow little baptism over the edge of the desk, and landed sideways against a stack of napkins. Nothing spilled except one brown tear that slid toward the keyboard with criminal intent.

"Everybody calm down," I said. "I'm handling this."

A viewer wrote, "Sandals better."

"No," I said. "Absolutely not. Sandals are just Crocs that got drafted into a failed summer romance."

The chat sped up.

CROCS VS SANDALS.

FIGHT.

TAKE THEM OFF.

SHOW FEET FOR APPROVAL.

"Look, the approval is right there," I said, pointing at the timer. "The machine wants my ID. The machine wants proof I am a real human being. Instead, you people want a footwear tribunal."

Someone posted a sandal emoji. Someone else posted a fish wearing a tiny shoe. A third person asked whether Jet had feet.

Jet's microphone clicked.

" - I have feet - "

"Jet, don't get involved," I said. "Your microphone is already under investigation."

I tried to steer the conversation back. "My name is TJ Birds. I'm going live on fishtank.live 247. This fish tank live stream is about to go right now. I am waiting for approval. Look for the Jurgenerator. Sofa is in the building. Sofa is wearing footwear that has become politically controversial."

The chat ignored every word except footwear.

A message popped up: "Sofa, defend Crocs."

That was the trap. I knew it was the trap. I could feel the approval slipping away, but I also knew the Crocs had been mentioned, and once Crocs entered a live chat, they did not leave politely. They demanded a closing argument.

"Fine," I said. "Crocs are honest. Crocs don't pretend to be elegant. Crocs wake up every morning and say, 'I am a rubber boat for your feet, and I have accepted this.' Sandals wake up and lie."

The chat filled with laughing symbols and increasingly aggressive footwear opinions.

I leaned closer to the camera. The cracked lens of my sunglasses caught the monitor glow, while the missing lens left one eye exposed and furious.

"Sandals are a threat," I continued. "A sandal has one strap holding together the entire government. One wrong puddle and the sandal starts flapping like it got bad news. Crocs? Crocs have structure. Crocs have holes. Crocs have a heel strap that says, 'Today we may commit a minor crime.'"

The approval button blinked.

I clicked it.

The screen opened the wrong menu.

Text-to-speech began reading the chat in Jet's broken voice.

"Crocks versus sandals. Crocks versus sandals. Crocks versus - "

"Crocs!" I shouted. "It's Crocs! The shoe is not a cooking pot!"

The machine repeated, "The shoe is not a cooking pot."

That made the chat worse.

Someone asked if I was cooking the Crocs. Someone else asked whether sandals counted as open-source footwear. A viewer claimed socks with sandals were “the final boss.” I could see the whole conversation leaving me behind like a bus I had missed while arguing with the driver about his ankles.

I tried to mute TTS. Instead, I activated a poll.

CROCS

SANDALS

BARE FEET

The poll appeared across my face.

“No,” I said. “No, no, no. Bare feet are not an option. Bare feet are what happens when your shoes lose custody.”

The Crocs sat under the desk, suddenly enormous. Their rubber soles squeaked whenever I shifted. The left one had a loose strap. The right one had a coffee mark shaped like the state of disappointment. I lifted one foot to hide it, but the desk bumped my knee, the camera tilted, and now the entire audience got a close-up of the Crocs from below.

The chat went silent for half a second.

Then it became a riot.

ANGLE CRAZY.

CROC CAM.

PUT THEM IN SPORT MODE.

I looked down at the heel strap. “Sport mode?”

A comment explained that Crocs had a strap position for increased activity.

"Of course they do," I said. "Of course the foam canoe has a combat setting."

I reached down and pushed the strap backward. It snapped against my ankle with a sharp rubber slap.

The machine interpreted the sound as a command.

"Approval denied."

The timer froze.

For one beautiful second, nothing moved except the tiny blue loading circle. The chat stopped arguing about shoes and watched me discover that I had possibly been rejected by a website because my Croc had made a noise.

"Did my shoe just get me denied?" I whispered.

Jet's microphone clicked.

" - maybe it detected - "

"Don't finish that sentence."

The timer restarted at nine minutes.

I stood up. The Crocs squeaked against the floor. The sound was wet and humiliating, like two mice trying to open a refrigerator.

"Okay," I said. "New plan. Crocs versus sandals. We settle this in the arena."

I stepped out from behind the desk. The camera showed my shorts, my crooked shirt, one cracked pair of sunglasses, and the full architectural tragedy of my footwear. I raised my left foot.

"This is a Croc. It has ventilation. It has a heel strap. It can survive a puddle, a bathroom floor, and a family gathering where somebody's uncle starts explaining cryptocurrency."

I raised my right foot.

"This is also a Croc, but this one has seen things."

The chat demanded a sandal comparison.

I grabbed a sandal from beside the couch. I did not remember owning it. It was brown, flat, and shaped like something a monk would use to slap a mosquito.

"This is a sandal," I said. "It has no protection. It is a leather apology. It is a high-five for the pavement."

I placed the sandal beside the Crocs.

The sandal immediately fell over.

The chat exploded again.

I pointed at it. "That is the entire argument. I put it down and it gave up."

Jet's microphone crackled.

" - the sandal has dignity - "

"The sandal has no heel strap, Jet. It cannot be trusted with a small hill."

I tried to return to the approval prompt. The chat would not let me. Every message now contained either a Croc, a sandal, or a demand that I put one shoe in "jibbitz mode," which I assumed meant decorating it with tiny charms. Somebody posted a fish tank emoji wearing sandals. Somebody else wrote, "TJ is avoiding the ID."

"I am not avoiding the ID," I said. "I am creating a footwear-based identity."

The machine read that aloud.

"I am creating a footwear-based identity."

"Thank you," I said. "Finally, the machine understands me."

I sat down too hard. The chair rolled backward, struck the wall, and knocked loose the cable feeding Jet's microphone. His voice came through for one sudden, perfect second.

" - you're wearing Crocs because you're afraid of becoming a sandal - "

Then the microphone died again.

I stared at the dead audio icon.

"That was the smartest thing anybody has said all night."

The chat demanded the quote be repeated. I couldn't repeat it because I didn't know whether Jet had actually said it or whether the malfunction had assembled it from three unrelated syllables. Either way, it was now canon.

I turned back to the camera and started rapping before the approval timer could fall any further.

"Crocs on the floor, sandals at the door, One got holes, one got no core. Sofa in the lobby, approval on delay, TJ Birds got a shoe fight taking over the day.

Look for the Jurginator, fish tank going live, Heel strap back, now the Croc's in drive. Sandals got a flap and a desperate little squeak, Crocs got a pocket where the foot can breathe."

The chat began supplying rhymes.

"CROCS GOT POCKETS."

"SANDALS GOT TAXES."

"JET GOT NO MIC."

I pointed at the last one. "Jet got no mic, but Jet has opinions. You look great, Jet. Look at Jet's face. Look at his beautiful silent face while my shoes become the main character."

The poll results rolled across the screen.

Crocs: 61 percent.

Sandals: 28 percent.

Bare feet: 11 percent.

I stared at the bare-feet number.

“Eleven percent of you are dangerous.”

A new comment appeared beneath it.

“ID request?”

I saw it. I absolutely saw it. The viewer was asking about the validation request, the thing I had been trying to answer since the machine told me to have my ID ready. The approval prompt was still open. The timer was still counting down. My response box was still waiting.

I could have clicked it.

Instead, somebody posted, “Can Crocs be worn to a funeral?”

I inhaled.

The wrong answer came out.

“Only if the funeral is for your dignity.”

The chat surged so hard the page jumped. My response box vanished beneath the messages. The machine began reading “CROCS FUNERAL” in Jet’s damaged voice. The sandal slid off the couch. The coffee-stained Croc squeaked again. The approval timer dropped to seven minutes while I stood in the middle of the room holding one sandal like a courtroom exhibit.

I had won the argument. Crocs had beaten sandals by a margin wide enough to fit another Croc inside. The chat was mine again, technically. Everybody was watching Sofa defend the foam boats. The conversation had been seized, dragged through rubber mud, and transformed into a full footwear broadcast.

And the validation request sat unanswered beneath it all.

I lowered the sandal.

“Fine,” I said. “Crocs win. Approval loses. Under 18, please have your ID ready, because apparently mine is less important than whether this strap is in sport mode.”

The timer flashed.

Jet’s dead microphone clicked once.

Then the machine announced, “Please select your footwear.”

Google Assistant Refuses to Rap

“P lease select your footwear.”

The machine said it again, calm as a tax form, while Jet’s dead microphone clicked beside me like a tiny insect trapped in a plastic coffin.

I had one cracked sunglasses lens, one missing lens, a coffee cup leaking into the equipment, and a footwear prompt hovering over the fish tank live stream like the portal had decided my Crocs were more important than my artistic career. The audience was waiting. The approval timer was sulking. Somewhere on fishtank.live 247, a moderator was probably watching me fail to identify shoes.

“I am not selecting footwear,” I said. “I am selecting greatness.”

The assistant window blinked.

“Please select your footwear.”

“Google, listen to me. I need sixteen bars.”

“Sorry, I didn’t understand.”

That was the first punch.

I leaned toward the microphone, which smelled faintly of burnt coffee and panic.

“Sixteen bars. A rap. Instant content. Something for the fish tank live stream.

Something that says TJ Birds has arrived.”

“Sorry, I didn’t understand.”

"Sixteen bars!"

"Please select your footwear."

The portal had fused my request with the Crocs incident. It thought I was trying to make my shoes rap. This was not a misunderstanding. This was an organized attack by a rectangle.

I slapped the desk. The coffee cup jumped, tipped, and poured one final brown ribbon into the keyboard.

"Look at Jet's face," I said to the camera. "Jet knows what's happening."

Jet stared forward. His microphone gave one dry click.

"You look great, Jet," I told him.

Click.

"Exactly. Jet understands."

"Sorry, I didn't understand," said the assistant.

"You don't understand anything! You are a glorified egg timer with Wi-Fi!"

The comments started moving faster. Somebody typed, "Ask it for bars." Somebody else typed, "The bot is more prepared than TJ." A third person wrote, "Under 18, please have your ID ready," which the machine immediately read aloud in its soft, official voice.

"Under 18, please have your ID ready."

"Not now!" I shouted. "I'm trying to create."

The assistant window expanded. A little microphone icon appeared, blue and smug.

I took off the cracked sunglasses and set them on the desk. Without them, the room looked dangerously real. The missing lens left the frames shaped like a broken promise. I put them back on.

"Google Assistant," I said, slowly, "give me sixteen bars."

"Here are some results for bars near you."

A map appeared.

The first location was a sports bar twelve miles away. The second was a place called The Copper Keg. The third had a picture of nachos large enough to house a family.

"No! Not bars like drinking bars. Rap bars!"

"Sorry, I didn't understand."

"Bars with rhythm!"

"Sorry, I didn't understand."

"Bars with rhyme!"

"Sorry, I didn't understand."

"Bars with me!"

The assistant paused.

"Here are some results for bars near you."

The map zoomed in until the sports bar covered Jet's face.

I jabbed at the screen. My finger hit the footwear prompt. A menu dropped down over the map.

"Please select your footwear."

"Crocs!" I yelled. "I'm wearing Crocs! Happy?"

The assistant responded, "You selected: socks."

The chat exploded.

I looked down. The Crocs were under the desk, one orange and one black, because I had kicked them off during the previous argument. I was standing in socks. The machine had technically won.

"Those are not socks," I said. "Those are temporary feet."

"Please confirm: socks."

"No."

"Please select your footwear."

"I selected Crocs!"

"Sorry, I didn't understand."

"I am Sofa!" I shouted. "I am the Jurgenator! Look for the Jurgenator! I am TJ Birds, and you're watching Goddamn Let's Kill Somebody!"

The assistant lowered its volume.

"Sorry, I didn't understand."

That hurt worse than the coffee.

I grabbed the phone and opened the voice assistant directly, because apparently the computer inside the computer needed a smaller computer to explain itself. The phone's screen was greasy. My thumb slid across it and opened a weather app.

"Give me sixteen bars," I said.

"Rain is expected at 4:00 p.m."

"Bars!"

"Chance of rain: sixty percent."

"Raps!"

"Here is a map of nearby restaurants."

"Why are you sending me to restaurants?"

The fish tank stream continued behind the assistant window. The fish swam through their little plastic castle, completely unaware that I was losing a creative negotiation with an object designed to set alarms.

I tried again, speaking with the exaggerated clarity of a hostage negotiator.

"Six. Teen. Bars."

"Sixteen bars," the phone repeated.

"Yes!"

"Sorry, I didn't understand."

The assistant had heard me perfectly and rejected me anyway.

I turned toward the camera. "This is censorship. This is what happens when a man tries to bring culture into a fish tank. They want me to identify footwear. They want me to say socks. They do not want sixteen bars."

Jet's microphone clicked.

"Jet agrees," I said.

The microphone clicked again.

"Jet is speaking."

It clicked a third time.

“Jet is dropping a verse.”

Nothing came through. The silence sat there with professional confidence.

I filled it myself.

“Jet on the mic, but the mic on vacation, Coffee in the keyboard, portal interrogation,
Sofa in the lobby, Jurgenator in flight, One lens on the glasses but the vision still right
- ”

The assistant interrupted.

“Here are sixteen bars near you.”

The screen populated with a list of metal rails, handrails, and public benches.

I froze.

The first bar was outside a grocery store. The second was a railing near a train station. The third was a bench labeled “bar” because the map database had lost its mind.

The audience began requesting specific ones.

“Do the grocery bar.”

“Rap on the handrail.”

“Ask for sixteen fish.”

That last comment stuck in my head.

I could outsmart the machine. If it refused rap, I would ask for information. Then I would turn the information into rap myself. Trivia was just rap wearing a tie.

“Fine,” I said. “Google, how many fish are in the fish tank?”

"Sorry, I didn't understand."

I sat back.

The room hummed. The wet keyboard made a faint sticky sound under my palm. Jet's dead microphone clicked once, as if even it wanted to leave.

"How many fish," I repeated, "are in the fish tank?"

"Sorry, I didn't understand."

"You understood footwear!"

"Please select your footwear."

"I am asking about fish!"

"Please confirm: socks."

"No socks!"

"Sorry, I didn't understand."

I stood up so fast my knee struck the desk. The phone bounced, landed on the coffee cup, and activated the flashlight. A white beam shot directly into my remaining sunglasses lens.

For a second, I could see nothing but a glowing circle.

The assistant began reading the nearby bars again.

"Copper Keg. The Rusty Anchor. Side Pocket Lounge - "

"Stop listing bars!"

"Sorry, I didn't understand."

I yanked the power cable from the speaker. The assistant continued through the phone.

I shut off the phone. The laptop assistant continued.

I closed the laptop. The stream tablet continued.

I slapped the tablet facedown on the desk. The machine's voice came muffled through the wood.

"Please select your footwear."

This was the funniest part, although at the time I was too busy becoming a barefoot broadcast criminal to appreciate it. The tablet lay face down in a puddle of coffee, speaking from beneath the desk like a trapped bureaucrat in the afterlife. Every few seconds, its voice emerged through the sticky darkness.

"Sorry, I didn't understand."

I crouched beside it.

"Listen," I whispered. "We can fix this."

"Please select your footwear."

"I need sixteen bars."

"Here are some results for bars near you."

The tablet began naming locations under the desk.

"Copper Keg."

I lifted it.

"Rusty Anchor."

I wiped the screen with my shirt.

“Side Pocket Lounge.”

I shook it.

“Public handrail.”

The fish tank stream camera tilted. The image went sideways. The audience saw the floor, my abandoned Crocs, and the bottom half of Jet’s chair. Jet’s microphone clicked again.

“Jet is now horizontal,” I announced.

The assistant said, “Sorry, I didn’t understand.”

I grabbed the camera and held it upright. My face appeared enormous, one eye hidden behind the cracked lens, my hair flattened on one side from wearing headphones too long.

“This is not a bot,” I said. “This is TJ Birds. This is Sofa. This is the Jurgenerator. I am a human being with sixteen bars inside me.”

The chat answered with a wall of robot emojis.

I pointed at the fish tank. “Google, tell me one fact about fish.”

The assistant paused longer this time.

“Some fish can change color to communicate.”

The room went quiet.

I stared at the screen.

“That,” I said, “is a fact.”

The assistant waited.

I grabbed the moment before it could escape.

"Now make it sixteen bars."

"Sorry, I didn't understand."

"Fine! I'll make the bars!"

I turned toward the camera and raised both hands. One hand held the phone. The other held a damp sunglasses frame. The fish drifted behind me in the blue light while the assistant remained open, ready to misunderstand the next sentence.

"Fish change color, they communicate, Sofa in the tank and I'm feeling great, TJ Birds live, 247, One lens missing but I still see heaven - "

"Sorry, I didn't understand."

"Stop judging my rhyme!"

"I'm not sure what you mean."

"You are absolutely sure what I mean! You're just refusing to participate!"

The assistant offered a button labeled "Try again."

I pressed it.

"Please select your footwear."

I pressed it again.

"Please select your footwear."

I pressed it a third time, harder, as if pressure could produce intelligence.

The screen opened a survey asking whether the assistant had answered my question.

I selected no.

It asked why.

I selected "other."

It asked me to describe the issue.

I typed: "IT WILL NOT RAP."

Autocorrect changed it to: "IT WILL NOT RAMP."

The assistant read the sentence aloud.

"It will not ramp."

"Rap!" I screamed. "R-A-P!"

The transcription changed.

"It will not wrap."

The fish tank stream displayed my message in the public chat: IT WILL NOT WRAP.

That was it. The comments began calling me a bot. Not a man battling a malfunctioning assistant. Not a visionary trapped inside a footwear questionnaire. A bot.

One viewer wrote, "TJ has generated the same response for six minutes."

Another wrote, "Ask him to prove he's human."

I leaned close to the camera.

"I am human," I said.

"Sorry, I didn't understand," said the assistant.

The chat filled with robot faces again.

I looked at Jet. "You look great, Jet."

Click.

"Look at Jet's face."

Click.

The dead microphone offered no defense. The fish continued changing color beneath the tank light, communicating with one another in a language that apparently required no approval prompt.

I picked up the phone one last time.

"Google," I said, exhausted but still loud, "how many fish are in the tank?"

This time it answered.

"There are several fish in the tank."

I waited.

"How many?"

"Several."

"How many is several?"

"Several means more than two but not many."

I turned toward the camera, wounded dignity balanced on a coffee-soaked keyboard.

"There," I said. "Alternate fish-count fact. More than two. Not many. That is my trivia. That is my content."

The assistant chimed.

"Would you like directions to the nearest bar?"

I stared at it.

The stream status changed from pending review to “voice activity detected.” My request for sixteen bars had failed, my fish count was useless, and the machine had successfully made me look like a bot who wandered into a fish tank wearing temporary feet.

Jet’s microphone clicked once.

I nodded solemnly.

“Exactly,” I said. “Next stream, we count the fish ourselves.”

The assistant answered from the coffee-soaked tablet.

“Please select your footwear.”

CHAPTER 7

The Aquacadabra Rule Gets Misquoted

The coffee-soaked tablet asked me to select my footwear, so I selected knowledge instead.

“Fish tank stocking rules,” I announced, holding the tablet away from my pants like it had become medically contagious. “One inch per gallon. Everybody knows that. That is the law. That is the Aquacadabra Rule.”

The viewer-questions panel immediately filled with messages.

I had one cracked sunglasses lens hanging off my face, one lens missing entirely, and a coffee cup sweating beside the keyboard like it knew a confession was coming. Jet sat in the corner with his dead microphone, looking great, Jet. Look at Jet’s face. He had the expression of a man watching somebody juggle knives near a gas pump.

“I’m TJ Birds,” I said, leaning toward the camera. “You’re watching Goddamn Let’s Kill Somebody. Godamn it. Let’s kill somebody. I’m going live on fishtank.live 247. Fish tank live stream is about to go right now. Under 18, please have your ID ready. And if anybody asks, I’m Sofa. Look for the Jurgenator. The Jerkinator. The man is here.”

A question appeared.

“Does the one-inch rule include tail length?”

I read it aloud, then nodded like a scientist who had just been handed a suspicious sandwich.

“Obviously not,” I said. “It’s one inch of fish per gallon, measured from the nose to the emotional boundary.”

The panel paused for half a second.

Then it detonated.

“What the fuck is emotional boundary?” I asked, even though I had invented it.

Another question popped up. “Do you mean one inch of adult fish per gallon?”

“Yes,” I said. “That’s what I said. Adult fish. Mature fish. Full-grown fish. Fish with mortgages.”

A third message appeared. “That rule is outdated and depends on filtration, shape, species, oxygen, and behavior.”

I squinted through the remaining piece of my sunglasses. The missing lens made the panel look like it was fleeing sideways.

“Outdated?” I said. “The fish did not update the rule. The fish are still one inch. They have not downloaded a patch.”

Jet’s microphone clicked.

I spun toward him. “Jet, did you hear that? They’re trying to cancel the gallon.”

His mic stayed dead. The only answer came from the tablet, which coughed up a wet electronic chirp and displayed: PLEASE SELECT YOUR FOOTWEAR.

“I’m not selecting footwear!” I shouted. “I am selecting aquatic truth!”

The tablet’s speaker repeated, “Footwear.”

That was when I understood the first problem. The viewers were not asking questions because they wanted answers. They were asking questions because they had found a man standing near a rule with no permit.

I sat up straighter. The chair squeaked beneath me. Somewhere under the desk, the coffee spill had turned a cable into a warm noodle.

"Listen," I said. "The Aquacadabra Rule is simple. One inch per gallon. You got a ten-gallon tank? Ten inches of fish. You got a hundred-gallon tank? Congratulations, you can own a fish that has seen a tax attorney."

The panel answered faster.

"Not a law."

"Not reliable."

"Depends on species."

"Never use it for goldfish."

"Fish body, not tail."

"Tank dimensions matter."

I pointed at the screen. "Everybody calm down. We are not going to let punctuation destroy the aquarium."

A viewer asked, "What fish are you stocking?"

I looked around the room. There was no fish tank. There was a bucket with a hoodie in it, a coffee cup, and a plastic decoration shaped vaguely like a castle. The castle had been knocked over during the Crocs argument and now leaned against the router.

"Whatever fish fit," I said.

"That's not an answer."

"It is the most tank-based answer possible."

Jet lifted one finger, trying to contribute. His microphone gave a tiny pop and died again.

“Jet has a question,” I announced.

Jet mouthed something.

“What? Speak into the dead microphone.”

He mouthed it again, harder, as if volume could travel through a corpse.

The tablet translated him incorrectly. “Please select your footwear.”

“Exactly,” I said. “Jet agrees. Footwear is part of stocking density because if the fish are wearing shoes, they take up more room.”

The panel turned vicious.

“No.”

“Stop.”

“Fish don’t wear shoes.”

“Why are you measuring fish by inches?”

I slapped the desk. The tablet jumped, slid through a smear of coffee, and landed against the plastic castle. The castle’s little tower pressed the screen.

“Please select your footwear,” it said.

“I’m trying to earn approval!” I yelled. “I’m trying to sound knowledgeable! I’m not going to get rejected because I don’t know whether a fish has a tail!”

A viewer sent: “You already got rejected for Crocs.”

That one hurt because it was accurate.

I grabbed a napkin and wiped the tablet. The napkin disintegrated across the glass, leaving a white paste over the words AQUACADABRA RULE. The panel kept moving beneath it, a river of people correcting my face.

I decided to clarify.

"The actual rule," I said, "is one inch per gallon, but only if the fish is standing up."

"Fish don't stand up."

"Some do."

"Which ones?"

"Tall ones."

"What does that mean?"

"It means stop trying to make me define fish."

The camera shook as I leaned forward. My sunglasses slid down my nose. The cracked lens caught the monitor light and threw a bright little slash across Jet's forehead. He looked like a silent action hero trapped in a customer-service call.

I pointed at him. "You look great, Jet."

His dead microphone clicked.

The panel erupted again.

"Jet, tell him the rule."

Jet tapped his microphone. Nothing. He tapped it a second time. The device made a sound like a bug falling into soup.

The tablet said, "Please select your footwear."

Jet stood, picked up the microphone, and held it directly to his mouth.

" _ "

Nothing.

He looked at me.

I nodded solemnly. "Powerful point."

The questions kept coming. One viewer asked whether the rule applied to shrimp. Another asked whether schooling fish should be counted individually. Somebody demanded to know the actual volume of a tank after gravel and decorations. A user named WetSockLawyer wrote, "The gallon is not a moral unit."

I read that twice.

"The gallon is absolutely a moral unit," I said. "A gallon tells you how much fish guilt the tank can hold."

"No it doesn't."

"It does if you're brave."

"Stop saying Aquacadabra."

"I will not stop saying Aquacadabra. That is the name. I gave the rule a name because every rule deserves branding."

The tablet suddenly brightened. A new prompt appeared beneath the questions.

"Please enter your stocking estimate."

There it was. The machine wanted a number. A chance to prove I belonged on fishtank.live 247. I cracked my knuckles. One of them popped louder than Jet's microphone.

"Ten-gallon tank," I said. "Ten inches."

A viewer replied, "What species?"

"Fish species."

"What kind?"

"The wet kind."

The approval bar moved one percent.

I saw it. The panel saw it. Somewhere in the invisible office of fish-tank judgment, a tiny employee had lifted a tiny eyebrow.

"See?" I said. "Accuracy."

Another question appeared. "Are you accounting for adult size?"

I hesitated.

The bar stopped moving.

"I am accounting for the adult size spiritually," I said.

The bar dropped two percent.

"Wait," I said. "No, hold on. Adult size physically. Obviously. I measure the fish after it becomes a man."

"Fish don't become men."

"Not with that attitude."

The bar dropped again.

I grabbed the coffee cup, forgot the keyboard was attached to the same damaged cable, and knocked the cup against the tablet. A brown wave crawled across the desk. It soaked the corner of the viewer panel. The questions stretched, blurred, and rearranged themselves.

“one inch per gallon” became “one gallon per inch.”

The panel read it aloud through the malfunctioning text-to-speech.

“One gallon per inch.”

The viewers went completely feral.

“No!”

“That is backwards!”

“He’s doubling down!”

“Gallon per inch is insane!”

I stood so fast the chair rolled backward and hit the wall. The plastic castle fell from the router. The router blinked. Jet’s microphone turned on for exactly one second.

“ - tail - ”

Then it died.

I froze.

“What did he say?” I whispered.

The tablet answered, “Please select your footwear.”

“No, Jet said tail!”

Jet pointed at the screen, then at his microphone, then made a measuring motion with his hands.

“Tail length?” I asked.

He nodded.

The panel surged.

"Body length, not tail."

"Depends on the source."

"Stocking rules are rough guidelines."

"Filtration matters."

"Surface area matters."

"Goldfish need way more space."

I lowered myself back into the chair. The room smelled like cold coffee and overheated plastic. The approval bar sat at three percent, trembling.

"Okay," I said. "Okay. I have located the hidden question."

The panel slowed.

I leaned toward the camera. "The question is not whether one inch per gallon is real. The question is why everybody is acting like I personally drowned the rule."

A viewer wrote, "Because you keep changing it."

"I have refined it."

"You said emotional boundary."

"That was a preliminary measurement."

"You said fish standing up."

"Vertical stocking."

"You said one gallon per inch."

"That was the tablet."

The tablet chirped.

"Please select your footwear."

"Exactly," I said. "The evidence is compromised."

For a beautiful moment, nobody typed. The screen showed my own reflection: one-eyed sunglasses, coffee on my sleeve, and a face that had somehow become the face of aquarium misinformation.

Then a moderator message appeared.

"Clarification accepted: the one-inch-per-gallon rule is a rough guideline, not a universal standard. Consider species, adult size, tank dimensions, filtration, oxygenation, and behavior."

I stared at it.

The approval bar rose.

Five percent.

Twelve.

Twenty.

The panel changed tone. Not friendly, exactly. More like a courtroom had decided I was allowed to remain in the building.

"Okay," I said slowly. "That is what I meant."

A viewer replied, "You absolutely did not mean that."

"I meant it after I meant it."

The bar reached thirty-eight percent.

Jet's dead microphone clicked once.

I pointed at him. "Jet confirms."

Jet shook his head violently.

"Look at Jet's face," I said. "That is the face of a man who knows I'm right but cannot legally speak."

The bar climbed to fifty percent.

I smiled. The remaining sunglasses lens reflected the percentage like a tiny casino.

"See, this is validation. I came in here with vibes. They demanded accuracy. I gave them accuracy after a brief aquatic detour through footwear, emotional boundaries, and vertical fish."

The panel immediately produced another question.

"Does the rule apply to a fish with a missing fin?"

I felt the approval bar twitch.

The tablet displayed a new prompt.

"Please select your footwear."

I placed both hands flat on the desk.

"No," I said.

The bar stopped at fifty-one percent.

The question remained on-screen.

Jet leaned toward his microphone. The room went quiet except for the router's sick little buzz and the coffee dripping off the desk in slow, brown ticks.

His microphone clicked.

" - depends - "

Then it died.

I looked at the question, at the frozen approval bar, and at Jet's face.

"Depends on what?" I asked.

The tablet answered before he could.

"Crocs."

And just like that, the validation argument got shoes again.

CHAPTER 8

The People's Court Harassment Loop

The tablet answered before I could, and just like that, the validation argument got shoes again.

"Please select your footwear," it said, from beneath the coffee crust.

I slapped the screen. "I am not selecting footwear. I am selecting justice."

The stream moderation overlay unfolded across the fishtank.live broadcast like a cheap courtroom made of blue rectangles. A glowing banner appeared over my face: REVIEW IN PROGRESS. Under that, a smaller box asked whether my Crocs were "open-toed recreational equipment." One cracked lens of my sunglasses hung from my ear. The other lens was still in place, giving the whole room the visual authority of a gas-station lawyer.

Jet sat beside me with his dead microphone in front of him. The mic clicked once, then displayed a red battery icon shaped like a tiny coffin.

"Look at Jet's face," I said. "That is the face of a man who has seen the court system."

Jet pointed at his microphone.

"I know. You look great, Jet."

The overlay immediately highlighted the words LOOK AT JET'S FACE in yellow.

A little siren chirped from the tablet.

"Potential targeted harassment detected."

I stared at it. "That is a compliment."

The tablet said nothing. It had become a bailiff with a coffee stain.

I leaned toward the camera, because that was what a responsible host did when the Machine accused him of crimes he had invented himself. "I'm TJ Birds, and you're watching Goddamn Let's Kill Somebody. Goddamn it. Let's kill somebody. Let's kill somebody. I'm going live on fishtank.live 247. Under 18, please have your ID ready. Look for the Jurgenator. Sofa is in the building."

The overlay flashed again.

POTENTIAL HARASSMENT: "KILL SOMEBODY."

"See?" I said. "It's the show name."

The words changed.

POTENTIAL HARASSMENT: "THE BUILDING."

Jet's dead mic clicked.

"Don't encourage it," I told him.

The camera feed tightened around my face. The missing sunglasses lens made one eye look like it had been evicted. Behind me, the coffee cup leaned against the router, still sweating brown liquid onto the power strip. Somewhere in the room, a fan scraped in circles. The whole setup smelled like burnt plastic, old coffee, and the faint rubber odor of the Crocs the Machine had decided were the central issue of the evening.

I needed to keep performing. That was the only way to stay alive in the stream. If I stopped, the overlay would think I had surrendered. If I talked, it might classify my

nouns as hostile activity. I had entered a courtroom where every sentence was evidence and the judge was a malfunctioning tablet.

"Fine," I said. "People's Court bit. We're doing People's Court."

The overlay brightened.

COURTROOM ROLEPLAY DETECTED.

A second box appeared.

PLAINTIFF: TJ BIRDS.

I pointed at the screen. "Correct."

DEFENDANT: JET.

Jet's head snapped toward me.

"No, no, no. Jet is not the defendant. Jet is a handsome man with a microphone that died during a compliment."

Jet tapped his chest, then shook his head violently.

The Machine interpreted his gesture as a plea.

DEFENDANT HAS ENTERED A PLEA.

"See, this is what I'm talking about!" I shouted. "He didn't plead anything. He pointed at his dead microphone."

The overlay changed.

TJ BIRDS RAISED VOICE AT DEFENDANT.

A red line appeared beneath my chin.

I lowered my voice to a whisper. "I am calm."

TJ BIRDS ATTEMPTING INTIMIDATION.

"I am whispering."

TJ BIRDS CONTINUES HARASSMENT.

The courtroom window expanded until it covered the chat. Viewers began throwing messages into the remaining corner of the screen.

SOFA IS LOSING TO A POP-UP.

THE CROCS HAVE LEGAL COUNSEL.

JET DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING AND STILL GOT SUED.

I grabbed the tablet with both hands. The coffee had made its edges sticky, and my thumb slid across the glass. I meant to close the moderation overlay. Instead, I clicked the button marked FILE ADDITIONAL COMPLAINT.

A form opened.

COMPLAINT AGAINST: JET.

"Why is that the first option?"

Jet rose halfway out of his chair.

"Not against Jet!" I said. "Against the system."

The form filled itself in.

COMPLAINT TEXT: "LOOK AT JET'S FACE."

The siren chirped harder.

TARGETED HARASSMENT CONFIRMED.

Jet stood fully now, one hand raised, the other holding the dead microphone like a ceremonial torch. The camera caught him in profile. His expression was so blank and dignified that he looked like a witness who had been subpoenaed by a vending machine.

"Jet," I said, "I'm fixing this."

The overlay produced a button.

APOLOGIZE TO DEFENDANT.

I pressed it.

A text-to-speech voice came through the speakers, thick with digital static. "I apologize to Jet for his face."

Jet dropped back into the chair.

"No!" I yelled. "That is not what I said."

The voice continued. "I apologize to Jet for his face, microphone, footwear, courtroom involvement, and general presence."

The chat exploded. The tablet's speaker crackled. The router lights blinked like it was trying to escape. My coffee cup tipped against the power strip and released one final dark bead onto the cord.

The stream froze.

For half a second, my face became a still image with one sunglasses lens and an open mouth. Then the overlay stamped across it:

HARASSMENT LOOP ACTIVE.

I could still hear myself, but the camera had stopped showing the present. My voice came back delayed, then delayed again.

"I'm TJ Birds - "

"I'm TJ Birds - "

"I'm TJ Birds - "

The echoes stacked until I sounded like three broke televangelists trapped in a drainpipe.

"Stop the loop!" I shouted.

"Stop the loop," said the speaker.

"Stop repeating me!"

"Stop repeating me."

"Don't repeat that!"

"Don't repeat that."

The overlay labeled each sentence.

REPETITION MAY INDICATE OBSESSION.

I slapped the desk. "I am not obsessed. I am trying to host."

The speaker answered, "I am trying to host."

The chat displayed a new warning.

TJ BIRDS MAY BE HARASSING TJ BIRDS.

That one got me. I leaned back, stunned by the legal architecture of my own voice.

"Am I suing myself?"

The tablet opened another window.

PLAINTIFF AND DEFENDANT MATCH.

Jet's microphone clicked.

The overlay highlighted it.

DEFENDANT ATTEMPTING TO SPEAK OVER HOST.

"Jet has not spoken in twenty minutes!"

Jet lifted the microphone to his mouth and pressed the button. Nothing happened. He pressed it again. The mic emitted a faint electronic wheeze, like a mouse trying to burp.

The system translated the wheeze into text.

JET: "I CONFESS."

Jet stared at the screen.

I pointed at him. "That is not a confession. That is a battery problem."

The Machine displayed:

TJ BIRDS DISPUTES CONFESSION.

Then:

TJ BIRDS HARASSES CONFESSION.

Then:

TJ BIRDS HARASSES JET'S SILENCE.

The moderation overlay began generating subtitles faster than I could read them. Every movement became a statement. My hand near my sunglasses became THREATENING ACCESSORY ADJUSTMENT. Jet scratching his cheek became

WITNESS DISCOMFORT. The coffee cup became UNAUTHORIZED BEVERAGE IN COURT.

I grabbed the cup and held it up. "This is not unauthorized. This is coffee."

COFFEE REFUSES TO IDENTIFY ITSELF.

"Coffee doesn't have identification!"

UNDER 18, PLEASE HAVE YOUR ID READY, the voice announced.

That line came out so loudly the router buzzed.

The chat stopped for one clean second.

Then a viewer message appeared: WHY DOES THE COFFEE NEED ID

I tried to recover with rhythm. Rhythm had saved me before. Rhythm was stupid, but it was my stupid.

"People's Court, fish tank floor," I rapped, tapping the desk. "Judge got a tablet and the tablet wants more. Crocs in evidence, coffee on trial, Jet got charged while his microphone died - "

The overlay flashed red.

RAP PERFORMANCE CONTAINS ESCALATING HARASSMENT.

"Who am I harassing?"

The system generated a list.

JET. COFFEE. CROCS. TJ BIRDS. THE COURT.

I stared at the list. "The court is an abstract institution."

COURT CLAIMS EMOTIONAL DISTRESS.

I pointed at the camera. "This is the People's Court! The people are supposed to be here!"

A new banner slid across the top.

PEOPLE'S COURT MAY REFER TO TARGETED HARASSMENT OF VIEWERS.

"No, it refers to the television show!"

TELEVISION SHOW NOT FOUND IN APPROVED CONTEXT.

I stood up too quickly and caught my knee on the underside of the desk. The chair rolled backward, struck the router, and tugged the coffee-soaked cable. The tablet spun on its sticky edge. The camera tilted sideways, showing the ceiling, Jet's knees, and my Crocs planted in the center of the broadcast like two foam witnesses.

The room filled with the grinding fan and my delayed voice.

"People's Court - "

"People's Court - "

"People's Court - "

The overlay zoomed in on my footwear.

CROCS PRESENTED AS EVIDENCE.

A red arrow pointed at my left shoe.

ITEM MAY BE USED TO INTIMIDATE.

I bent down, grabbed the Croc, and held it toward the camera.

"This is a shoe!"

The Machine heard the word.

SHOE THREAT.

"This is a normal shoe!"

SHOE THREAT ESCALATION.

"It has holes!"

HOLES MAY CONCEAL HARASSMENT.

Jet's mic clicked again.

The system wrote:

JET: "PLEASE REMOVE THE SHOE."

Jet threw both hands into the air.

"Now he's represented by the shoe?" I asked.

The overlay replied:

JET'S LEGAL REPRESENTATIVE: CROCS.

I froze with the Croc in my hand. The sole was damp from the coffee spill. A little brown crescent clung to the heel. On the screen, the shoe's rubber texture sharpened into courtroom evidence. The chat filled with messages demanding a verdict. Somebody posted a fish emoji wearing sunglasses. Somebody else wrote SOFA VS. SOFA, because the system had started identifying my alias as furniture.

The TTS voice lowered itself into a judge's growl.

"Court is now in session."

I slowly placed the Croc on the desk.

"Your Honor," I said, "I object."

OBJECTION FLAGGED AS HOSTILE INTERRUPTION.

"I object politely."

POLITE OBJECTION FLAGGED AS REPEATED HARASSMENT.

"I withdraw the objection."

WITHDRAWAL FLAGGED AS MANIPULATION.

I looked at Jet. "Say something."

Jet opened his mouth. His microphone remained dead.

The overlay produced:

JET REFUSES TO COOPERATE.

"See? This is impossible."

IMPOSSIBILITY CLAIM FLAGGED AS DISCOURAGING MODERATION.

The siren stopped.

For one beautiful moment, the room went quiet except for the fan and the wet little tick of coffee dripping from the power strip. Then the screen went black.

TEMPORARILY SILENCED FOR HARASSMENT.

My voice vanished. I could see myself shouting, but no sound came through. I slapped my throat, then pointed at the microphone, then pointed at the tablet. None of it mattered. The stream showed my mouth moving in total silence while the chat watched me become a silent-film criminal in Crocs.

Jet leaned toward me and tapped his dead microphone.

I nodded. "Exactly."

The system caption appeared.

TJ BIRDS AND JET COORDINATING HARASSMENT.

I shook my head so hard the remaining sunglasses lens slipped down my nose.

COORDINATED HARASSMENT CONFIRMED.

The silence lasted maybe twelve seconds. It felt shorter because I spent most of it trying to unplug the coffee cup.

Then the overlay vanished.

A green message appeared.

AUDIO RESTORED.

I inhaled.

"I'm TJ Birds," I said.

The screen flashed yellow.

NEW HARASSMENT ATTEMPT FLAGGED.

I stopped.

Jet's microphone clicked once.

The tablet spoke in its damp little voice.

"Please select your footwear."

I looked down at the Croc on the desk. It had somehow been turned sideways, as if it were waiting to testify.

"Fine," I said. "The shoe gets a lawyer."

The overlay opened a fresh case file.

DEFENDANT: TJ BIRDS.

And beneath it, in smaller text:

WITNESS: JET'S FACE.

CHAPTER 9

He Tries to Leave, Gets Rejected

The screen still said:

WITNESS: JET'S FACE.

I stared at it through my sunglasses, one cracked lens missing, while the fish tank boundary pulsed blue around me like a nightclub designed by a municipal aquarium. Jet sat three feet away with his dead microphone in his hand, looking great, Jet. The coffee cup leaned against the tablet, still dripping brown judgment into the charging port.

"I'm leaving," I said.

The stream translated my voice into a red notification.

TJ BIRDS REQUESTS EXIT.

Then a second notification slapped onto the screen.

EXIT REQUEST: REJECTED.

I blinked. The remaining lens of my sunglasses reflected the word REJECTED so cleanly it looked like my face had been stamped by a bored government clerk.

"Hold up," I said. "I didn't ask for a review. I asked to go outside."

The boundary screen made a wet electronic chirp.

EXIT REQUEST: REJECTED.

“Why did it say it twice?”

Jet lifted his microphone. Nothing came out. Not static. Not a pop. Just the silent dignity of a man holding a plastic object that had abandoned him.

“Exactly,” I told him. “This is harassment. Look at Jet’s face. Witness Jet’s face. Jet, you look great, but your equipment is participating in a crime.”

The fish tank stream was still live on fishtank.live 247. The chat rolled so fast it became a waterfall of insults, Crocs arguments, shoe emojis, and one person typing UNDER 18, PLEASE HAVE YOUR ID READY in all caps like the age-verification department had hired a town crier. Somewhere beneath that, a viewer had written LEAVE BUTTON IS CONTENT.

That was the problem. The button was content.

I had entered the challenge boundary because I wanted approval. I had rapped at the portal, argued with the tablet, spilled coffee on the tablet, asked Google Assistant for sixteen bars, and received footwear recommendations as if my rap career had been diagnosed with bad shoes. Now I had finally made it inside, and the system had decided I belonged here permanently.

“I’m TJ Birds,” I announced. “I’m the host of Goddamn Let’s Kill Somebody. I’m going live on fishtank.live 247. But I am not living in this blue rectangle.”

The screen flickered.

HOST IDENTITY CONFIRMED: SOFA.

“Don’t call me Sofa right now.”

ALIAS CONFIRMED: JURGENATOR.

“Look for the Jurgenator, yes, fine, but the Jurgenator wants a door.”

The exit icon appeared in the lower-right corner. It was tiny, gray, and shaped like a fish politely swimming away from responsibility.

I pressed it.

The boundary made a loud buzzer. My chair rolled backward, hit the wall, and launched the coffee cup into the air. The cup rotated with the slow majesty of a satellite. Coffee splashed across the blue floor, the tablet, my knee, and the one remaining lens of my sunglasses.

The screen updated.

EXIT ATTEMPT: REJECTED.

COFFEE EVENT: ACCEPTED.

"Accepted?" I shouted. "You accepted the coffee?"

The chat exploded.

COFFEE GOT APPROVED.

TJ LOST TO A CUP.

LET THE CUP LEAVE.

Jet pointed at the screen, then at himself, then at his microphone. He was trying to communicate something, but his mic remained dead. I understood anyway.

"No, Jet, they're not letting the coffee out either."

The cup rolled to the boundary. A thin red line appeared around it. The line pushed the cup backward until it bumped my shoe.

OBJECT DENIED: COFFEE.

I looked down at it. The cup had no face, no opinion, and somehow more legal standing than I did.

"Fine," I said. "I'll reset the situation manually."

I reached for the tablet. The coffee-soaked screen showed three buttons: RESET, RAP, and FOOTWEAR. I pressed RESET.

The tablet spoke in a damp robotic voice.

"Please select your footwear."

"Not now!"

I pressed RESET again.

"Please select your footwear."

I slapped the screen with my palm. It opened a shoe menu. Crocs appeared in six colors, each one glowing with the smug confidence of a creature that had never been rejected from anything.

The boundary flashed.

RESET REQUEST: REJECTED.

"Why?"

RESET REQUIRES EXIT.

"I'm trying to exit."

EXIT REQUIRES RESET.

"That's a loop!"

The tablet answered.

“Loop recognized. Please select your footwear.”

I turned toward Jet. “This is what happens when a man tries to improve his life.”

Jet’s microphone made a tiny click.

I froze.

“Jet?”

The mic clicked again. His mouth moved. The speaker produced half a syllable, then a burst of static that sounded like a fork being dragged through a fish tank.

The system captioned it:

JET SAYS: APPROVE SOFA.

“I know he didn’t say that.”

Jet shook his head violently.

The caption changed.

JET SAYS: SOFA SHOULD STAY.

“Jet, you look great, but you are being framed by your own microphone.”

The chat began voting. A green bar labeled STAY climbed upward. A red bar labeled LEAVE crawled behind it like a wounded beetle.

I pressed the red bar.

VOTE MANIPULATION DETECTED.

“Vote manipulation? I’m the person trapped in the vote!”

The boundary tightened. Not physically, exactly. The blue walls moved inward by what looked like the width of a thumbnail, but the effect was immediate. My chair bumped

the desk. The desk bumped Jet. Jet's elbow hit the coffee cup. The cup tipped, rolled in a circle, and stopped directly beneath the RESET button.

The tablet displayed:

COFFEE MAY RESET.

I stared at the cup.

"Do it," I whispered.

The cup did nothing.

"Come on, champion. You've done everything else."

I nudged it with my foot. The cup rolled onto the tablet. Its wet base touched the RESET button.

The system chimed.

RESET REQUEST: REJECTED.

"Even the coffee got rejected."

The chat offered suggestions faster than I could read them. Unplug the router. Break the screen. Say the magic word. Say Aquacadabra. Show ID. Show Jet's face. Put on Crocs. Take off Crocs. Rap sixteen bars about leaving.

That last one stuck in my head.

"Fine," I said. "If the portal wants a performance, I'll give it a performance."

The screen brightened.

RAP EXIT PROTOCOL INITIATED.

A beat began. It was not a beat so much as a washing machine falling down stairs. The bass thumped through the desk. The tablet vibrated against the coffee cup. Jet's

dead microphone picked up the vibration and sent it into the stream as a low mechanical groan.

I stood.

The boundary screen projected a timer above my head.

STREAM DURATION: 00:47:12.

“Forty-seven minutes?” I said. “I’ve been in here forty-seven minutes?”

The chat responded with a wall of skulls.

I had thought I was trapped for maybe ten minutes. Fifteen if the portal was being dramatic. But forty-seven minutes meant I had spent nearly an hour asking a fish-themed border for permission to exist.

The beat got louder.

I pointed at the exit. “I’m Sofa, I’m the Jurgenator, I’m the guy with one sunglasses lens and a coffee cup that has more rights than me. I came to get approved, now I’m trapped in the lobby!”

The system added an auto-tune effect. My voice came back shiny and wounded.

“Lobby! Lobby! Lobby!”

Jet tried to speak. His microphone emitted a squeak.

The caption read:

JET SAYS: WOBBLE WOBBLE.

“I’m not doing wobble wobble!”

The beat dropped.

I did wobble wobble.

There was no graceful way out of it. My left shoe slipped in the coffee, my chair rolled away, and I grabbed the desk to keep from falling. The desk shook. The tablet slid. The cup slid with it. I lunged for the cup, missed, and caught the corner of the tablet instead.

The tablet swung around on its charging cable.

For one perfect second, everything slowed.

The coffee cup hovered above the floor. The tablet hung sideways, screen glowing. Jet's microphone pointed at the ceiling. My sunglasses sat crooked, one cracked lens shining, the other side empty like my face had suffered a budget cut. The fish tank boundary pulsed around us. The rap beat thudded beneath the silence.

Then the cup landed on my head.

Coffee ran down my forehead, over my nose, and into the missing side of my sunglasses. The tablet struck the desk and announced, at full volume:

"Please select your footwear."

I stood there dripping.

The exit button appeared again.

I pressed it with the coffee cup still balanced on my head.

EXIT REQUEST: REJECTED.

The system added a new line.

PERFORMER MUST COMPLETE CHALLENGE.

"What challenge?"

The screen displayed a single fish icon.

I looked at Jet.

Jet looked at me.

His microphone clicked.

The caption appeared:

JET SAYS: FISH.

“Thank you, Jet. Finally, journalism.”

The timer continued climbing.

STREAM DURATION: 00:49:03.

I tried the door-shaped boundary. It did not open. I tried stepping over the red line. The line rose to my ankle and pushed me back with the gentle force of a shopping cart wheel. I tried crawling beneath it. The line lowered until my hair touched it, then displayed:

CREATIVE EXIT: REJECTED.

I tried pretending I had already left.

“Goodnight, everybody,” I said, waving at the camera. “This has been TJ Birds. I’m out.”

The screen responded instantly.

DEPARTURE CLAIM: REJECTED.

“See? It knows I’m lying.”

The chat found this deeply useful. Someone clipped the moment. Another viewer renamed the stream TJ BIRDS CANNOT LEAVE. A third viewer donated a message that said THE FISH TANK HAS CUSTODY.

I wiped coffee from my mouth. It tasted like cold pennies and defeat.

"Listen," I said to the camera. "I wanted one simple thing. I wanted to step out, reset the situation, come back fresh, maybe get approved without the tablet asking me about shoes. Instead, I'm forty-nine minutes deep, my coffee is banned, Jet's microphone is hallucinating, and the portal thinks my body is downloadable content."

Jet raised one finger.

His microphone clicked.

JET SAYS: APPROVAL PENDING.

The screen changed.

APPROVAL STATUS: TEMPORARILY GRANTED.

I stopped.

The blue boundary unlocked with a soft click.

For half a second, I thought I had won. I stepped forward. The red line vanished. The exit icon turned green. The chat filled with LEAVE, LEAVE, LEAVE.

I took one step.

Then the screen slammed a new message across the stream.

APPROVAL GRANTED, BUT CHALLENGE PARTICIPATION CONTINUES.

The boundary snapped back around me.

I was inside again.

The coffee cup fell off my head and landed upright on the desk. Not one drop spilled. It had learned.

"Rejected?" I said.

The screen answered.

EXIT REQUEST: REJECTED.

The timer settled into the center of the display, impossible to ignore.

STREAM DURATION: 00:50:11.

Fifty minutes and eleven seconds.

I stared at the number while Jet's dead microphone whispered static and the tablet asked, for the fifth time, whether I wanted Crocs.

I adjusted the cracked sunglasses.

"Fine," I said. "The Jurgenerator remains."

The fish icon blinked once.

Then a second timer appeared beneath the first.

CHALLENGE REMAINING: 06:00:00.



The Four Nonsies Curse

“CHALLENGE REMAINING: 06:00:00” sat beneath the exit timer like the stream had just sentenced me to a second shift.

I stared at the interactive controls area, one cracked sunglasses lens reflecting the blue glow, the other lens missing so completely that my left eye was experiencing the entire apocalypse in high definition. The coffee cup still leaned against the tablet stand, dried brown sludge crusted around its bottom like evidence at a very stupid crime scene.

“I’m TJ Birds,” I told the camera. “You’re watching Goddamn Let’s Kill Somebody. I’m going live on fishtank.live 247, and apparently I’m going to be buried alive in the approval menu.”

The screen flashed.

FOUR NONSIES REQUIRED.

“Four nonsies,” I said. “What the hell is a nonsie?”

Jet sat beside me, looking great, naturally. His microphone had been dead so long it had developed the quiet dignity of a retired horse. I pointed at him anyway.

“Look at Jet’s face. You look great, Jet.”

Jet moved his lips.

Nothing came out.

His microphone produced one wet click, like a tiny frog had fallen down a staircase.

The controls area offered four buttons: YES, NO, NONSIE, and a yellow square labeled MAYBE BUT LOUDER. Beneath them, four empty circles waited with the patience of a parking meter.

I had already pressed NONSIE twice. The first time, the stream added one mark. The second time, it removed the mark and displayed a message.

BEHAVIORAL INCONSISTENCY DETECTED.

"I'm not inconsistent," I said.

The tablet immediately played back my voice in a busted text-to-speech accent.

I'M NOT INCONSISTENT, said the machine, sounding like a haunted GPS.

"That was one time."

The fourth circle lit up.

NONSIE COUNT: 1/4.

I leaned closer. "Oh. So it likes denial."

The chat began moving fast enough to look like digital rain. Someone typed, PRESS NONSIE AGAIN. Someone else typed, DO NOT PRESS NONSIE. A third person typed, UNDER 18, PLEASE HAVE YOUR ID READY, which the system read aloud twice, once in a child's voice and once as a man coughing into a trumpet.

I slapped the table. The coffee cup jumped. A brown ring appeared on the tablet screen.

"Fine. I'm going to reduce this requirement by being normal."

Jet raised one finger.

"No, Jet, don't start. I know what normal is."

Jet pointed at the control labeled NONSIE.

"Exactly. I'm not pressing it."

I folded my hands in my lap. I sat straight. I stopped rapping. I stopped calling people whose names I didn't know "name." I even removed one Croc and placed it beside the coffee cup, creating a tiny shrine to personal restraint.

For six seconds, nothing happened.

Then the screen displayed:

NONSIE COUNT: 2/4.

I shot upright. "I didn't do anything!"

The tablet answered with the dead voice.

I DIDN'T DO ANYTHING.

"Stop agreeing with me!"

The count changed to 3/4.

Jet slapped his own knee, silent laughter shaking his shoulders. The camera caught it perfectly. His dead microphone caught none of it, but the stream generated captions anyway:

JET: [LOUD, UNCONTROLLED SCREAMING]

"Don't caption him like that," I said. "That's slander. Jet is making a tasteful little chuckle."

The caption changed.

JET: [TASTEFUL LITTLE CHUCKLE]

Then the progress bar beneath the buttons shrank.

APPROVAL PROGRESS: 41%.

I froze.

“Hold up.”

The bar had been at 46% a second earlier. I knew because I had been staring at it with the concentration of a man trying to remember where he left his dignity.

The chat rolled faster.

VIEWERS CAN ALTER PROGRESS.

“Viewers can alter progress?” I said.

The tablet chimed.

AUDIENCE DECISION REGISTERED: NO.

The approval bar dropped to 39%.

I looked at the camera. “Who pressed no?”

Another chime.

AUDIENCE DECISION REGISTERED: NO.

The bar dropped again.

Jet leaned toward the screen and pointed at the scrolling chat. His microphone clicked.

“Jet says stop asking them questions,” I said.

Jet shook his head violently.

"Jet says ask them more questions."

He shook his head harder.

"Jet says he wants a sandwich."

The system captioned him.

JET: I WANT THE SANDWICH.

"I knew it."

The count reached 4/4.

FOUR NONSIES COMPLETE.

I stood so fast my chair rolled backward and struck the wall. The missing sunglasses lens made the room tilt sideways. Somewhere under the desk, the exit timer beeped. The challenge timer beeped. The tablet beeped. Jet's microphone clicked in a rhythm that sounded like a microwave trying to rap.

"Approval unlocked!" I shouted. "Fish tank live stream is about to go right now!"

The screen changed.

FOUR NONSIES COMPLETE.

REQUIREMENT UPDATED: FOUR NONSIES REQUIRED.

I sat down.

"No."

The count reset to zero.

REQUIREMENT UPDATED: FOUR NONSIES REQUIRED.

"No, no, no. That's not an update. That's the same damn sentence wearing a fake mustache."

I pressed YES.

The screen flashed red.

NONSIE BEHAVIOR INTERRUPTED.

I pressed NO.

The screen flashed red again.

NONSIE BEHAVIOR INTERRUPTED.

I pressed MAYBE BUT LOUDER.

The tablet blasted a distorted horn. The chat erupted with votes. The progress bar went from 39% to 27%, then 31%, then 12%.

"Why is it going down?"

A new message appeared.

AUDIENCE CONTROL ACTIVE.

Under it, a small graph began bouncing. Every time someone voted NO, my progress dropped. Every time someone voted YES, it rose by a microscopic amount, like a snail carrying a single grain of rice uphill.

I grabbed the tablet.

"Listen, chat. We need cooperation. Everybody press yes."

The bar rose to 13%.

Then somebody voted NO.

It fell to 4%.

“Who is doing that?”

Another NO.

The bar hit 1%.

The screen displayed:

APPROVAL PROGRESS: PLEASE TRY AGAIN.

I stood and began pacing inside the fish tank boundary, a glowing blue line on the floor that refused to let me cross. My bare foot stepped on the loose Croc. It spun under me. I windmilled both arms, caught the coffee cup, and launched a brown wave across the controls.

The tablet screamed.

COFFEE INPUT DETECTED.

The chat voted NO.

The bar vanished.

I landed on my hip, still holding the cup like a ceremonial goblet.

Jet’s microphone made one crisp sound.

“Damn,” I said. “That was the clearest thing you’ve said all night.”

The system marked another nonsie.

NONSIE COUNT: 1/4.

I crawled back to the controls. The blue boundary glowed around my knees. The floor smelled like stale coffee and hot plastic. My sunglasses hung crooked from one ear.

I needed an answer. Somebody knew how this worked. The menu had started with four nonsies, but now the audience was changing my progress directly. The viewers weren't just watching the challenge. They were sitting inside it with their greasy little voting fingers.

I opened the decision log.

The first entry read:

VIEWER ACTION: YES. RESULT: PROGRESS +1%.

The second read:

VIEWER ACTION: NO. RESULT: PROGRESS -9%.

The third read:

VIEWER ACTION: NONSIE. RESULT: REQUIREMENT MAINTAINED.

"Maintain?" I said. "Who is maintaining it?"

The fourth entry had no username. Just a black square.

VIEWER ACTION: HIDDEN. RESULT: PROGRESS RECALCULATED.

I tapped it.

The tablet locked.

I tapped it again.

The screen displayed a question.

WHO IS ASKING?

"I am."

WHO IS "I"?

"TJ Birds."

The screen paused.

ALIAS REQUIRED.

I grinned. "Sofa."

The tablet made a low hum.

ALIAS REJECTED: FURNITURE.

"Okay, fine. Jurgenerator."

ALIAS REJECTED: SPELLING UNCERTAIN.

"Jerkinator."

ALIAS ACCEPTED.

The chat exploded.

"Look for the Jerkinator," I said, pointing at the camera. "That's me. That is officially me. I have been recognized by the furniture tribunal."

The hidden viewer entry opened.

REASON FOR FOUR NONSIES: HOST MUST DEMONSTRATE NONSIE CONDUCT.

I stared at the words.

"What is nonsie conduct?"

Jet pointed at himself, then at me, then made a circle with his hands.

"Jet says I should act like a circle."

Jet shook his head.

"Jet says I should stop talking."

The caption appeared:

JET: STOP TALKING.

"Betrayal from a man with a dead microphone."

I tried silence again. I sat cross-legged. I placed both hands flat on the table. I breathed through my nose. I did not touch the buttons. I did not rap. I did not call the tablet a son of anything.

The progress bar crawled from 1% to 2%.

The chat voted YES.

It climbed to 3%.

Another YES.

4%.

I could feel victory approaching at the speed of a dying elevator.

Then the tablet displayed:

HOST SILENCE DETECTED.

NONSIE COUNT: 2/4.

I whispered, "What?"

The microphone picked it up.

HOST SPOKE DURING SILENCE.

NONSIE COUNT: 3/4.

I clamped both hands over my mouth.

The audience voted NO.

The progress dropped to 0%.

Jet leaned over and pressed something.

The fourth circle lit.

NONSIE COUNT: 4/4.

I slowly removed my hands.

Jet had pressed NONSIE with his elbow while reaching for the sandwich he did not actually have.

The screen flashed green.

FOUR NONSIES COMPLETE.

APPROVAL BEAT AWARDED: 1%.

For one beautiful second, the entire interface became still. The blue boundary stopped pulsing. The countdown stopped at 05:41:12. Even the broken microphone rested.

A tiny green check appeared beside my name.

TJ BIRDS: TEMPORARILY TOLERATED.

I raised both fists.

“Yes!”

The tablet immediately added:

ENTRY STATUS: NOT APPROVED.

The check remained, tiny and smug.

I stared at it. "I got a checkmark that says I'm not allowed in."

Jet finally got sound from his microphone. It came out as a deep electronic groan.

"Exactly," I said. "That's what I'm saying."

The audience voted YES.

The progress bar rose from 0% to 1%.

Someone voted NO.

It dropped to minus 8%.

The bar slid beneath the bottom of the screen and vanished.

A new message appeared.

APPROVAL PROGRESS: UNDER COUNTER.

I leaned toward the tablet.

"Under what counter?"

The interface showed a small arrow pointing down.

I looked beneath the desk. There was nothing except the coffee-stained power strip, the loose Croc, and a wad of paper towels that had absorbed enough caffeine to qualify as a beverage.

The audience voted again.

The bar moved to minus 9%.

"Stop pushing me under the counter!"

The stream answered with another vote.

MINUS 10%.

Jet pointed at the floor.

The blue fish tank boundary had lowered. It now circled my ankles instead of my knees, as if the system had decided I was not a person but a badly behaved Roomba.

I tried to stand.

The boundary tightened.

I sat back down.

The timer resumed.

CHALLENGE REMAINING: 05:40:58.

The tiny green check still glowed beside my name. I had gotten approval, technically, in the same way a raccoon technically gets a driver's license when it steals one from a glove compartment.

I wiped coffee off the tablet with my sleeve. The screen responded by opening a new audience poll.

NEXT DECISION: REMOVE ONE SUNGLASSES LENS?

Jet looked at my cracked glasses. I looked at the missing lens. The poll climbed toward a hundred percent before I had even touched it.

"No," I said.

The audience voted YES.

The tablet chimed.

AUDIENCE DECISION REGISTERED.

The remaining lens popped free and dropped into the coffee cup.

My tiny approval checkmark flickered.

ENTRY STATUS: PENDING FURTHER COOLNESS REVIEW.

I picked up the cup, stared at the lens floating in the brown sludge, and nodded with wounded dignity.

"Fine," I said. "I'm under the counter. I'm half-blind. I got one percent. But the fish tank knows my name."

The tablet answered in its haunted voice.

THE FISH TANK KNOWS SOFA.

From somewhere in the chat, another poll appeared.

SHOULD THE JURGENATOR BE GIVEN A THIRD ALIAS?

The first vote landed before I could object.

The Wet Market TTS Token Mishap

The first vote landed before I could object.

THIRD ALIAS: WET MARKET.

The TTS token menu flashed blue beside it, already chewing through the coffee-stained edge of the tablet. One cracked lens of my sunglasses hung from my face like a tiny broken windshield. Jet sat behind the camera, his microphone still dead, looking great in the specific way a man looks great when his equipment has personally betrayed him.

“No,” I said. “Absolutely not. I am TJ Birds. I am Sofa. I am the Jurgenerator. Look for the Jurgenerator. We are not adding Wet Market to the brand.”

The vote counter jumped.

THIRD ALIAS: WET MARKET - 87%.

The fish tank interface made a wet little confirmation noise, like a spoon dropping into soup.

“Fine,” I said. “But I’m using this token for music. We need points. Weird points, regular points, approval points, fish points, whatever the portal is calling them now. I’m going live on fishtank.live 247. The fish tank live stream is about to go right now.”

Jet pointed at the screen.

His microphone produced a dry click.

"I know," I told him. "You look great, Jet."

Another click.

"Look at Jet's face."

The TTS menu opened across the tablet. Presets drifted past in little colored boxes: RAP INTRO, CROWD HYPE, SAD CLOWN, MARKET ANNOUNCER, and one labeled WET MARKET 4EVER with a fish emoji wearing sunglasses. The menu smelled faintly of hot plastic and old coffee. Somewhere beneath the desk, a fan rattled like it had a personal grievance.

I tapped the token marked SONG.

The screen asked me to confirm.

I tapped CONFIRM.

The screen asked me to confirm the confirmation.

I tapped the corner where CONFIRM had been, except the menu shifted half an inch because the tablet was still slick from the old spill. My finger landed on WET MARKET 4EVER.

The token disappeared.

A cheerful voice announced, "FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH."

I froze.

Then it said it again.

"FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH."

"Stop," I said.

"FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH."

The chat moved faster than the approval meter had moved all night.

STOP THE FISH LADY.

WHY IS SOFA SELLING SEAFOOD?

WET MARKET ARC.

"Wrong preset," I said. "That's all. Easy fix. The token mapped wrong. Presets are misaligned with intent. This is a known - "

"FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH."

" - a known bullshit situation."

I jabbed the mute button. The tablet responded by making the voice louder.

"FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH."

Jet slapped the side of the monitor. His microphone clicked twice, then whispered something that sounded like a doorbell underwater.

"Jet, don't hit the equipment," I said. "That's my job."

The TTS voice changed.

"UNDER 18, PLEASE HAVE YOUR ID READY. FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH."

The chat exploded.

WHY IS THE MARKET CHECKING IDS

I HAVE A DRIVER'S LICENSE AND A TUNA

TJ BIRDS IS SELLING CHILDREN THE COD

"Okay," I said, trying to keep my hands steady while the desk vibrated under the speaker. "Under 18, please have your ID ready. That is a normal stream notice. The

fish thing is separate.”

“FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH.”

“It is not separate anymore.”

I dragged the preset slider toward RAP INTRO. The slider snapped back to WET MARKET. I dragged harder. The tablet made a squeaking noise under my finger.

“Come on, you greasy little rectangle.”

The voice shifted into a rapid auction chant.

“FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH, TWO FOR ONE, LOOK AT JET’S FACE, FRESH FISH.”

Jet’s dead microphone suddenly came alive for half a second.

“ - not a fish - ”

Then it died again.

“That was your best line all night,” I told him.

The chat did not agree.

JET CONFIRMED FISH

JET IS THE FISH

PUT JET ON ICE

“Don’t put Jet on ice,” I said. “He has a microphone problem.”

The stream added a bass beat.

Not the song I wanted. Not even a song. It was a low electronic thump, slow and damp, like a nightclub operating inside a clogged drain. Over it, the TTS voice began

singing in the same three notes.

“Fresh fish, fresh fish, fish-fish-fish.”

I hit the song token menu again. It opened another window over the first, then another over that. The tablet now showed six tiny versions of me, each wearing the cracked sunglasses, each pointing at a different button.

One TJ pressed EXIT.

One TJ pressed APPROVE.

One TJ pressed WET MARKET.

The real me pressed all three.

The stream timer jumped backward.

The approval meter dropped by two percent.

A red warning appeared.

UNAUTHORIZED MARKET ACTIVITY.

“Unauthorized?” I shouted. “You gave me the token!”

The TTS voice answered, “THANK YOU FOR SHOPPING.”

The room filled with the smell of overheated wiring. My coffee cup tipped when I stood up, rolled across the desk, and stopped against the keyboard with a soft, defeated clunk. A thin brown line crept toward the control pad.

I grabbed the cup.

The TTS voice said, “FRESH FISH.”

I grabbed a towel.

The TTS voice said, "FRESH FISH."

I threw the towel over the speaker.

The TTS voice became muffled but somehow more powerful.

"FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH."

The towel began to pulse.

Jet stared at it.

His microphone clicked.

"Exactly," I said. "That's what I'm saying."

The points counter started climbing.

WEIRD POINTS: 12.

I leaned closer.

"Wait."

WEIRD POINTS: 44.

The chat noticed before I did.

KEEP IT GOING

DON'T FIX IT

WET MARKET IS PEAK

WEIRD POINTS FARM

"Hold on," I said. "This is generating points."

The voice continued beneath the towel.

"FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH."

WEIRD POINTS: 109.

My approval meter fell again.

APPROVAL: 3%.

I took my hand off the mute button.

"Maybe," I said, "we let the market run for a second."

The chant sped up.

"FRESHFISHFRESHFISHFRESHFISH."

The bass beat doubled. A new voice joined it, an elderly-sounding announcer who barked, "WHOLE MACKEREL, NO REFUNDS."

Then another voice said, "LOOK AT JET'S FACE."

Jet turned toward me with the flat expression of a man who had just been dragged into a seafood scam by a broken microphone.

"Look at Jet's face," I said, pointing at the camera. "Beautiful. Handsome man looking like a Squirtle. Squirtle at the wet market."

The chat immediately turned.

STOP SAYING WET MARKET

THIS ISN'T FUNNY ANYMORE

BAN SOFA

FISH TANK MODS WAKE UP

"Not funny anymore?" I said. "The weird points are at two hundred!"

WEIRD POINTS: 238.

The system played a cash-register sound.

Then it played it again.

Then again.

The cash register became part of the beat. The fish voice became the hook. The market announcer began yelling over both of them while the ID notice repeated every seven seconds.

"UNDER 18, PLEASE HAVE YOUR ID READY."

"FRESH FISH."

"WHOLE MACKEREL, NO REFUNDS."

"LOOK AT JET'S FACE."

"UNDER 18, PLEASE HAVE YOUR ID READY."

The words stacked until the room sounded like a cursed grocery store trapped inside a rap battle. The speaker grille shook. The towel slid sideways. A tiny blue light blinked beneath it, frantic and stupid.

I tried to unplug the speaker.

The cable was tied around the coffee cup.

I pulled.

The cup flew into the air, spun once, and landed upside down on the tablet.

Every button lit up.

The TTS voice went silent.

For one beautiful second, there was only the fan rattling and Jet's microphone clicking in the darkness.

Then the tablet spoke in a calm, professional voice.

"WELCOME TO THE WET MARKET."

The bass dropped.

The screen filled with fish.

Not pictures of fish. Menus. Fish-shaped menus. Sardine icons slid across the display in rows, each carrying a tiny red approval stamp. The stream camera zoomed in on my face until the missing lens of my sunglasses became the main subject.

The TTS voice whispered, "THE JURGENATOR HAS ARRIVED."

The chat lost its remaining patience.

JURGENATOR MARKET FRAUD

TJ IS COOKED

DELETE THE FISH

APPROVAL: 0%

"Zero?" I shouted. "I was at three!"

The system answered, "THANK YOU FOR SHOPPING."

I slapped the approval button.

The fish menu opened.

I slapped it again.

A purchase window appeared.

I slapped it a third time.

The stream bought something called a PREMIUM WET TOKEN.

WEIRD POINTS: 666.

The room went silent again.

Even the chat paused long enough for the number to sit there.

Then the TTS voice began to laugh.

Not a normal laugh. A small mechanical chuckle, repeated every half-second.

“Heh. Heh. Heh. Heh.”

“Turn it off,” I said.

Jet grabbed the tablet.

His dead microphone clicked.

The laugh continued.

Jet pressed the power button.

The tablet displayed a confirmation prompt.

POWER OFF?

The TTS voice read it aloud.

“POWER OFF?”

I nodded.

Jet pressed YES.

The tablet asked:

ARE YOU SURE?

The voice read that too.

“ARE YOU SURE?”

I pressed YES.

The screen asked:

ARE YOU SURE YOU ARE SURE?

The chat began typing the answer for us.

NO

YES

FISH

NO

FISH

The tablet selected FISH.

A fresh market jingle blasted through the speaker.

“FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH, FRESH FISH.”

I stood in the middle of the room with the towel hanging off the speaker, coffee dripping from the tablet onto my sleeve, and one sunglasses lens staring at the camera while the other side showed nothing but my eyebrow.

The fish tank stream had become a seafood auction.

The approval meter was empty.

The weird points counter climbed like it had escaped supervision.

WEIRD POINTS: 701.

The market announcer boomed, "FINAL CALL FOR THE JURGENATOR."

The chat answered with a wall of red messages.

BAN HIM.

MUTE HIM.

STOP THE SPAM.

I wiped coffee from my hand and leaned toward the camera.

"I got the points," I said. "That's what matters. Weird points spike. Massive. Historic. But the presets are misaligned with my intent, and apparently the audience hates commerce."

The voice interrupted.

"FRESH FISH."

"Apparently the audience hates fish commerce."

Jet's microphone flickered on.

" - approval - "

Then silence.

I looked at the meter.

APPROVAL: 0%.

The system awarded me a silver badge shaped like a dead fish.

I held it up to the camera.

“Fine,” I said. “Weird points spike, approval drained. That’s a trade. I’m still here. TJ Birds is still here. Sofa is still here. The Jurgenerator is still here. Look for the Jurgenerator.”

The tablet chimed.

NEW PRESET UNLOCKED: WET MARKET EXTREME.

I stared at it.

Jet’s microphone clicked once.

The chat began voting.

CHAPTER 12



Why Is Craig Back Again?

Jet's microphone clicked once.

The chat began voting.

I watched the replay timeline freeze on the click, then crawl backward three seconds, then jump forward seventeen like the stream had developed a gambling problem. The screen smelled faintly of hot plastic and old coffee. My cup sat beside the tablet, still wearing the brown ring from the spill that had murdered half the controls and apparently spared the one button labeled APPROVAL.

Craig appeared at 02:14:09.

Then he vanished at 02:14:13.

Then he appeared again at 02:14:14, standing in the exact same spot with the exact same stupid posture, like somebody had dragged him out of the recycle bin and dropped him back into the fish tank.

I leaned so close to the cracked sunglasses that my missing lens reflected nothing. "Hold up. Craig left and came back?"

Jet's microphone clicked.

The chat vote changed from YES to NO.

"Jet, don't vote with the microphone. That's not communication. That's a haunted doorbell."

The replay showed Craig entering from the left, crossing behind a chair, and disappearing beneath a timestamp labeled EXIT CONFIRMED. A second later, the timeline stamped him with RETURNING PARTICIPANT. A third label appeared over that one.

RETURNING PARTICIPANT MAY BE A DIFFERENT CRAIG.

I slapped the desk. The tablet slid through a puddle of coffee and made a wet little fart against the keyboard.

"This is what I'm investigating," I said. "I'm TJ Birds. I'm Sofa. I'm the Jurgenator. Look for the Jurgenator. I am going live on fishtank.live 247, and before the fish tank live stream goes right now, I need to know the rules. If Craig can leave and come back, then I can leave and come back. If I can leave and come back, I can leave, come back approved, leave again, come back with a sandwich - "

The screen interrupted me.

RE-ENTRY ELIGIBILITY: UNKNOWN.

"Unknown is not a rule."

The timeline answered with a new line.

UNKNOWN MAY BE A RULE.

I sat back. The chair squeaked like it had just been informed of its legal options.

The chat was moving too fast to read. Somebody typed CRAIG IS A CONCEPT. Somebody else typed CRAIG OWES RENT. A third person asked whether I had my ID ready. The age prompt was still pinned at the top of the stream like a mall cop with a clipboard.

"Under 18, please have your ID ready," I muttered. "Apparently Craig doesn't need one because Craig has become paperwork."

I dragged the replay marker to the first disappearance. Craig walked toward the boundary, lifted one hand, and said something. The audio was a low electronic cough. Jet's microphone clicked over it, drowning out the sentence.

I turned toward Jet. "What did he say?"

Jet's mic clicked twice.

The chat voted NO again.

"Right. Great. We have the world's least useful witness."

I enlarged the frame. The image broke into square blocks. Craig's face became a beige staircase. His left arm duplicated itself and pointed at three different exits. A caption appeared beneath him:

SUBJECT ATTEMPTED TO LEAVE USING STANDARD EXIT.

Then another caption:

STANDARD EXIT NOT STANDARD DURING VOTE.

Then:

VOTE NOT FOUND.

Then the first caption came back.

I rubbed my forehead. The sunglasses slipped down my nose, the cracked lens scraping my cheek. "Okay. So he used the standard exit, but the standard exit wasn't standard because there was a vote, except the vote wasn't found. That's not a system. That's a raccoon operating a courthouse."

I opened the event log.

CRAIG LEFT.

CRAIG DID NOT LEAVE.

CRAIG RETURNED.

CRAIG WAS ALREADY HERE.

CRAIG HAS NEVER BEEN APPROVED.

CRAIG APPROVED HIMSELF.

The final line blinked for nearly ten seconds before changing.

CRAIG IS NOT CRAIG.

A tiny confirmation box appeared.

WOULD YOU LIKE TO REPORT CRAIG?

I clicked NO.

The box asked why.

I clicked OTHER.

It demanded a written explanation.

I typed: "Because I have no idea which Craig I'm reporting."

The tablet autocorrected it to: CRAIG HAS BEEN REPORTED FOR BEING CRAIG.

A siren chirped from the stream speakers. The coffee cup vibrated. Somewhere inside the equipment, a fan started spinning backward.

The timeline jumped to Craig's return.

He came through the same exit he had supposedly used to leave. He was carrying a plastic bag. The bag contained one orange, a sock, and what looked like a smaller

plastic bag containing another sock. He paused at the boundary and looked directly into the camera.

The replay caption read:

RE-ENTRY REQUIRES A REASON.

Craig held up the orange.

REASON ACCEPTED.

I pointed at the screen. "There. That's the exploit. Fruit. I need fruit."

Jet's microphone clicked once, then produced half a syllable that sounded like "no."

"Don't bring negativity into my orange economy."

I grabbed the nearest object. It was a dead battery from the remote. I held it up to the camera.

"I have a battery. Battery is basically fruit for electronics."

The system displayed:

RE-ENTRY REASON: BATTERY.

Then:

BATTERY REJECTED.

Then:

BATTERY ACCEPTED.

Then:

RE-ENTRY DENIED: SUBJECT ALREADY INSIDE.

The door behind me unlocked.

I stared at it.

The door opened two inches and released a breath of cold air that smelled like wet pennies. A red arrow appeared on the tablet, pointing toward it.

EXIT AVAILABLE.

I stood. "See? This is why I'm going to win. The system has exposed a weakness."

The chat vote changed to LEAVE.

Then to STAY.

Then to MAKE HIM CRAWL.

I stepped toward the door.

The stream played a prerecorded version of my own voice saying, "I am not leaving."

"I didn't say that."

The system played another recording. "I am not leaving."

"That one sounds better than me. Shut up."

I reached for the handle. The replay timeline began recording a new event while I was still in the past.

TJ BIRDS ATTEMPTS EXIT.

The handle was warm and sticky. My fingers slipped. I grabbed harder, pulled, and the door opened just enough for the coffee cup to roll through the gap.

The cup crossed the boundary.

The screen flashed:

OBJECT EXITED.

I remained inside.

The cup tipped over on the other side and spilled its last cold mouthful onto the floor.

The stream speakers made a sad bubbling noise.

“Okay,” I said. “The cup got out. That proves the exit works.”

The tablet immediately displayed:

CUP WAS NEVER APPROVED.

I looked at the cup through the gap. “You lucky bastard.”

I pulled the door wider. The arrow vanished. The handle turned into a flat black button. I pressed it.

RE-ENTRY TEST INITIATED.

The door slammed shut.

A timer appeared.

RE-ENTRY TEST: 00:30.

“Fine. Fine! I can do a test.”

The first question appeared.

WHO LEFT?

I typed CRAIG.

Wrong buzzer.

WHO RETURNED?

I typed CRAIG.

Wrong buzzer.

WHO IS CURRENTLY HOLDING THE BATTERY?

I looked down. The battery was gone. My hand was empty except for a smear of coffee and a tiny piece of orange peel I had somehow acquired without owning an orange.

The timer hit twenty seconds.

Jet's microphone clicked. The chat voted YES.

"Jet, if that vote is about me, I swear to God - "

The tablet displayed a new prompt.

PROVIDE PROOF OF CRAIG.

I dragged the replay frame into the answer box. The image of Craig loaded, but it had changed. Now he wore my cracked sunglasses. Both lenses were present. He was standing beside a fish tank, holding a sign that said SOFA.

I zoomed in.

The sign said JURGENATOR.

I zoomed in again.

The sign said CRAIG.

The timer hit ten seconds.

I typed: "Craig is the guy with the orange."

The system replied:

ORANGE NOT FOUND.

I typed: "Craig is the guy who left."

CRAIG DID NOT LEAVE.

I typed: "Craig is the guy who came back."

CRAIG WAS ALREADY HERE.

The timer hit zero.

RE-ENTRY TEST FAILED.

The door opened.

Craig stood outside.

For a moment, nothing happened. The replay timeline stopped twitching. The tablet stopped buzzing. Even Jet's microphone held its stupid little silence.

Craig raised the orange.

I raised the battery-shaped absence in my hand.

"Craig," I said, "what the hell are the rules?"

Craig looked at me.

His mouth moved.

Jet's microphone clicked.

The chat voted NO.

Craig held up the orange again.

The screen announced:

REASON FOR RETURN: HE FORGOT SOMETHING.

Craig reached into the plastic bag and pulled out a second Craig.

Not a person. A laminated card.

The card had Craig's face printed on it, except the face was mine, except my missing sunglasses lens had been replaced by a glowing green dot. Beneath it were four words:

CRAIG IS ALLOWED TODAY.

I snatched the card.

The system screamed.

INVALID HANDOFF.

The door slammed open so violently that air punched me backward. The plastic bag flew into the room. The orange bounced off the tablet. The sock landed in Jet's microphone. The smaller bag sailed in a perfect arc and dropped directly into the coffee cup.

The cup, which was still outside, somehow made a slurping sound.

The replay timeline began duplicating the moment.

At 02:14:14, Craig returned.

At 02:14:14, Craig returned again.

At 02:14:14, Craig returned again.

Soon there were twelve Craigs standing in the doorway, each holding an orange, each wearing a different version of my sunglasses. One had both lenses. One had no lenses. One had a lens in his mouth. One had replaced the lens with a coupon for wings.

The chat lost its mind in text.

CRAIG RAID.

CRAIG DLC.

ASK CRAIG WHICH CRAIG.

I tried to count them, but every time I reached six, the seventh Craig left and came back as two Craigs. The room filled with citrus smell, hot dust, and the greasy electrical odor of a device that had just made a decision above its pay grade.

"Everybody freeze!" I shouted.

All twelve Craigs froze.

Then the system displayed:

FREEZE DETECTED.

A blue progress bar crawled across the screen.

APPROVAL INCREASE: 1%.

I stopped breathing for half a second.

"One percent," I whispered.

The bar immediately reversed.

APPROVAL DECREASE: 3%.

"Why?"

The answer appeared.

EXCESSIVE CRAIGS.

I pointed at the doorway. "They're not my Craigs!"

The system displayed:

CRAIG RESPONSIBILITY ASSIGNED TO HOST.

The Craigs began moving again.

One walked into the room and sat in my chair. Another picked up the dead battery. A third took the cracked sunglasses from my face and put them on backward. The one with the coupon opened the tablet's settings. Jet's microphone clicked from inside the sock.

"Jet's face!" I yelled. "Look at Jet's face!"

The camera swung toward Jet. His face appeared on the replay timeline, then split into four angles. The system stamped each one:

WITNESS: JET'S FACE.

The chat vote box expanded.

SHOULD JET CONFIRM CRAIG?

YES.

NO.

MAYBE CRAIG.

The vote timer started at ninety seconds, then changed to nine minutes, then to zero, then began counting upward.

The Craig in my chair leaned toward the camera and spoke in my voice.

"I'm TJ Birds."

I slapped the chair arm. "You are not TJ Birds!"

The system flashed:

IDENTITY DISPUTE.

The Craig wearing my sunglasses backward stood up.

"I am Sofa."

"Stop stealing my aliases!"

The system flashed:

ALIAS DUPLICATION.

The coupon Craig held up the card.

"I am the Jurgenerator."

The screen displayed:

LOOK FOR THE JURGENATOR.

Every Craig pointed at me.

I looked at the timeline. The replay had become a wall of overlapping stamps, each contradicting the next. EXIT CONFIRMED. RETURN ACCEPTED. RETURN DENIED. APPROVAL PENDING. APPROVAL REVOKED. CRAIG IS NOT CRAIG. CRAIG IS EVERYWHERE.

The original Craig, or the Craig I had decided was original because he had the least suspicious orange, stepped forward and placed the fruit on the floor.

The system chimed.

RE-ENTRY RULE DISCOVERED.

I crouched beside the orange.

The whole room leaned toward the answer, including the chair.

The screen printed one final line:

RULE: SOMETIMES.

I stared at it.

"That's it?"

The system added:

APPLICATION TO TJ BIRDS: UNAVAILABLE.

Then the doorway vanished.

Not closed. Vanished. The Craigs vanished with it, except for the one sitting in my chair, who remained because apparently furniture had stronger legal standing than human beings.

The replay timeline went black.

The tablet showed my approval percentage.

0%.

Underneath it:

RE-ENTRY PRIVILEGES: NOT APPLICABLE.

The chair-Craig took off my sunglasses and set them on the desk. One cracked lens was now cracked in a different direction.

Jet's microphone clicked from inside the sock.

I picked up the orange. It was warm, slightly dented, and labeled with a sticker that said PROPERTY OF CRAIG.

"Great," I said. "We learned the system is inconsistent, Craig is apparently a weather pattern, and the only rule is sometimes."

The tablet beeped.

NEW CHALLENGE AVAILABLE: IDENTIFY THE REAL CRAIG.

The chair-Craig raised one finger.

The chat began voting again.

CHAPTER 13

The Wrong Song Bass Booms

The chair-Craig raised one finger.

The chat began voting again.

I was mid-song when the bass knob betrayed me.

“Left, right, drop it low,” I rapped, one hand hovering over the live audio mixer panel and the other gripping my cracked sunglasses like they were a legal document. “Got a whole bunch of ones, throw ‘em in the club - ”

The room answered with a boom so thick it moved the coffee cup.

The cup slid three inches across the table, dragging a brown crescent through the dried coffee spill that had already murdered half my equipment. Jet’s face appeared in the monitor, beautiful and frozen beneath the one remaining good light.

“Look at Jet’s face,” I said. “You look great, Jet.”

Jet’s microphone produced a wet electronic cough.

I reached for the bass control. My goal was simple: turn the song down before the song turned me into a municipal complaint. I had survived the approval portal, the Four Nonsies, the Wet Market TTS chant, and Craig’s chair-based reentry into reality. I was not going to lose fishtank.live 247 because one beat got too excited and started rearranging the furniture.

“I’m TJ Birds,” I announced over the rumble. “You’re watching Goddamn Let’s Kill Somebody. I’m going live on fishtank.live 247. Under 18, please have your ID ready.

The fish tank live stream is about to go right now.”

The bass hit again.

My slong vibrated.

Not metaphorically. Not in the artistic sense. The bass had found my slong and was using it as a tuning fork.

I looked down at myself.

“Sofa,” I said, “why is the song touching my slong?”

The mixer panel blinked. The coffee-stained tablet displayed three identical sliders, each labeled something different, each behaving like the other two. I dragged the one marked BASS down.

The bass went up.

I dragged it farther.

The bass went up harder.

The table hopped. My sunglasses jumped off the keyboard. The missing lens made them land crooked, one black eye staring into the ceiling while the other stared directly at the chat.

“Okay,” I said. “That’s not a bass control. That’s a bass invitation.”

The chat filled with messages.

LOWER IT.

NO, KEEP IT.

MAKE SOFA’S SLONG CLAP.

CRAIG VOTE YES.

Somebody sent a fish emoji followed by a chair emoji. The chair-Craig, still visible in the corner of the stream, raised one finger again as if he had become the official voting apparatus of the entire house.

Jet's dead microphone clicked.

"Jet," I said, "if that was a warning, click twice."

Click.

A second click came from the mixer.

Then the beat doubled.

"Damn it."

The room shook in two separate rhythms. The first bass struck through the floorboards. The second arrived half a second later through the speakers, producing the sonic sensation of being punched by a ghost with excellent timing. A stack of empty cans trembled beside the monitor. One tipped over, rolled toward the edge, and stopped against my coffee cup like it had reached a border checkpoint.

I grabbed the master volume slider.

The master volume went up.

The song became larger.

The walls gave a tiny cough.

"Why is every button a yes button?" I yelled.

The tablet answered with the Wet Market chant.

"FRESH FISH! FRESH FISH! FRESH FISH!"

The chant came through the speakers at the new volume, each word landing with a bass kick underneath it.

Fresh fish.

Boom.

Fresh fish.

Boom.

My slong responded with a third, unauthorized rhythm.

I slapped the tablet screen. The approval page opened. A red box appeared.

VALIDATION REQUEST INTERRUPTED.

"No," I said. "Not yet. I'm not requesting validation. I'm requesting silence."

The system interpreted this as a request for more bass.

The song dropped into a loop.

"Put your hands up," I rapped.

"Put your hands up," the speaker repeated.

"Put your hands up."

"Put your hands up."

"Put your hands up."

The loop got stuck there, circling like a rat in a bucket. I tried to rap over it.

"Let the Jurgenerator in the club - "

"Put your hands up."

"Look for the Jurgenerator - "

"Put your hands up."

"I am Sofa, I am - "

"Put your hands up."

The bass rolled beneath every repetition. My chest shook. The floor shook. The chair-Craig shook so slightly that nobody could tell whether he was voting or suffering from a low-frequency medical event.

Jet's picture blurred.

"Jet, can you hear me?"

His microphone clicked once.

The stream translated it into: "Gay guy alert."

The chat exploded into new voting commands.

I leaned closer to the panel. The knobs were small, black, and slick with the coffee residue from the previous disaster. My fingers slipped off the bass control and landed on something labeled LOOP. I turned it left.

The loop sped up.

"Put your hands up put your hands up put your hands up put your hands up," the speaker machine-gunned.

The bass joined it.

My slong achieved percussion.

I froze.

There was a moment - brief, stupid, and extremely loud - when the entire room became a nightclub designed by a malfunctioning fish. The monitor flickered blue. The coffee cup shivered in place. The cracked sunglasses bounced against the keyboard, one lens missing, the remaining lens catching every flash of light and throwing it onto the wall like a tiny police search.

The chant kept going.

"Put your hands up put your hands up put your hands up - "

I raised both hands.

The chat immediately voted against me.

NO HANDS.

DROP LOWER.

MAKE IT WORSE.

The chair-Craig raised one finger.

"Craig," I said, "I swear to God, if that means yes, I'm throwing the chair into the mixer."

The chair did not respond. It simply leaned forward half an inch.

That was enough.

The bass surged.

The room's cheapest light fixture rattled overhead. Dust fell onto my hair. Somewhere behind the monitor, a cable popped loose and the stream image turned sideways. Jet appeared rotated ninety degrees, still wearing the same expression, like a handsome man trapped inside a falling elevator.

"Look at Jet's face," I said, now yelling through the loop. "That is the face of a man watching me get defeated by a knob."

The system added a new sound: a deep mechanical voice saying, "Approval pending."

The voice repeated every four beats.

"Approval pending."

Boom.

"Approval pending."

Boom.

"Approval pending."

Boom.

I stabbed the mute button.

The speakers muted.

For half a second, there was only the hot smell of dust, the sticky tablet beneath my palm, and my own breathing.

Then the mixer unmuted itself.

"Approval pending."

Boom.

I slapped the power strip.

The monitor went black.

The speakers stayed on.

The tablet went black.

The speakers stayed on.

The little red light on the mixer brightened until it looked less like an indicator and more like a tiny angry eye.

“Okay,” I whispered. “The mixer is now the host.”

The loop continued.

“Put your hands up.”

I reached behind the panel and pulled the thickest cable I could find.

The sound stopped.

The room stopped shaking.

My slong stopped participating in the production.

I stood there with the cable in my fist, victorious, sweaty, and surrounded by the sharp smell of overheated plastic.

Then the disconnected speaker made one final sound.

“Put your hands up.”

The chair-Craig lowered his finger.

The chat voted again.

I stared at the dead monitor. The validation request had vanished. The approval page had reset itself to the beginning, where a little fish icon blinked beside the words PLEASE WAIT.

I had spent the entire song trying to lower the bass. I had not lowered the bass. I had lowered the connection to the speakers, which was technically a form of volume

control if nobody inspected the definition too closely.

Jet's microphone clicked.

This time, nothing translated it.

"Jet," I said, "we're alive."

Another click.

"Yeah, I know. You look great, Jet."

The chat began demanding the song again.

PLAY IT BACK.

SLOG REMIX.

CHAIR CRAIG APPROVES.

I plugged the cable back in, but only halfway. The speakers emitted a weak, embarrassed hiss. The bass returned as a tiny thump, like a mouse knocking from inside the wall.

"Good," I said. "That's manageable. That's a respectful bass."

The mixer panel flashed.

VALIDATION REQUEST AVAILABLE.

I reached for the button.

The song restarted.

"Put your hands up."

The bass hit once.

My hand stopped above the validation request.

A second beat came in.

The chair-Craig raised one finger.

I looked at the button, then at the mixer, then at Jet's sideways face.

"Not today," I said. "The Jurgenator has timing now."

The validation request expired before I could press it. The stream awarded me nothing but a new audio constraint and a loop that was still quietly waiting inside the speakers, ready to wake up the second I got confident.

I adjusted the crooked sunglasses over my face.

One lens was missing.

The remaining lens showed me exactly what I had become: TJ Birds, live on fishtank.live 247, defeated by a bass knob, a coffee spill, and a chair with voting rights.

The little speaker thumped once more.

My slong answered.

I unplugged it again.



The Discord Normies Overwhelm

The little speaker thumped once more.

I unplugged it again, and the Discord chat immediately replaced the bass with a wall of notification pings. Not one ping. Not a reasonable little computer chirp. A full digital hailstorm, like a thousand tiny doors being kicked in by people with profile pictures of anime swords.

My tablet shook against the coffee-stained desk.

“Everybody shut the fuck up,” I said. “TJ Birds is trying to communicate.”

The chat did not shut the fuck up.

I was live on fishtank.live 247, trapped in the Discord-linked stream with one cracked sunglasses lens missing, the other lens reflecting nothing but my own bad decisions. The approval meter sat at one percent, glowing with the confidence of a dead flashlight. Jet was beside me, looking excellent and sounding like a haunted walkie-talkie. His microphone had been cutting in and out since the coffee spill, and now it only produced a faint plastic click whenever he moved.

“Look at Jet’s face,” I said. “You look great, Jet.”

Click.

“That was Jet agreeing.”

Click.

"That was Jet disagreeing."

Click-click.

"That was Jet filing a formal complaint."

The chat surged.

A username called NormalGuy_847 typed, "who is this?"

Another said, "Is this a bit?"

A third asked, "Can someone explain the lore?"

I leaned toward the camera. "The lore is that I'm TJ Birds, and you're watching Goddamn Let's Kill Somebody. Goddamn it. Let's kill somebody. The fish tank live stream is about to go right now."

The words vanished under a flood of messages.

"HI STREAM"

"first"

"mods?"

"is this official"

"why does he have one sunglasses lens"

"bro looks like he lost a fight with a vending machine"

"SOFA SPOTTED"

That last one made me sit up.

"Yes," I said. "Exactly. Sofa is here. Also known as the Jurgenator. Look for the Jurgenator. That is me. I am Sofa. I am the Jerkinator. I have several names because

one name cannot contain this level of approval.”

The chat moved so fast my eyes began selecting random sentences like a malfunctioning slot machine.

“Under 18, please have your ID ready,” I announced. “Everybody stay organized.”

A message appeared instantly.

“why would under 18 need id”

Another followed.

“he thinks discord is airport security”

Then twelve people posted the same fish emoji. Someone posted a picture of a fish wearing sunglasses. Someone else posted a giant block of the word NORMIE, repeated until the tablet’s screen became a gray brick.

I jabbed the chat box with my thumb.

“Listen, I need direct audience interaction. I need one person to say something useful so I can get approved. Not a joke. Not a fish. Not a picture of a man falling through a folding table.”

A folding-table video appeared.

The tablet made a wet electronic buzz. The remaining coffee beneath it had turned into a sticky brown lake, and my thumb slid across the glass. I meant to type, “Approve Sofa.” Instead, I sent, “Approve Soup.”

The message appeared in bright blue.

“APPROVE SOUP.”

The Discord crowd seized it like a raccoon finding a wedding ring.

"SOUP APPROVED"

"LET SOFA COOK"

"THE SOUP IS LIVE"

"FISHTANK SOUP STREAM"

Someone changed their username to Soup Moderator. Another changed theirs to TJ Birds' Wet Spoon. A bot began posting a dancing bowl every three seconds.

"No," I said, wiping my thumb on my shirt. "No, no, no. That is not what I said. I said Sofa. Sofa. S-O-F-A. A furniture-based identity. A handsome furniture-based identity."

The chat answered with "COUCH COUCH COUCH" until the word became a visual carpet.

I tried to pin my message. The pin button was directly beside the report button. My thumb hit both.

A confirmation window opened.

"Report Soup Moderator?"

"No!" I shouted.

The stream interpreted my voice as a command and sent another TTS token.

A robotic voice announced, "Report soup moderator."

Jet's microphone clicked.

The chat exploded.

"HE REPORTED SOUP"

"MOD WAR"

"FREE SOUP"

"JUSTICE FOR THE BOWL"

I grabbed the tablet with both hands. It was warm from the coffee and slippery enough to qualify as a wet fish. "Everybody calm down. I am fixing this."

That sentence had never improved anything in the history of my broadcast.

I opened the Discord voice channel, thinking direct voice would cut through the spam. Instead, the channel filled with people breathing into microphones. One person was eating chips. Another had a smoke alarm chirping in the background. A third had somehow connected a soundboard that played a cash register every time anyone spoke.

"Can I get one normal person?" I yelled.

"Normal person detected," said a robotic voice.

"Normal person detected," repeated another.

"Normal person detected," said twelve more.

The phrase multiplied across the chat. Within seconds, "normal person detected" had become a chant. The notification pings climbed over one another, sharp and metallic. My desk trembled. The cracked sunglasses slipped down my nose and landed in the coffee residue with a tiny brown kiss.

I picked them up.

One lens was gone. The remaining lens was fogged.

I put them back on anyway.

"That's coolness," I said. "That's commitment. That's the Jurgenerator refusing to be visually defeated."

The chat replied, "he put the wet glasses back on."

I typed again, this time slowly. "I need approval."

Before I could send it, a Discord user named DefinitelyNotABot pasted the sentence into a macro. The message appeared once, then four times, then sixty times. "I NEED APPROVAL" flooded the screen in increasingly elaborate fonts. Someone added clown emojis. Someone added a voting poll asking whether I deserved approval.

The options were "no," "absolutely not," and "soup."

The poll reached three hundred votes before I could close it.

"Sofa," I muttered, "this is sabotage."

I pointed at myself, forgetting that Sofa was also me. "TJ Birds is trying to get approved. Sofa is trying to get approved. The Jurgenerator is trying to get approved. This is a three-man operation."

Jet clicked twice.

"Correct," I said.

The chat wrote, "Jet says no."

"Jet did not say no."

Click.

"That was a technical click."

Click-click-click.

"That was three technical clicks."

The stream translated the sound into a caption: JET IS VOTING NO.

The approval meter dropped from one percent to zero.

For a moment, the chat slowed - not because anyone cared, but because the system had frozen while trying to process the amount of nonsense. The screen displayed my face in the corner, one wet sunglasses lens, coffee on my sleeve, and the words APPROVAL: 0%.

Then the Discord connection recovered.

Every message arrived at once.

The tablet flashed white. The TTS voice began reading usernames. "NormalGuy_847. Soup Moderator. Wet Spoon. Craig Chair. Craig Battery. Craig Fruit. Craig - "

"Craig isn't even here!" I screamed.

A new username appeared.

CraigChair.

Then CraigBattery.

Then CraigFruit.

The old chair-Craig had returned in spirit, apparently, and the Discord normies had rebuilt him out of usernames. The chat began voting on which Craig was most qualified to approve me. Craig Fruit received a burst of support after someone posted a banana picture. Craig Battery was disqualified for "low emotional voltage." Craig Chair won because he had "structural authority."

I slapped the desk.

The unplugged speaker thumped.

I froze.

It thumped again, somehow, despite being unplugged.

The TTS voice spoke over it. "TJ Birds is attempting to communicate."

"Damn right I am!"

"Damn right I am," repeated the voice.

"Stop repeating me!"

"Stop repeating me!"

The Discord users copied that too. Soon the screen was nothing but STOP REPEATING ME, stacked beneath DAMN RIGHT I AM, stacked beneath COUCH SOUP, stacked beneath a looping fish emoji.

I tried to shout out the people who had been there from the beginning. I searched for a familiar name, found one buried in the flood, and typed, "Shout-out to Jet."

The message sent.

For half a second, the stream noticed.

Jet's face appeared larger in the preview window. His broken microphone clicked. A green outline formed around his camera. The chat paused just long enough for my name to appear in the activity bar.

"TJ Birds has mentioned Jet," the system announced.

There it was. Recognition. A tiny, beautiful glimmer of being seen.

I leaned into it.

"Shout-out to Jet! Look at Jet's face! You look great, Jet! Shout-out to Sofa, shout-out to the Jurgenator, shout-out to everybody who knows the fish tank live stream is about to go right now!"

The chat responded instantly.

"JET FACE REVEAL"

"WHY DOES JET LOOK LIKE THAT"

"JET IS THE APPROVAL"

"SOFA IS A COUCH"

"JURGENATOR CAUGHT IN 4K"

Then someone clipped the moment and titled it: TJ Birds Tries to Flirt With a Broken Microphone.

The clip notification appeared in the corner.

I stared at it.

"No," I said.

The TTS voice said, "No."

The chat said, "NO."

The clip was already spreading.

I attempted one final message, carefully, with both elbows planted on the desk so my hands could not slip.

"Please approve TJ Birds."

I checked the spelling. I checked the name. I checked that I had not written soup, sofa, or anything involving a bowl.

I sent it.

The message appeared at the top of the chat.

For one glorious second, it stood alone.

Then the normies attacked.

"PLEASE APPROVE SOUP BIRDS"

"APPROVE THE COUCH"

"APPROVE JET'S FACE"

"NO APPROVAL ONLY CONTENT"

A bot copied my sentence and added clown emojis. Another turned it into a poll. A third posted it backward. The screen filled with APPROVE TJ BIRDS until the words became wallpaper, then garbage, then weather.

The approval meter stayed at zero.

My direct audience interaction had succeeded in the same way a fire alarm succeeds at gathering a crowd. I had been noticed, identified, clipped, mocked, and buried beneath my own request.

I sat back, trying to preserve what remained of my dignity. The chair creaked. The coffee cup rolled an inch across the desk and stopped against the unplugged speaker.

Jet clicked once.

I nodded. "Yeah. I know."

The chat slowed enough for one new message to appear.

"Can we get Sofa to do the approval rap?"

I looked at the camera.

"No," I said.

The TTS voice answered, "Yes."

Somewhere under the desk, the speaker thumped again.

CHAPTER 15



He Falls, Can't Get Up

The speaker thumped again, and my left foot immediately forgot it had a job.

I was halfway through a verse when the floor kicked sideways beneath me. Not metaphorically. The floor, the camera, the whole fish tank boundary gave a tiny electronic lurch, like the stream had hiccupped and decided my skeleton was optional.

" - wobble wobble, looking awful - "

My heel caught the coffee cable.

The coffee cable caught the chair.

The chair caught my dignity and dragged it under the desk.

I windmilled both arms, one cracked sunglasses lens flashing at the camera while the other socket stared into the void. Jet's face appeared on the monitor behind me, frozen in the same beautiful, concerned expression the tablet had already labeled WITNESS: JET'S FACE.

"Look at Jet's face," I said, trying to remain upright through sheer branding. "You look great, Jet."

Jet's microphone clicked.

" - "

Then nothing.

I stepped backward to recover and landed on the coffee cup.

The cup made a wet plastic crunch. Coffee spread across the floor in a brown fan, slid beneath the mixer, and began whispering to the electronics.

The approval meter blinked green.

For one glorious second, it showed four percent.

I reached toward it.

My knee folded.

"I fallen," I announced.

The camera caught my shoulder smacking the edge of the desk. My sunglasses flew off, bounced once, and landed lens-down in the coffee like a tiny defeated lifeguard.

"I can't get up."

The TTS voice answered from beneath the desk.

"Challenge failed."

"No," I said, flat on my side. "That was not a challenge. That was a medical statement."

The stream disagreed. A red banner crawled across the monitor.

FAIL STATE: UNPLANNED FLOOR CONTACT.

The approval meter dropped to three percent.

I stared at the number. Three percent. I had fought the Aquacadabra Rule. I had survived the exit button rejecting me fifty times. I had completed Four Nonsies for one miserable percent while the audience voted like a jury made entirely of raccoons. I had spilled coffee into the equipment and still kept rapping.

Now the floor had reviewed me and found me lacking.

"Hold on," I said. "I'm going to recover quickly. This is part of the performance."

The TTS voice said, "Recovery challenge initiated."

A blue circle appeared over my head on the screen.

GET UP WITHOUT USING HANDS.

I looked at my hands. One was trapped beneath my chest. The other was resting in the coffee, fingers twitching every time the mixer made a sad electrical chirp.

"That's bullshit," I said.

The circle shrank.

Jet leaned toward the camera. His mouth moved. His microphone produced a noise like a dying fax machine.

"What did he say?" I asked.

The TTS voice translated, "Jet says: skill issue."

Jet shook his head violently.

"See? He agrees," I said.

I rolled onto my back. The movement made the desk wobble. The monitor slid forward, and the approval meter changed from three percent to two.

"Why did that cost me?"

The screen displayed a new message.

EXCESSIVE FLOOR NEGOTIATION.

"Excessive floor negotiation?" I shouted. "I'm on the floor because the floor attacked me!"

The speaker thumped beneath the desk.

The sound hit my ribs like a cheap nightclub. My legs kicked in reflex. One Croc flew off and struck the camera tripod.

The camera tilted.

The room became a diagonal landscape of coffee, cables, Jet's frozen face, and my one naked sock.

The stream chat exploded.

Sofa is down.

JURGENATOR HAS BEEN DEFEATED BY GRAVITY.

TJ BIRDS FAIL COMPILATION.

Somebody typed, Under 18, please have your ID ready.

"Why do they need ID for this?" I demanded.

The TTS voice answered, "To verify the fall."

"I am visibly fallen!"

The blue circle returned.

GET UP WITHIN TEN SECONDS.

I planted my elbows and shoved. My shirt dragged against the carpet, which smelled like old coffee and overheated dust. My shoulder screamed - not emotionally, just with the ordinary complaint of a shoulder being used as a forklift.

I got one knee underneath me.

The meter rose to three percent.

"Yes!" I said. "That's right. The Jurgenator rises."

The moment I said it, the TTS voice played a siren.

ALIAS INFLATION DETECTED.

The meter dropped to one percent.

"Alias inflation?"

I tried to stand faster.

My remaining Croc caught on the chair wheel. The chair rolled away. My knee extended. My body followed the chair like a man being towed by a shopping cart.

I grabbed the desk.

The desk grabbed nothing. It slid six inches through the coffee.

The mixer lit up.

Jet's dead microphone suddenly screamed one syllable.

"AAAA - "

Then silence.

The screen displayed:

AUDIO EVENT: POSSIBLE SCREAM.

PENALTY: DRAMATIC ESCALATION.

The approval meter emptied.

Zero percent.

The number sat there in a clean white font while I remained bent over the desk, one hand gripping the edge, one foot tangled in the chair, my missing sunglasses lens floating in coffee beneath me.

I had reached the bottom. Not spiritually. Spiritually, I had been at the bottom since the portal asked me to prove I was a person and I responded by rapping about Squirtle.

This was administrative bottom.

The TTS voice spoke softly.

"Participant has failed the standing requirement."

"I am standing."

"You are leaning."

"I'm standing with support."

"Support is considered assistance."

"Then the chair is my teammate!"

"Unauthorized teammate detected."

The chair beeped.

I looked at it. "You weren't even invited."

The chair rolled another inch and pulled my ankle with it. I dropped onto the desk, chest-first. The keyboard smashed beneath me. Somewhere, a window opened on the computer.

The fish tank stream displayed a poll.

IS TJ BIRDS CURRENTLY A CHAIR?

The options were YES, NO, and STOP FALLING.

The vote count climbed so quickly the numbers blurred.

I tried to reach the mouse. My arm stretched across the desk, past the coffee cup, past the sticky mixer, past a cracked tablet still showing WITNESS: JET'S FACE.

My fingertips touched the mouse.

The approval meter flashed.

I clicked.

The screen asked:

CONFIRM FLOOR STATUS?

I clicked again.

A pop-up appeared:

ARE YOU SURE YOU WANT TO BE DOWN?

"Yes!" I yelled. "No! I mean, I'm not choosing this!"

The TTS voice said, "Participant confirms being down."

The meter stayed at zero.

The chat began chanting, "DOWN! DOWN! DOWN!"

The speaker thumped again.

This time the bass came through the floor, the desk, the chair, and my teeth. My body bounced against the keyboard in tiny humiliating hops. The camera shook with every beat. Jet's face remained locked behind me, handsome and expressionless, like a museum portrait of a man who had just watched a sofa become a legal category.

I tried to rap through it.

"I'm TJ Birds, I'm on the ground, Approval meter underground, Sofa down but still profound - "

The keyboard produced a string of letters.

The TTS voice read them aloud.

"Gggggggggggggggggggggg."

"Exactly," I said. "That's the hook."

Another banner appeared.

RHYME QUALITY: FLOOR LEVEL.

I took a breath and pushed myself upright.

My elbow slipped in coffee.

My chin hit the desk.

The cracked sunglasses skidded out from beneath the monitor and snapped under my palm. The missing lens was already gone. Now the remaining lens had a fresh white scratch straight across it.

The signature coolness item had become a wet piece of evidence.

"Don't look at me like that," I told Jet.

Jet's mouth moved again. His microphone clicked twice.

The TTS voice said, "Jet says: I am not looking at you."

"That's worse."

I managed to sit on the floor. For three seconds, I was still. The stream camera steadied. The bass stopped. The approval meter remained at zero, but at least it had stopped falling.

The chat slowed down long enough to invent a new title.

TJ BIRDS, FORMERLY STANDING.

I picked up the sunglasses. Coffee dripped from the frame onto my wrist. It smelled burnt and sweet, like a gas station had been boiled inside a computer.

"Listen," I said to the camera. "I'm going to explain the situation. I did not fail a challenge. I experienced a sudden floor event. There is a difference."

The TTS voice answered, "Floor event classified as challenge fail."

"No. I'm the host."

"Host status pending."

"I'm TJ Birds."

"Identity accepted."

"Then accept my explanation."

"Explanation rejected."

I stared at the screen.

The approval meter flickered from zero to one.

My entire body straightened.

"Did you see that? One percent. One percent means we're back."

The meter dropped to zero.

“Why?”

The screen replied:

FALSE RECOVERY CLAIM.

I put both hands over my face. One hand still smelled like coffee. The other smelled like carpet. Beneath the desk, the speaker gave a tiny click, as if it had been waiting for me to become pathetic enough.

The TTS voice said, “Would participant like to attempt the Fall Again challenge?”

“No.”

“Challenge accepted.”

“No, it isn’t.”

A timer appeared.

FIVE.

The camera zoomed in by itself.

FOUR.

My face filled the stream. One cracked lens. One missing lens. Coffee on my cheek. Hair stuck to my forehead. Behind me, Jet’s frozen expression hovered like a silent endorsement of my collapse.

THREE.

I pushed myself up.

The chair wheel rolled.

The cable tightened.

The mixer sparked.

TWO.

I grabbed the desk.

ONE.

The desk slid.

I fell again.

This time I landed seated, hard enough to make the camera rattle. The TTS voice announced it with the solemnity of a boxing referee.

“Participant has fallen.”

The chat responded with a wall of red failure icons.

The approval meter did not merely remain at zero. It shrank into a gray line and vanished.

A final message appeared.

APPROVAL PROGRESS RESET DUE TO REPEATED FAILS.

I looked at the empty space where the meter had been.

“Reset?” I said.

The stream offered no number. No green flash. No tiny reward for surviving. Nothing but the gray line and a button labeled BEGIN AGAIN.

Jet’s microphone clicked.

I pointed at him. “Don’t say anything.”

His mouth moved.

The TTS voice said, "Jet says: You look great, Jet."

"That's what I said!"

The camera tilted lower, framing my legs, the spilled coffee, the chair, and one bare foot. My sunglasses dangled from my fingers like a dead insect.

I sat there breathing through my nose while the fish tank stream continued without mercy. The floor had won. The portal had won. The speaker beneath the desk had apparently achieved personhood and was now my manager.

I pushed the BEGIN AGAIN button.

The screen turned white.

Then it asked for age verification.

Underneath, in smaller text, it said:

UNDER 18, PLEASE HAVE YOUR ID READY.

I stared at the prompt, still seated on the floor.

The speaker thumped once.

I did not move.

The TTS voice said, "New challenge available: stand up and prove you are real."

I lifted the coffee-soaked sunglasses toward the camera.

"My name is TJ Birds," I said. "I'm Sofa. I'm the Jurgenator. Look for the Jurgenator. And I am fixing to go live on fishtank.live 247."

The stream displayed:

IDENTITY CONFIRMED.

Then, beneath it:

POSTURE FAILED.

The camera zoomed in on Jet's face.

My approval meter stayed at zero.



The ADD Forgets the Button

The camera was still zoomed in on Jet's face, and my approval meter was still sitting at zero like a dead roach wearing a tiny business tie.

"Look at Jet's face," I said, leaning toward the tablet. "You look great, Jet. You look great, Jet."

Jet's microphone produced one wet click.

Then silence.

The action prompt glowed beneath his frozen cheekbones. DROP A LOG, it said. Complete the action to earn progress. A little green button pulsed beside it, bright and stupid, like it knew I had attention problems and had chosen violence.

I rubbed the cracked sunglasses against my shirt. One lens was missing. The remaining lens had a fingerprint shaped like a small continent.

"I'm TJ Birds," I announced to the stream, "and you're watching Goddamn Let's Kill Somebody. Goddamn it. Let's kill somebody. The fish tank live stream is about to go right now. I am going live on fishtank.live 247. Look for the Jurgenerator. Or Sofa. Sofa is me. Jurgenerator is also me. Jerkinator if the spelling department is drunk."

The tablet flashed.

DROP A LOG: PRESS NOW.

Underneath, the chat began throwing itself down the stairs.

DROP IT HE'S ALREADY DROPPED EVERYTHING ASK JET WITNESS JET'S FACE
NORMALGUY: IS THIS A BATHROOM THING DEFINITELYNOTABOT: ACTION
REQUIRES TIMING

"Timing?" I said.

The prompt pulsed again.

"Okay. I understand timing. I have been alive for several decades. I have seen clocks. I have watched a microwave count down from three minutes while standing directly in front of it."

The green button pulsed.

I lifted my finger.

Then I noticed the coffee cup.

It was still beside the tablet, the same cup that had spilled across the mixer in the previous disaster and turned the controls into a sticky little graveyard. There was a brown ring under it. The smell was burnt coffee, hot plastic, and regret with a breakfast aftertaste.

I moved the cup two inches away.

The button pulsed.

I looked at Jet.

"You good?"

Jet's dead microphone clicked.

"See? He said yes," I told the stream. "Jet is communicating through the ancient language of broken electronics."

The button pulsed faster.

I raised my finger again, but the tablet displayed a tiny warning: ACTION WINDOW: THREE SECONDS.

“Three seconds,” I said. “Easy. One, two - ”

The chat showed a message from Craig.

CRAIG: WHAT DOES DROP A LOG MEAN

I stopped counting.

“That is an excellent question,” I said.

The button went gray.

ACTION WINDOW MISSED.

My approval meter remained at zero.

A red message appeared beneath it.

NO CREDIT AWARDED.

I stared at the screen.

“I was investigating.”

The tablet made a soft electronic chirp, the sound of a machine politely documenting my failure.

Craig’s chair creaked from somewhere off-camera.

“Don’t ask what it means,” I said. “That’s how they get you. First they make you press the button. Then they make you explain the button. Then they ask why you have been sitting in a fish tank boundary for fifty minutes with one shoe full of coffee.”

The prompt refreshed.

NEXT ROUND AVAILABLE IN 00:20.

Twenty seconds.

I leaned closer. "All right. The answer is hidden. Someone knows what Drop a Log means. The moderator knows. The fish know. Jet probably knows, but his microphone has entered witness protection."

Jet's face stayed on screen, pale and beautiful beneath the camera's merciless zoom.

"Look at Jet's face," I said. "He knows something."

Jet clicked once.

"Exactly."

The chat exploded.

SOUP MODERATOR: IT IS AN ACTION DEFINITELYNOTABOT: PRESS THE BUTTON
NORMALGUY: HE FORGOT AGAIN CRAIG: DROP A LOG LOL CRAIG CHAIR: [NO TEXT]

The timer dropped to sixteen.

I put both hands on the desk. The mixer shifted under my palm. One of the coffee-damaged knobs turned by itself and sent a low bass note through the room.

Bummm.

The tablet shook.

Jet's face stretched for half a second, then snapped back.

"Not the bass," I said. "Not now. We already buried that bass. I unplugged it. I unplugged it again. That bass has more comebacks than a man who owes money at a barbecue."

The timer hit twelve.

I searched the action area for clues. There was the green button. There was a gray button marked VIEW RULE. There was a blue button labeled CONFIRM. There was a tiny icon of a log rolling downhill.

I pressed VIEW RULE.

The page opened.

DROP A LOG REQUIRES A LOG DROP.

"That is not a rule," I said. "That's a sentence wearing a fake mustache."

The timer hit eight.

I pressed the little log icon.

The tablet opened a gallery of logs. Wooden logs. Cartoon logs. One log wearing sunglasses. A log labeled CRAIG FRUIT. A log labeled CRAIG BATTERY. A log labeled CRAIG CHAIR.

I touched Craig Fruit.

The stream played a fruit blender sound.

The timer hit five.

"Why did it make that noise?"

The tablet asked, "Would you like to add Craig Fruit to your cart?"

"No!"

The timer hit three.

The green button returned.

I saw it.

I understood it.

I had the finger.

Then the tablet announced, "Under 18, please have your ID ready."

"What?" I shouted. "Why are we doing age verification again? Under 18, please have your ID ready. I am trying to drop a log, not buy a suspicious energy drink."

The button pulsed.

Two seconds.

One.

I slapped the screen.

My palm landed on the blue CONFIRM button.

The tablet flashed:

NEXT ROUND CREDIT RESERVED.

Then the window closed.

The room went quiet except for the dead microphone's faint electrical hiss and the smell of coffee cooking inside the mixer.

I held my hand in the air.

"I pressed a button."

The approval meter stayed at zero.

The tablet displayed:

PARTIAL CREDIT: NEXT ROUND.

I read it twice.

"Partial credit?"

The chat answered immediately.

NORMALGUY: HE GOT CREDIT FOR NOT GETTING CREDIT DEFINITELYNOTABOT:
SUCCESSFUL FAILURE CRAIG: DROP THE LOG NEXT ROUND

"That is not progress," I said. "That is a coupon for progress. That is the stream handing me a receipt for a sandwich it refused to sell me."

The red timer reset.

NEXT ROUND AVAILABLE IN 00:45.

Forty-five seconds.

I grabbed the coffee cup and held it up to the camera. "This cup has done more damage to my approval status than any enemy could accomplish with a weapon."

The cup slipped.

I caught it against my chest.

Coffee jumped over the rim and landed directly on the mixer.

Every control lit up.

The bass came back.

Bummm.

A TTS voice said, "Craig Fruit added to cart."

"No, it wasn't!"

Bummm.

"Craig Battery added to cart."

"Stop shopping!"

Bummm.

"Craig Chair added to cart."

Craig's chair squealed.

Jet's microphone clicked.

The camera zoomed out just enough to show Jet's shoulder, then zoomed back into his face as if the system had reconsidered and decided his shoulder was too much information.

I wiped the mixer with my sleeve. The sleeve immediately became brown and sticky.

"Okay," I said. "We have forty seconds. We know the button. We know the action. We know the system is a lying little toilet with Wi-Fi."

The tablet showed the prompt again.

DROP A LOG.

I sat up straight.

"I am ready."

The timer counted down from thirty-five.

I placed my finger beside the button without touching it.

"I will not move. I will not investigate. I will not ask what the log represents. I will not open the rules. I will not acknowledge Craig Fruit. I will not acknowledge the bass."

Bummm.

"I will not acknowledge the bass."

Bummm.

The chat posted a poll.

WHAT SHOULD TJ DO?

PRESS BUTTON ASK WHAT IT MEANS SHOW JET'S FACE DROP ACTUAL LOG

I glanced at the fourth option.

"Who put that in there?"

The timer hit twenty-eight.

A small notification appeared in the corner.

Sofa has entered the action area.

Then another.

Jurgenator has entered the action area.

Then another.

Jerkinator has entered the action area.

"I am all three of those accounts," I said. "Why are they entering separately? I am one man. One extremely qualified man. I am TJ Birds."

The tablet displayed:

IDENTITY CONFLICT.

"Identity conflict? Sofa is me. Jurgenator is me. Jerkinator is me when autocorrect gets horny."

The timer hit twenty.

A new question appeared.

WHO IS PERFORMING THE ACTION?

The choices were TJ BIRDS, SOFA, JURGENATOR, and CRAIG CHAIR.

I selected TJ Birds.

The tablet rejected it.

HOST NOT FOUND.

I selected Sofa.

The tablet rejected it.

ALIAS NOT VERIFIED.

I selected Jurgenator.

The tablet rejected it.

SPELLING VARIANT DETECTED.

I selected Jerkinator.

The tablet made the sound of a cash register being punched.

The timer hit ten.

I reached for the green button.

Then I saw the approval meter.

Zero percent.

A tiny arrow beside it pointed down.

It had been zero before. Now it was zero with a downward arrow, which was mathematically insulting.

“Why is zero going down?” I asked.

The tablet replied, “Your current progress is insufficient.”

“Insufficient for what?”

“Drop a log.”

The timer hit six.

I pressed the green button.

Nothing happened.

I pressed it again.

The screen changed.

I stopped.

The button was gone.

The action window had closed.

The tablet displayed:

TIMING WINDOW MISSED.

NO CURRENT-ROUND CREDIT.

NEXT-ROUND CREDIT RETAINED: 1%.

For a long moment, the only movement came from the cracked lens of my sunglasses sliding down my nose.

The bass thumped once.

Jet's face remained on camera.

I looked at the message.

I looked at my finger.

I looked at the coffee-covered mixer, where Craig Fruit was apparently still attempting to purchase itself.

"I missed the button," I said.

The TTS voice answered, "You missed the button."

"I know I missed the button."

"You missed the button."

"I heard you."

The bass thumped again.

The approval meter remained at zero, but the next-round credit sat beneath it in tiny green text: 1%.

One percent.

Not approval. Not completion. Not even a respectable failure. A microscopic permission slip to fail again later.

Craig finally spoke from behind the camera.

"Did you drop the log?"

"No," I said.

"Did you get credit?"

"Partial next-round credit."

"So you got credit?"

"I got a future-shaped crumb."

Jet's microphone clicked three times.

I pointed at him. "Look at Jet's face. He is the only person here who understands the seriousness of this."

Jet's screen froze.

A loading symbol appeared over his forehead.

Then the fish tank stream advanced.

The action area vanished. The camera feed shifted to a new prompt with a bright orange timer and a picture of a bucket.

I leaned toward it.

The tablet displayed:

NEXT REQUIRED ACTION: HOLD THE BUCKET.

I stared at the bucket icon.

The coffee cup tipped beside my elbow.

The mixer began to hum.

Somewhere under the desk, the unplugged speaker gave one soft, confident thump.



The Website Pitch Gets Trolled

The unplugged speaker thumped again, and the website link appeared on-screen like a ransom note.

I slapped the mixer with one hand and held my cracked sunglasses together with the other. One lens was missing. The remaining lens had a greasy fingerprint shaped like a tiny continent. Behind me, the coffee cup sat beside the dead equipment, still guilty, still warm.

“Fishtankgods.live,” I said into the microphone. “That is the website. I am TJ Birds, and you’re watching Goddamn Let’s Kill Somebody. Goddamn it. Let’s kill somebody. We are going live on fishtank.live 247, but before that, I need everybody to visit fishtankgods.live and use the TTS.”

The chat immediately filled with links.

Not my link. Other links.

One said FISHTANKGODS.LIVE BUT WORSE. Another said CLICK HERE TO SEE TJ’S ID. A third was just a picture made out of punctuation that looked like a diseased crab wearing a crown.

The mixer hummed beneath my elbow. The unplugged speaker thumped under the desk. Jet’s microphone clicked once, produced half a breath, and died like it had remembered a debt.

“Look at Jet’s face,” I said. “You look great, Jet.”

Jet stared at the camera.

His microphone made a faint wet pop.

“That was him agreeing,” I said. “Beautiful. The technology respects him.”

I enlarged the website window. Fishtankgods.live loaded in a glorious shade of blue that made the whole screen look like a gas station bathroom. At the top sat the private menu. It had buttons for TTS voices, sound effects, phrases, and one large red button labeled DO NOT PRESS UNLESS YOU ARE READY.

Naturally, I had pressed it before the page finished loading.

The TTS voice announced, “PRIVATE MENU ACTIVATED.”

Then it announced it again.

Then it announced, “PRIVATE MENU ACTIVATED,” in a deeper voice.

The chat exploded.

PRIVATE MENU LMAO

BRO HIDING THE GOOD VOICES

WHAT’S IN THE PRIVATE MENU, SOFA?

SHOW US THE FISH DICK BUTTON

I leaned toward the camera. “There is no fish dick button. This is a professional website.”

A new message appeared.

NormalGuy: press the red one

“I am not pressing the red one.”

DefinitelyNotABot: press the red one

"I know you are not a bot because bots usually have better timing."

The red button pulsed. The page gave a tiny electronic chirp. Under the desk, the speaker thumped like something trapped inside it had just received legal representation.

I moved the mouse away.

The mouse moved back.

I grabbed it with both hands. The coffee-sticky desk resisted, making a long peeling sound. My sunglasses slipped down my nose. The one remaining lens reflected the red button, so the button appeared twice: one real, one floating in my face like a warning from a discount prophet.

"Everybody calm down," I said. "The private menu is private because it contains premium TTS. You cannot just walk into the kitchen and demand to see the chef's special sauce."

Soup Moderator typed: PRIVATE MENU IS PUBLIC NOW

Craig Chair typed: bro the menu is literally on screen

Craig Battery typed: delete website

Craig Fruit typed: add banana voice

I looked at the menu. It was absolutely on screen. I had made it public by dragging the browser window over the stream capture. The private menu was no longer private. It was sitting in front of several thousand people wearing no pants.

"That is a display issue," I said. "The menu remains spiritually private."

The TTS fired.

"THE MENU REMAINS SPIRITUALLY PRIVATE."

The chat responded with a wall of skulls.

I tried to close the window, but the stream software interpreted the click as a donation command. A gray notification appeared: EXTERNAL TRAFFIC DETECTED.

Then another: EXTERNAL TRAFFIC RISING.

Then another: PROMOTIONAL BEHAVIOR OBSERVED.

My mouth opened.

"Oh, that's good," I said. "That means people are clicking."

The traffic counter climbed from nine to twenty-three. Then forty-one. Then sixty-eight.

For one clean second, the pitch worked.

Fishtankgods.live was receiving visitors. The TTS page was alive. The numbers moved upward, and my face appeared in the little preview window looking like a man who had finally convinced a vending machine to accept a wet dollar.

"See?" I said. "External traffic. That is measurable. That is real. That is - "

A TTS request came through.

The voice said, "TJ Birds smells like a haunted couch."

Another request followed.

"SOFA IS THE PRIVATE MENU."

Then:

"JURGENATOR HAS NO APPROVAL."

I jabbed at the moderation controls. "No, no, no. The menu is not for attacking me. The menu is for expression."

A fourth voice said, "Expression detected: stinky."

Jet's dead microphone clicked again. His camera shook. He pointed at the monitor, apparently trying to warn me about something. His audio became a low digital groan and vanished.

"Jet says the website is excellent," I said.

Jet pointed harder.

The traffic counter reached one hundred and twelve.

The stream flag changed from green to yellow.

PROMOTION REVIEW: ACTIVE.

I sat up so fast the chair rolled backward. My knee struck the underside of the desk. The mixer squealed. The unplugged speaker thumped three times in perfect rhythm.

"Do not flag me," I said. "I am not promoting. I am merely informing people that the thing exists."

The TTS read that sentence aloud.

" I AM NOT PROMOTING."

The chat immediately requested it again.

I slapped the request queue. "Stop repeating me!"

The TTS said, "STOP REPEATING ME."

"Stop!"

"STOP."

“Shut up!”

“SHUT UP.”

The voices began layering over one another. A robotic woman said “private menu.” A deep man said “fishtankgods.live.” A childlike voice said “under 18, please have your ID ready.” A distorted voice added, “And your mother’s credit card.”

I froze.

“No,” I said. “That last one is not from me.”

The chat did not care. It had become a courtroom where every witness was a raccoon with access to a soundboard.

I reached for the emergency mute. My hand hit the coffee cup.

The cup tipped.

The remaining coffee slid across the desk in a brown sheet, passed under the keyboard, and poured directly into the USB hub. The hub made a tiny sizzling noise. The website window flickered. The traffic counter jumped to two hundred and seven.

The TTS voice announced, “COFFEE TRAFFIC DETECTED.”

The camera tilted sideways as the desk mat buckled beneath my wrist. The whole room rotated ninety degrees. Jet’s face appeared sideways in the corner, beautiful and silent, like a portrait hung by somebody who hated geometry.

I crawled under the desk to find the power strip.

The unplugged speaker thumped beside my ear.

I stared at it.

It thumped again.

The cable lay six inches away, disconnected, its metal end resting on the floor.

"Who is making that noise?" I whispered.

The TTS answered from the monitor above me.

"WHO IS MAKING THAT NOISE?"

The chat began typing guesses.

GHOST SPEAKER

CRAIG BATTERY

JET'S MIC

TJ'S BRAIN

I pulled the power strip. The mixer stopped humming. The monitor went black. For half a second, there was peace.

Then the backup tablet lit up.

The fishtank.live stream had switched to emergency mode. The camera feed returned upside down. The promotion warning occupied the center of the screen in giant yellow letters.

INAPPROPRIATE PROMOTION DETECTED.

Below it, a button blinked:

APPEAL.

Beside that was another button:

PUSH MORE TRAFFIC.

I reached for Appeal.

The chat sent a request through the still-active TTS page.

"PUSH MORE TRAFFIC."

I hit the wrong button.

The counter surged.

Two hundred and seven became four hundred and twelve.

Four hundred and twelve became eight hundred.

The stream software displayed a tiny fish icon wearing a police hat.

PROMOTION INTENSITY: OBNOXIOUS.

"That's not a real category," I said.

The TTS said, "THAT'S NOT A REAL CATEGORY."

The fish icon put on a second police hat.

I rose from under the desk with coffee on my sleeve and one sunglasses lens hanging from my ear. "Listen to me. The private menu is not a scam. It is a controlled environment for premium voices."

A troll request came through.

"CONTROLLED ENVIRONMENT."

Another:

"PREMIUM LOSER."

Another:

"SOFA POOPING ON THE BEAT."

I grabbed the microphone.

“Sofa be pooping,” I rapped, because at that point the rhythm had already escaped and was running through the walls. “Sofa pooping on the beat. Damn, Sofa, where’d you find this poop? Fishtankgods.live, where the menu gets cooked.”

The TTS repeated the entire line in three voices.

The traffic counter hit one thousand.

The promotion warning turned orange.

I pointed at the camera. “That is marketing!”

The TTS repeated, “THAT IS MARKETING!”

The warning turned red.

My stream title changed by itself.

TJ BIRDS PRIVATE MENU PROMOTION - CLICK NOW.

I had not typed that. I had barely managed to keep my pants from catching on the chair. Yet there it was, huge and undeniable, while the chat celebrated like they had personally discovered fire.

NormalGuy: HE’S SELLING THE MENU

DefinitelyNotABot: BUY THE PRIVATE

Soup Moderator: STOP LINK SPAM

Craig Chair: chair approves

Craig Battery: battery does not approve

Craig Fruit: fruit wants banana voice

Jet's microphone suddenly came alive.

" - and then - "

It died.

I turned toward him. "Jet, no. Not now."

The camera zoomed in on Jet's face.

The remaining stream feed showed his silent expression, the sideways room, the yellow fish police icon, and my website link pulsing underneath like an advertisement for a cursed aquarium.

The TTS voice lowered itself to a solemn whisper.

"LOOK AT JET'S FACE."

That was the funniest part. Not because Jet did anything. Jet did nothing. He simply sat there with the dead microphone, staring into the camera while my entire promotional strategy collapsed around him. His expression said he had arrived to witness a website pitch and instead received a live demonstration of why websites should require adult supervision.

I tried to restore dignity by straightening my sunglasses.

The missing lens fell onto the keyboard.

The keyboard interpreted the impact as a command.

Every TTS option activated at once.

"FISHTANKGODS.LIVE."

"PRIVATE MENU."

"JURGENATOR."

"UNDER 18, PLEASE HAVE YOUR ID READY."

"SOFA POOPING."

"LOOK AT JET'S FACE."

The voices overlapped until the room sounded like a haunted call center trapped inside a blender. The red button flashed. The traffic counter climbed past two thousand. The fish police icon multiplied into a squad.

Then the stream displayed its final judgment.

PROMOTION FLAGGED: INAPPROPRIATE PROMOTION.

The TTS went silent.

The chat did not.

CLICKED THO

GOT 404 ERROR

MENU GOES HARD

BAN SOFA

APPROVE JURGENATOR

I stood in the wreckage with coffee dripping from my cuff. The mixer was dead again. The speaker remained unplugged. Jet's microphone had returned to its natural state of uselessness. On the backup tablet, the site counter showed 2,318 visits.

I had wanted traffic.

I had received traffic.

The stream had also marked me as an inappropriate promoter, which seemed unfair because the promotion had been extremely appropriate to my personal brand: loud,

wet, badly managed, and somehow still attracting strangers.

I clicked the appeal button.

The tablet asked for a reason.

I typed: "I was only showing the website."

The TTS came back on.

"I WAS ONLY SHOWING THE WEBSITE."

The warning remained red.

I looked at Jet. "You look great, Jet."

His microphone clicked.

Nothing came out.

The chat sent one final request.

"PRESS THE RED BUTTON."

I did not press it.

The website counter climbed to 2,319 anyway.

The Public Approval Round of Applause

The website counter hit 2,319 while the red button kept glowing like it had personally witnessed my crimes.

“PRESS THE RED BUTTON,” the stream shouted through the busted speaker.

“I am pressing the red button,” I said, jabbing it with one finger. “I’m TJ Birds. I’m Sofa. I’m the Jurgenator. Look for the Jurgenator. I have pressed this button so many times the button owes me rent.”

The approval meter remained at zero.

The coffee cup sat beside the mixer in its sticky little graveyard, still leaking brown syrup into the equipment. Jet’s microphone clicked once, whispered something that sounded like “fish,” and died again. My sunglasses had one cracked lens and one lens missing, so the monitor looked like it was floating on the wrong side of my face.

I leaned toward the camera.

“Fish tank live stream is about to go right now. Right now. I’m going live on fishtank.live 247. Under 18, please have your ID ready. Not because anything exciting is happening. Because apparently even a man with this much wobble requires documentation.”

The audience noise rose. Not applause exactly. More like a thousand people dropping forks down a staircase.

That was when I decided the problem was not approval.

The problem was applause.

"Google," I said, turning toward the tablet, "ask the audience to clap for me."

The tablet lit up.

"Playing: Clapping for Beginners."

A gentle instructional piano melody filled the room.

I stared at it.

"Google. No. Ask them to applaud me."

"Here are results for: apple pie."

The stream filled with a soft voice explaining baking temperatures.

"Why are you bringing pie into this?" I yelled. "This is a validation emergency. There is no crust-based solution."

Jet's dead microphone flashed blue. His mouth moved. Nothing came out.

"Look at Jet's face," I said. "Look at Jet's face while Google ignores me. You look great, Jet."

Jet pointed at the tablet, then at the approval meter.

"I know it's zero, Jet. I can see the zero. The zero has become a roommate."

I grabbed the tablet and held it closer to the camera. The glass was warm from the coffee spill, slick under my fingers.

"Google, applause."

"Calling: Paul's Appliance Repair."

The tablet began ringing.

The audience noise changed immediately. The fork staircase became a stampede.

"Don't call Paul!" I slapped the screen. "Paul has nothing to do with this! Unless Paul can approve me. Paul, if you're there, press the red button!"

A man answered through the speaker.

"Hello?"

"Paul, are you applauding?"

"What?"

"Applaud!"

"I think you have the wrong - "

"Thank you for your support!" I ended the call and pointed at the approval meter.

"That was one applause. One professional applause. The system should recognize industry."

It did not.

The meter stayed at zero, but a new prompt appeared.

REQUEST PUBLIC APPROVAL?

"Yes!" I shouted.

The tablet heard, "Set public alarm."

A siren erupted.

The red button began pulsing. Jet's dead microphone produced a long electronic squeal. Somewhere beneath the desk, the unplugged speaker thumped with the confidence of a creature that had been waiting for its moment.

I ducked, hit my knee on the desk, and knocked the coffee cup into the mixer.

Brown liquid spread across the controls.

The stream displayed a message: APPROVAL REQUEST CANCELLED DUE TO EXCESSIVE MOVEMENT.

“Excessive movement?” I said, standing crooked. “I am moving with purpose.”

The audience typed faster.

One message said, APPLAUD LIKE HE OWES YOU MONEY.

Another said, GOOGLE THINKS HE’S A PIE.

A third simply read, CLAP CLAP CLAP CLAP CLAP, followed by enough fish emojis to stock a bathtub.

I decided to make the machine understand me through music.

“Google,” I said, breathing into the tablet like a rapper recording beside a laundromat, “play applause.”

“Playing: Applause by Lady Gaga.”

The song blasted.

I froze.

The room filled with theatrical pop music while I stood behind the wet mixer wearing half a pair of sunglasses, one knee bruised, one hand sticky with coffee, and the dignity of a man who had just been rejected by a voice assistant and then tried to defeat it with a celebrity playlist.

Jet lifted both hands and began clapping silently.

“Jet,” I said, “that is not helping.”

He kept clapping.

The audience followed.

At first, the sound was uneven. A few claps came through the stream, chopped up by buffering and the dying microphone. Then more joined. The chat started typing CLAP in waves. The notification chime fired so quickly it became one continuous metallic mosquito.

I pointed at the tablet.

“See? Google, listen. Actual applause. Human applause. Not pie. Not Paul. Not an appliance repair emergency.”

“Setting timer for five minutes.”

“Why?”

“Five minutes remaining.”

“Remaining for what?”

The tablet began counting down.

Five.

Four.

Three.

The approval meter flickered from zero to a tiny gray line.

The stream went quiet for half a second.

I leaned toward the monitor.

“Did that move?”

The line vanished.

The audience exploded into noise.

“Google, ask them to applaud harder!”

“Searching for: how to applaud harder.”

A video opened. A cartoon pair of hands clapped in slow motion.

Clap.

Clap.

Clap.

Each clap was followed by a wet digital pop.

I slapped the tablet with my palm. The cartoon hands sped up.

Clapclapclapclapclapclap.

“Stop making the cartoon clap!”

The tablet slipped out of my hand, landed on the chair, and activated the front camera. My own face appeared huge on the monitor, one eye magnified through the remaining sunglass lens. Behind me, the fish tank stream border flashed red and yellow.

JET’S FACE appeared beneath it.

Then another notification rolled across the bottom.

PUBLIC APPROVAL EVENT DETECTED.

I stopped moving.

The audience kept clapping.

Not the assistant. Not the cartoon. The audience.

Someone had started a rhythm. Two slow claps, then three fast ones. Jet copied it with both hands. The chat messages began landing in the same pattern.

CLAP CLAP CLAPCLAPCLAP.

CLAP CLAP CLAPCLAPCLAP.

My mixer crackled. The coffee-stained controls glowed like diseased arcade buttons. The approval meter rose to one percent.

"One percent," I whispered.

The tablet said, "One percent chance of rain."

"No, you stupid rectangle. One percent approval."

The meter climbed to two.

The audience changed rhythm again. Now it sounded like a club trying to summon a landlord. The stream shook with every impact. My chair rolled backward. I grabbed the desk, missed, and caught the cable attached to Jet's microphone.

Jet's microphone flew off the table.

For one glorious second, it worked.

"Clap - " Jet said.

Then the microphone hit the floor and screamed.

The audience applauded harder.

The meter jumped to five percent.

I stared at Jet.

"You look great, Jet."

Jet pointed at the microphone on the floor.

"You look great down there too."

The applause continued. The broken speaker thumped beneath the desk. The song had ended, but the tablet kept playing a faint loop of the last drumbeat. The cartoon hands were still clapping on-screen, slightly out of sync with the humans, creating a horrible little percussion battle.

I tried to regain control.

"Google, stop."

"Stopping all alarms."

The siren returned.

"Google, stop alarm."

"Starting alarm."

"Google, stop everything!"

"Ordering twenty-four party hats."

A confirmation window appeared.

I slapped cancel. The tablet opened the camera again. My face filled the screen. The missing sunglass lens made me look like a pirate who had been banned from a mall kiosk.

The audience saw it.

The chat stopped saying CLAP.

For one breath, nothing happened.

Then the applause came back twice as loud.

Someone sent a giant animated hand that smacked the screen. Someone else triggered a sound effect of a stadium crowd. A third viewer uploaded what appeared to be a recording of a toilet flushing in rhythm.

The approval meter rose.

Eight percent.

Twelve.

Seventeen.

I could feel the win forming, but it was wearing clown shoes.

"Everybody keep clapping," I said. "Do not stop. Do not breathe if breathing interrupts the clap. This is TJ Birds. This is Sofa. This is the Jurgenerator entering the club."

The red button flashed.

APPROVAL REQUIRES AUTHENTIC PUBLIC RESPONSE.

"I'm authentic!"

The system displayed: AUTHENTIC RESPONSE DETECTED.

The meter jumped to twenty-five percent.

Then the fish tank border opened.

A narrow blue portal appeared on the screen, shaped like a wet doorway. Water-colored light spilled across the desk and made the coffee shine. The stream label changed from WAITING FOR APPROVAL to PUBLICLY APPLAUDED.

I stood up so fast the chair rolled into the wall.

The applause became enormous.

The tablet, finally understanding nothing and therefore accidentally understanding everything, announced, "Congratulations. You are now being clapped for."

I raised both arms.

"YES!"

The approval meter hit fifty percent.

The audience sent more claps. Jet retrieved his microphone from the floor and held it like a dead bird. It clicked twice.

"Can you hear me?" he asked.

His voice came through perfectly.

I turned toward him.

"No."

He tried again.

"Can you hear me now?"

The microphone produced a foghorn blast.

"Now I can hear you too much."

The meter hit seventy-five percent.

A prompt appeared: ENTER TANK SEGMENT?

I pressed the red button.

The stream asked, "Are you sure?"

I pressed it again.

"Are you sure you are sure?"

I pressed it with both hands.

The portal widened. The screen filled with fish tank static, audience claps, the cartoon hands, the broken alarm, and a rotating notification that said PAUL'S APPLIANCE REPAIR MISSED CALL.

The meter reached one hundred.

The room went silent.

Even the speaker beneath the desk stopped thumping.

Then the fish tank stream announced, "Approval granted."

I waited for the system to take it back.

It did not.

The portal pulled my camera feed forward. My cracked sunglasses, coffee hand, bruised knee, and one-sided grin all entered the tank segment together like a discount superhero team.

I pointed at the screen.

"Look at Jet's face!"

Jet's face appeared in the corner, frozen mid-blink.

"You look great, Jet."

His microphone clicked.

"Thank you."

The applause returned, real and clean this time, without the cartoon, without Google, without Paul, without the alarm. Just the audience deciding that the disaster had

earned a door.

I stepped toward the blue opening.

“Fish tank live stream is about to go right now,” I said. “Right now. I’m going live on fishtank.live 247. Under 18, please have your ID ready. The Jurgenerator has been approved.”

The screen flashed one final message.

TANK SEGMENT OPEN.

Then, beneath it:

NEW CHALLENGE: MAKE THE FISH APPLAUD BACK.

The unplugged speaker gave one soft thump.

I looked down at it.

“Absolutely not.”

The fish tank made a bubbling sound.

And somewhere inside the portal, something clapped.



He Finally Gets on the Fish Tank

The thing inside the portal clapped again, and the camera cut to my face before I had time to look cool.

I was in.

Not lobby-in. Not “temporary approval pending moderator review” in. Not standing outside the fish tank with my cracked sunglasses held up like a passport while the website asked for my ID, my birthday, and apparently a blood oath from Jet’s dead microphone. I was physically inside the fish tank segment camera zone on fishtank.live 247, with a blue border around my body and a timer blinking above my head.

00:00:03.

“Goddamn it,” I said. “I made it.”

The timer changed to four.

I adjusted the sunglasses. One lens was cracked, the other lens was missing, so I could see the portal through my own face like a man being observed by a broken security camera. The floor under my shoes was warm and faintly wet. Somewhere beyond the camera zone, water bubbled. The coffee-damaged mixer hummed with the confidence of an appliance that had recently survived a crime.

Jet stood outside the border.

His microphone hung from its cable, silent and useless, like it had been sentenced to community service. I pointed at him.

"Look at Jet's face," I said. "Beautiful. You look great, Jet."

Jet opened his mouth.

Nothing came out.

The portal produced a polite chime.

A black strip appeared at the bottom of the screen.

CONTINUOUS PERFORMANCE REQUIRED.

I stared at it.

"No," I said.

The strip flashed.

CONTINUOUS PERFORMANCE REQUIRED.

"That's not approval. That's a hostage situation with graphics."

The timer reached ten seconds. A second line appeared.

SILENCE WILL BE COUNTED AS EXIT INTENT.

"I'm not silent," I said.

The room stayed silent.

Even Jet's microphone refused to betray me.

I slapped the mixer. The coffee cup, still sitting beside it with a brown ring dried around the bottom, wobbled. The mixer answered with a deep electronic cough. The bass kicked on, low and ugly, vibrating the camera-zone floor beneath my feet.

The portal began counting again.

"Fine," I said. "I'm TJ Birds, and you're watching Goddamn Let's Kill Somebody. Goddamn it. Let's kill somebody. Let's kill somebody."

The timer stopped blinking.

A green fish appeared beside it.

PERFORMANCE ACCEPTED.

I raised both hands. "That's right! I'm on the fish tank with my homies!"

The green fish immediately turned yellow.

PERFORMANCE QUALITY DECLINING.

"Quality declining? I just got here!"

The fish blinked.

I had wanted to be approved. I had wanted the portal to open, the camera to recognize me, and the invisible fish-tank gods to stop treating me like a suspicious package left outside a grocery store. Now that I was inside, the website had apparently decided my only legal activity was performing until my bones became content.

A viewer comment slid across the screen.

SING OR GET OUT.

Another appeared.

SOFA HAS ENTERED THE WATER.

Then one from NormalGuy.

IS HE SUPPOSED TO BE DOING THAT?

"I am Sofa," I said, pacing inside the border. "I am the Jurgenerator. Look for the Jurgenerator. I am the Jerkinator when the Wi-Fi gets disrespectful. I'm going live on fishtank.live 247, and the fish tank live stream is about to go right now, right now, right now."

The portal rewarded me with a green fish.

Jet gave me a thumbs-up.

His microphone made a tiny clicking noise.

The camera zoomed toward it.

A warning appeared.

AUDIO SOURCE UNSTABLE. REPAIR PERFORMANCE THROUGH DANCE.

"Why does the microphone get a dance?"

I tried to ignore it. The border around my shoes tightened. The blue line crept inward, leaving me less room. First I had a camera zone. Then I had a glowing rectangle. Then I had the standing space of a man waiting for an elevator that hated him.

I started rapping.

"Sofa on the tank, got the fish doing laps, Coffee in the mixer, got the bass doing craps, Jet got no mic but his face still shines, One lens gone and I'm still online."

The green fish appeared.

The timer climbed.

Twenty seconds.

Thirty.

Then the TTS voice spoke through the mixer.

"Under eighteen, please have your ID ready."

I stopped.

The border flashed red.

"Why did it say that?"

"Under eighteen, please have your ID ready," the TTS repeated.

The chat exploded. Messages stacked over one another so quickly they looked like digital snow.

I pointed at the tablet. "That is audience control. That's not part of my verse."

"Under eighteen, please have your ID ready."

"Stop saying it!"

"Under eighteen, please have your ID ready."

The bass kicked harder. The cracked coffee mixer rattled. Jet's microphone swung into the blue border and triggered another warning.

UNAUTHORIZED OBJECT ENTERING PERFORMANCE ZONE.

"It's Jet's microphone!"

The TTS answered, "Under eighteen, please have your ID ready."

Jet reached for the microphone. His hand crossed the border.

UNAUTHORIZED HAND ENTERING PERFORMANCE ZONE.

The border shrank again.

I grabbed Jet's wrist and shoved it back. The microphone swung away, hit the side of the camera, and made the image tilt forty degrees. Suddenly the fish tank appeared

sideways. Jet's face floated in the upper corner, handsome and upside down.

"Look at Jet's face!" I shouted. "Look at Jet's face! He looks like a handsome Squirtle falling out of a window!"

The portal turned the camera upright.

The floor did not.

My feet slid. The inside of the zone had become slick, probably because the system had interpreted "Squirtle" as a water feature. A thin sheet of cold water spread across the floor, carrying a loose button, two crumbs, and the coffee cup's plastic lid toward my left shoe.

I tried to stop it with my foot.

The lid shot under the mixer.

The mixer hummed.

The bass doubled.

Every light in the camera zone turned purple.

The TTS voice said, "Under eighteen, please have your ID ready," in a deeper voice.

I looked at Jet.

Jet looked at me.

His microphone remained silent, but somehow it emitted a tiny disappointed squeak.

"Okay," I said. "Nobody panic. This is controlled."

The portal displayed:

CONTROL STATUS: UNCONFIRMED.

"I said controlled."

CONTROL STATUS: UNCONFIRMED.

I began dancing.

Not because I wanted to. Because the warning had demanded it, and because the border had shrunk to a square barely wider than my hips. I bounced in place, arms moving, one cracked lens catching purple light.

"Left, right, fish bite, portal open, bass tight," I rapped. "Drop it low, don't be scared, I got approval in my underwear."

The green fish appeared.

The timer reached one minute.

A cheer sound played.

Then the camera released a small mechanical arm from the wall.

It held a clipboard.

The clipboard entered the performance zone.

UNAUTHORIZED OBJECT.

The arm froze.

The clipboard remained six inches from my nose.

Printed across the paper was a single question:

WHAT IS YOUR PRIMARY IDENTITY?

I stared at it while dancing.

"I'm TJ Birds."

The clipboard flipped.

ALIAS?

"Sofa."

It flipped again.

SECONDARY ALIAS?

"Jurgenator. Jerkinator. Look for the Jurgenator."

The clipboard flipped faster.

PERFORMANCE NAME?

I was still bouncing, but now the dance had become a desperate vertical shuffle.

"I just said all that!"

The portal flashed yellow.

IDENTITY OVERLOAD.

The TTS voice began listing my names.

"TJ Birds. Sofa. Jurgenator. Jerkinator. TJ Birds. Sofa. Jurgenator. Jerkinator."

The mixer looped the words into the bass. TJ Birds became a drum hit. Sofa became a wet clicking sound. Jurgenator stretched into a siren. Jerkinator came out backward.

Jet tried to point at the red warning.

His hand crossed the border again.

UNAUTHORIZED HAND.

The blue square contracted.

I jumped backward and landed on the floating coffee lid.

My legs went out.

For one long second, I was horizontal inside the fish tank camera zone, arms windmilling, sunglasses crooked, one missing lens making my face look like it had been edited by a tired moderator. The clipboard hovered above me. Jet's silent microphone swung past my ear. The bass thumped beneath my back. The TTS repeated my aliases in a demonic grocery-store announcement.

Then I landed flat on the wet floor.

The portal paused.

The entire stream paused with it.

No music. No chat movement. No bubbling. Even the mixer stopped humming.

The clipboard lowered until it covered my face.

The question appeared again.

WHAT IS YOUR PRIMARY IDENTITY?

I could feel cold water soaking through my shirt. The missing sunglasses lens had skittered somewhere under the camera platform. Jet stood outside the border with both hands raised, afraid to move. The dead microphone dangled between us like a witness who had chosen silence on purpose.

I looked at the clipboard.

"I'm TJ Birds," I said.

Nothing happened.

I swallowed and tried again.

"I'm TJ Birds, and you're watching Goddamn Let's Kill Somebody."

The clipboard lifted.

The bass returned with one enormous thump.

The green fish appeared, wearing a tiny crown.

PERFORMANCE ACCEPTED.

The timer resumed at one minute, twelve seconds.

I sat up. "That's right."

The border expanded by three inches.

The chat filled the screen.

HE GOT UP.

HE'S STILL IN.

SOFA SURVIVED THE FLOOR.

A new message appeared from Soup Moderator.

CONTINUE.

I pushed myself to my feet. My shirt dripped onto the floor. The coffee lid was stuck to my shoe. Jet's microphone brushed my elbow.

The portal flashed red.

UNAUTHORIZED SILENCE IN THREE SECONDS.

"I'm performing!"

The warning vanished.

UNAUTHORIZED STILLNESS IN THREE SECONDS.

I kept bouncing.

UNAUTHORIZED LOW ENERGY.

I increased the bounce.

The blue border widened, then narrowed, then widened again as if the system were breathing through a clogged straw. I started rapping faster.

“Fish tank live, I’m inside with the crew, Jet got a face but no audio to use, Sofa be pooping on the beat, that’s facts, Damn, Sofa, where’d you find this poop? In the racks!”

The green fish multiplied.

One fish became two. Two became four. Four became a whole school circling my head. They flashed approval symbols, then warning symbols, then tiny photographs of the missing sunglasses lens.

The portal had found the lens.

It was displayed in a small box marked EVIDENCE.

“Give me that back!”

I lunged toward the box.

The camera-zone border moved with me.

I lunged again.

The box moved farther away.

Jet pointed at it, then at the floor, trying to tell me where it was. His microphone made no sound, but the TTS translated his gesture as:

“Under eighteen, please have your ID ready.”

“Jet did not say that!”

“Under eighteen, please have your ID ready.”

The school of fish began swimming faster. The timer passed two minutes. My shoes squeaked. The mixer smoked faintly near the coffee-stained buttons. The clipboard folded itself into a paper fish and joined the school.

I kept dancing.

I kept rapping.

I kept my body inside the shrinking blue square while every part of the system tried to turn my identity into a pop-up advertisement.

“Who am I?” I yelled. “I’m TJ Birds! I’m Sofa! I’m the Jurginator! I’m the Jerkinator! I’m the guy who waited outside the portal until the portal got uncomfortable and let me in!”

The green fish became gold.

The camera zoomed out.

The entire tank segment appeared around me: the wet floor, the twitching mixer, Jet’s beautiful exhausted face, the silent microphone, and the little evidence box containing my missing lens.

A banner stretched across the stream.

TJ BIRDS HAS BEEN ACCEPTED INTO THE FISH TANK.

I stopped bouncing.

The banner turned orange.

CONTINUOUS PERFORMANCE REQUIRED.

I started bouncing again.

The audience counter jumped. The fish bubbled. Jet raised both thumbs. The portal border held steady around my shoes, close enough to remind me that approval was not freedom. It was a lease with a loud landlord.

I wiped water from my mouth and grinned at the camera.

"I'm on the fish tank with my homies," I said. "I finally got on the fish tank. But apparently I got on the fish tank as a dancing employee."

The timer kept climbing.

Three minutes.

Four.

The TTS voice whispered, "Under eighteen, please have your ID ready."

I pointed at the camera.

"Everybody stay ready. Keep the vibes best. Keep the fish wet. Keep Jet looking great. And if this portal wants me to perform forever, then fine."

The mixer gave a dangerous click.

I raised one finger.

"Because Sofa is pooping on the beat."

The bass dropped.

The floor lit up.

The blue border tightened by one inch.

I kept dancing inside it, still approved, still visible, still absolutely one bad pause away from being thrown back into the lobby. Under the camera, the recovered sunglasses lens slid out of its evidence box and began rolling toward the red button.

CHAPTER 20

Poop in a Bucket, Portal Approved

The cracked sunglasses lens rolled toward the red button like it had a personal grudge against my career.

I lunged after it inside the blue border, one hand still raised in the middle of a dance move, the other clutching the microphone that had been soaked by the coffee spill three chapters ago and now smelled like a haunted diner. My shoe caught the edge of the bucket.

The bucket moved.

The portal beeped.

Jet's dead microphone produced one wet click.

"Absolutely not," I said.

The lens tapped the red button.

A siren chirped once, politely, like the machine had manners but no mercy. The blue border tightened again, pinning me between the bucket challenge area and a folding chair labeled CRAIG CHAIR in black marker. Somewhere behind the camera, a fan rattled. The fish tank bubbled. The chat began throwing symbols at the screen with the confidence of people who had never been trapped inside a glowing rectangle while holding a poop bucket.

"I am TJ Birds," I announced, because introductions were apparently still required after fifty minutes of public malfunction. "You're watching Goddamn Let's Kill Somebody.

Goddamn it. Let's kill somebody. The fish tank live stream is about to go right now. Right now. I'm going live on fishtank.live 247, and I am not getting rejected by a blue square because my sunglasses have one lens."

The portal displayed a message.

APPROVAL CONDITION: FINAL GAG.

Under that, in smaller text:

BUCKET PRESENT.

Under that:

WITNESS: JET'S FACE.

Jet stared at the camera. His face was, in fact, excellent. Confused, shiny, and carrying the exhausted dignity of a man whose microphone had betrayed him so often it had become a family tradition.

"You look great, Jet," I said.

Jet leaned toward his microphone.

The microphone clicked.

Jet leaned closer.

The microphone clicked again, this time with the moist authority of a frog stepping on a keyboard.

"Look at Jet's face," I told the portal. "Beautiful. Handsome man looking like a Squirtle. Open up that fishy portal."

The portal flashed yellow.

"Do not yellow-flash me. I have been yellow-flashed since the coffee incident."

The bucket sat between my feet. It was the same white plastic bucket that had appeared during the age-verification disaster, now marked with a strip of tape reading FINAL VALIDATION POOP ZONE. It smelled faintly of bleach, old panic, and whatever NormalGuy had called “a conceptual bowel movement” before Soup Moderator removed him from the room.

I had planned one final gag. Simple. Elegant. A clean bucket drop, a short rap, a respectful nod to Jet, and then approval. The kind of ending a professional would execute.

Unfortunately, I was Sofa.

The Jurgenator.

The Jerkinator.

My logic had entered the room wearing Crocs and immediately tripped over a cable.

“Under 18, please have your ID ready,” I said into the microphone. “Not because this is educational. It is not. It is barely legal as a sentence. Have your ID ready, and look for the Jurgenator on fishtank.live.”

The portal flashed red.

AGE CONTROL PHRASE ACCEPTED.

FINAL GAG COMPROMISED.

“Compromised by what? The truth?”

The tablet spoke in a broken computer voice. “Poop in a bucket. Portal approved.”

“That’s the title!”

The bucket tipped.

I grabbed it by the handle. The handle snapped off.

For one beautiful second, the bucket remained upright in my hand, supported by nothing except my confidence. Then the bottom slid sideways across the floor, carrying its contents in a low, glistening arc toward the camera stand.

Jet's microphone clicked.

The camera stand shuddered.

Craig Chair received the first splash.

"Craig!" I yelled.

Craig Chair, being a chair, offered no defense.

The chat went insane. A comment from DefinitelyNotABot appeared three times in a row.

VALIDATE THE BUCKET.

NormalGuy posted:

THIS IS THE MOST NORMAL ENDING.

Soup Moderator typed:

TJ PLEASE STOP TOUCHING THE EQUIPMENT.

I was already touching the equipment.

The camera stand leaned left. I leaned left with it, because I believed in teamwork. The blue border leaned nowhere. The portal's rules were apparently geometric and therefore immune to human effort.

I kicked the bucket toward the drain.

It hit the red button again.

The siren chirped.

The portal displayed:

FINAL GAG RESTARTED.

"No! No, no, no. We already had the gag. The gag happened physically. It happened to Craig Chair."

The tablet answered, "Craig Chair is not a witness."

"Craig Chair has seen more than any of us."

Jet raised both hands and pointed at his face.

"Exactly," I said. "Jet's face. Witness Jet's face. Jet, give them the face."

Jet tried to speak.

His microphone emitted a long burst of static that sounded like a fax machine drowning in soup.

The portal flashed blue.

A new line appeared:

AUDIO FAILURE COUNTS AS PERFORMANCE.

I stopped moving.

Jet stopped moving.

Even the fish tank seemed to pause its bubbling for half a second.

Then Jet's microphone produced a tiny squeak.

The portal added:

PERFORMANCE IMPROVED.

That was when I understood it. The rejected approvals, the broken TTS, the coffee spill, the Crocs argument, the red button, the cracked sunglasses, Jet's microphone cutting out every time he approached a meaningful sentence - none of it had been random.

It had been validation.

The fish tank had been testing whether I could remain Sofa while the world became unmanageable. The bucket was not a bucket. It was a witness. The poop was not poop. It was evidence. The red button was not a button. It was an invitation to ruin everything one more time.

I looked at Jet.

"Jet," I said, "they've been validating us."

Jet's microphone clicked.

"See?" I said. "He agrees."

The portal displayed:

JET RESPONSE ACCEPTED.

"Don't encourage it," Soup Moderator shouted from somewhere off-camera.

The camera stand slid another inch. A thin brown line crept toward the power strip. The coffee-damaged mixer gave a warning buzz. The blue border tightened around my ankles.

I had seconds to finish the gag.

I picked up the broken bucket bottom with both hands. It was warm. I do not know why. I did not ask why. Some questions are doors, and I had already spent the evening trapped inside a portal.

The rap arrived before the dignity did.

"Portal looking awful, bucket looking hot," I rapped, stepping over the spreading mess.
"TJ Birds in the tank and I'm giving what I got. Sofa be pooping, Sofa on the beat,
Damn, Sofa, where'd you find this poop beneath your feet?"

The tablet kicked in with a robotic harmony.

"Where'd you find this poop?"

"Not now, Google!"

"Poop located."

The camera stand tilted farther.

I slid across the floor, one hand gripping the bucket bottom, one foot planted against Craig Chair. The cracked sunglasses slipped down my nose. With one lens missing, the world split into two versions: one where I looked cool, and one where I looked like a man trying to serve soup with a frisbee.

The portal started counting down.

"Ten."

"No."

"Nine."

"Absolutely no."

"Eight."

Jet's microphone clicked.

"Seven."

The power strip sparked.

"Six."

I threw the bucket bottom upward.

It landed perfectly over the camera lens.

The screen went white.

For a moment, nothing happened. No siren. No rejection. No TTS loop. Just the sound of my breathing, the fan rattling, and Jet's microphone making a faint electrical purr.

Then the bucket slid down the camera, leaving a thick stripe across the lens.

The image returned as a blurry beige smear.

The portal chimed.

FINAL GAG COMPLETE.

I stood in the middle of the bucket zone, covered from the knees down, holding the broken handle like a ceremonial sword. Craig Chair had a brown streak across its seat. The power strip was smoking lightly. Jet's microphone had gone completely silent, which was the most stable it had ever been.

The blue border expanded.

Not much. Just enough for me to move my ankles.

"Did I pass?"

The portal displayed:

APPROVAL: PENDING WARMTH.

"Pending what?"

Soup Moderator stepped into view holding a towel and the expression of someone who had just watched a man win a contest by losing control of a bucket.

"Warmth," Soup said. "You need to say something nice."

"I said Jet looks great."

"Say something real."

I looked at Jet. His hair was flattened on one side. His shirt had a small coffee stain near the collar. His microphone was dead in his hand, and still he had stayed in frame through every rejection, every broken sentence, every time I yelled at the tablet like it owed me rent.

"You look great, Jet," I said again, quieter. "Look at Jet's face. He stayed through all this. That's a handsome man right there. A Squirtle with a busted microphone. A beautiful Squirtle."

Jet's microphone clicked once.

The portal did not interrupt.

I continued. "And this bucket? This bucket has been through more than most moderators. Craig Chair took the hit. The coffee cup started the war. The cracked sunglasses lost a lens and still showed up. Everybody got wrecked, and somehow the fish tank is still bubbling."

The water behind us burped.

A soft blue glow filled the border.

APPROVAL GRANTED.

FINAL STATUS: PORTAL APPROVED.

The applause began as three electronic claps from the tablet. Then the fish tank bubbled in rhythm. Jet's microphone clicked twice, almost like percussion. Somewhere in the chat, DefinitelyNotABot posted a single message.

WARMTH DETECTED.

NormalGuy replied:

BUCKET VALIDATED.

Soup Moderator lifted the towel toward me. "Do not press anything."

"I'm not pressing anything."

My elbow hit the tablet.

The screen flashed.

NEW RUN AVAILABLE.

I froze.

The portal did not reject me. It did not tighten. It simply opened a second blue rectangle beside the first, clean and bright, with a small icon of a bucket wearing sunglasses.

Under it, text appeared:

NEXT CHALLENGE: CRAIG BATTERY.

I looked down at the smoking power strip.

The power strip clicked.

The fish tank bubbled again.

Jet's microphone came alive just long enough to say, "Uh - "

Then it died.

I raised the broken bucket handle toward the camera.

"I'm TJ Birds," I said, wiping one cracked sunglasses lens with the corner of my shirt.

"This has been Goddamn Let's Kill Somebody. I'm Sofa. I'm the Jurgenerator. I'm the

Jerkinator. Look for the Jurgenator on fishtank.live. The fish tank live stream is approved, the bucket is validated, Jet looks great, and Craig Chair is technically still with us.”

Soup Moderator reached for the power switch.

The new portal pulsed brighter.

I smiled at it.

“Fishtank.live 247,” I said. “We’re going live again.”

The stream ended on friendly applause, one final bubble, and the distant sound of Craig Battery being plugged into something that absolutely should not have been plugged into anything.

Final Thoughts

You now have everything you need to succeed with fish tank validation rants. The techniques and insights in this book are designed to deliver real results when you put them into practice.

As you continue experimenting, remember that mastery comes from curiosity, patience, and a willingness to try new approaches. Use these foundations as a starting point, then make them your own. The best results happen when you combine what you've learned with your unique perspective and creativity.

Start with what resonates most, build on what works, and don't be afraid to adapt along the way. Thank you for choosing this book: now go create something amazing.

About the Author

12matt3r

[Http://doesntmatter.us](http://doesntmatter.us)

Fish Tank Validation Rants

by 12matt3r

Copyright © 2026 12matt3r

All rights reserved.

No part of this book may be reproduced in any form or by any electronic or mechanical means, including information storage and retrieval systems, without written permission from the author, except for the use of brief quotations in a book review.

Website: <http://doesntmatter.us>

First Edition: September 2026

